HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University

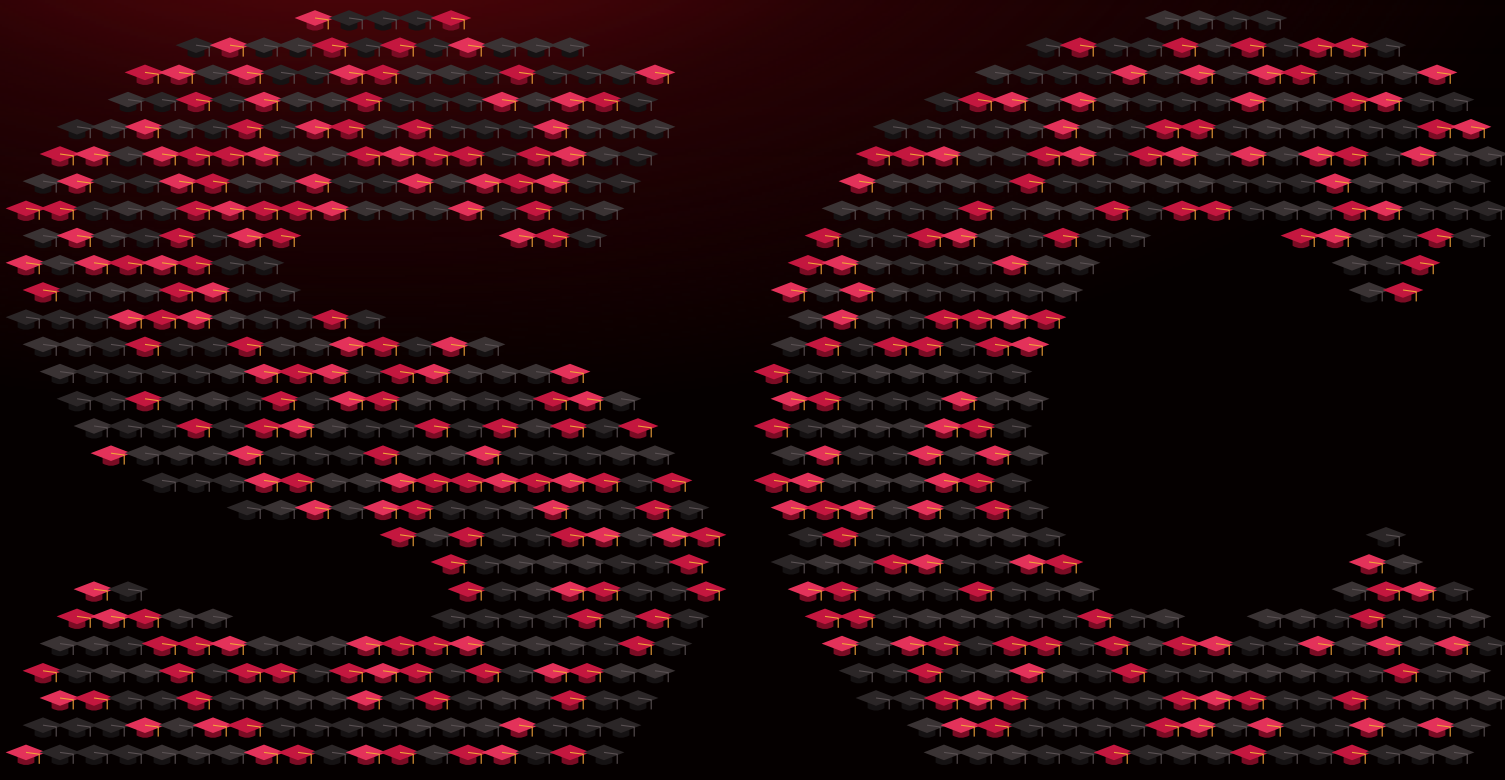
Stanford University
Human-Centered
Artificial Intelligence

NOVEMBER 2026

The 2026 South Carolina Talent Profile

Emerson Johnston
Amy Zegart

The bright caps, **39 in every 100**, mark the international share of South Carolina's STEM master's degrees.



This page intentionally left blank.

HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University

HAI Stanford University Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence

The 2026 South Carolina Talent Profile

By Emerson Johnston and Amy Zegart

NOVEMBER 2026

A publication jointly produced by the Hoover Institution and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University.

Table of Contents

OVERVIEW

At a Glance 6

SECTIONS

Section 1 International Dependence 8
Section 2 STEM Degrees 18
Section 3 Where Students Come From 24
Section 4 K-12 Preparation 30
Section 5 Graduate Research 32
Section 6 Do Graduates Stay? 34
Section 7 Research Funding 36
Section 8 H-1B Jobs and Green Cards 38
Section 9 STEM Workforce 42
Section 10 Patents 44
Section 11 Competitors 46
Section 12 Fields of Study 48
Section 13 Students and Money 58
Section 14 Student Outcomes 66
Section 15 Faculty 70
Section 16 Institutions 74

BACK MATTER

About these Data 78
By the Numbers 80
Sources 89

Authors

Emerson Victoria Johnston is a research assistant with the Hoover Institution's Technology Policy Accelerator. A Knight-Hennessy Scholar, she holds a master's in international policy from Stanford University, and is on leave from its master's program in the history of science, technology, environment, and medicine.

Dr. Amy Zegart is the Morris Arnold and Nona Jean Cox Senior Fellow at the Hoover Institution, director of Hoover's Technology Policy Accelerator, and a senior fellow and associate director at Stanford University's Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence.

Data come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), the Department of Homeland Security's SEVIS by the Numbers, the National Assessment of Educational Progress, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates and Survey of Earned Doctorates, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and USPTO patent data via PatentsView, processed in Python; every figure and table is generated from those sources, and each one names its source.

About This Profile

This profile is a companion to *The 2026 US Talent Report: Benchmarking America's STEM Pipeline Amid the Great Talent Competition*. It applies the report's measures to South Carolina: the students the state develops at home, those it draws from abroad, and how both compare with the nation and with the states closest to it in size.

Degrees, enrollment, prices, outcomes and faculty come from IPEDS, the federal census of U.S. colleges and universities, harmonized across 1980–2025. Countries of citizenship come from SEVIS by the Numbers, the Department of Homeland Security's monthly count of active F-1 and M-1 students. Each figure names its source. Peer states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

How to Cite this Profile

Emerson V. Johnston and Amy Zegart, “The 2026 South Carolina Talent Profile,” Technology Policy Accelerator, Hoover Institution, and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence, Stanford University, Stanford, CA, November 2026.

Public Data and Tools

The data behind every chart come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), published by the National Center for Education Statistics, and from SEVIS by the Numbers, published by the Department of Homeland Security's Student and Exchange Visitor Program. An interactive version of this profile accompanies the report.

To share any charts and figures, proper attribution is required. This profile is licensed under Attribution-NoDerivatives 4.0 International (CC BY-ND 4.0). Please cite as: The 2026 South Carolina Talent Profile.

AT A GLANCE

What South Carolina's numbers say

1. **International students earn 39% of South Carolina's STEM master's degrees,** 13.3 points below the U.S. (52%) in 2025, ranking 32nd of 51 on dependence. The share is 41% for STEM research doctorates (U.S. 43%) and 1.9% for STEM bachelor's (U.S. 6.6%).
2. **South Carolina awarded 462 STEM master's degrees to international students in 2025,** 0.4% of the U.S. total and 35th of 51 among states. Since 2015 the count changed +53%, against 2.2× nationally.
3. **The heaviest dependence is in computer & info sciences,** where international students earned 66% of master's degrees (195 degrees; U.S. 65%). 2 STEM fields with at least 50 master's graduates are majority-international.
4. **Among states of similar size,** South Carolina ranks 3rd of 5 on the international share of STEM master's: South Carolina 39%, Louisiana 33%, New Hampshire 35%, Kentucky 75%, Alabama 43%.
5. **72% of South Carolina's first-time students in fall 2024 were state residents** and 1.3% came from abroad. More students arrived from other states (12.8K) than residents left (7.16K), a net gain of 5.63K; the top destination for those leaving was North Carolina.

39%

of the STEM master's degrees South Carolina awards go to international students (U.S. 52%).

SCORECARD

Nine numbers against the nation

256K #26
Students enrolled, 2024
U.S. **19.7M** · +2.4% since 2015

462 #35
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · +53% since 2015

39% #32
International share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · +4.9 pp since 2015

10% #35
International share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · +0.1 pp since 2015

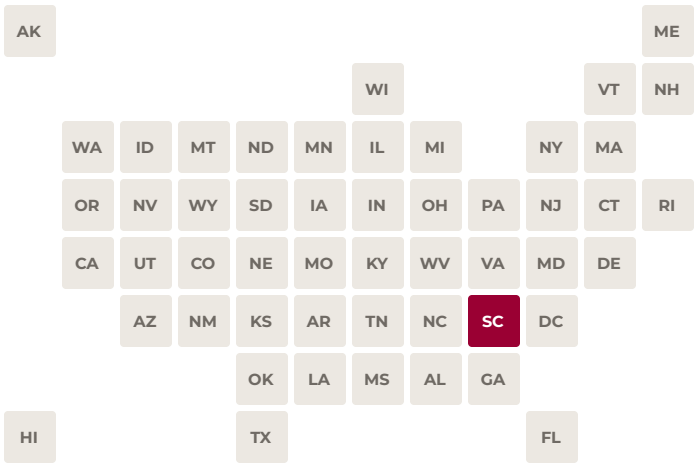
23% #26
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · +2.9 pp since 2015

62% #24
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · +5.8 pp since 2015

$9.11K #38
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · +71% since 2015

72% #27
First-time students from in state, 2024
U.S. **–** · −4.1 pp since 2016

$83.9K #40
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · −7.5% since 2016

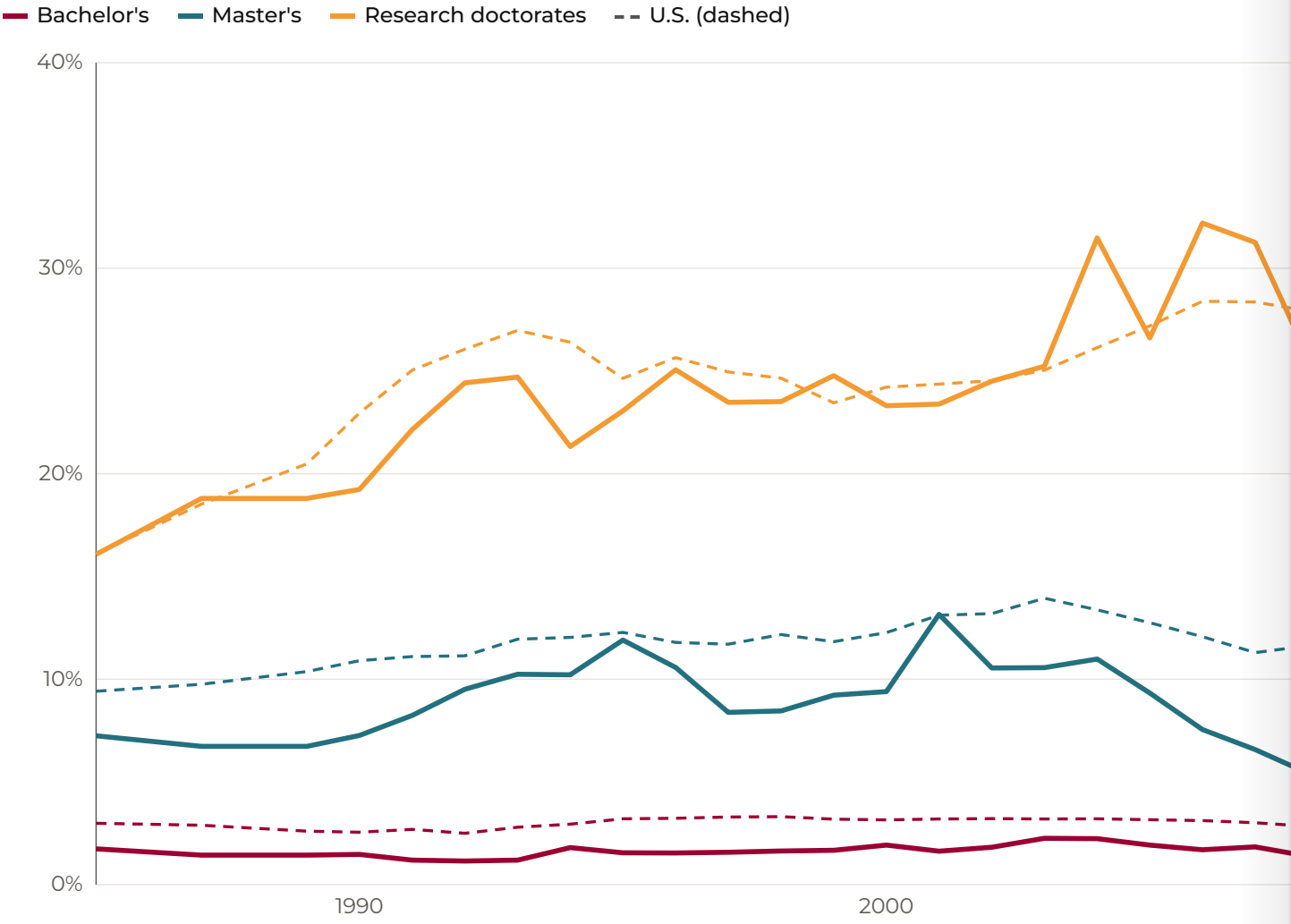


Badges give South Carolina's rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Changes are since 2015.

SECTION 1

International Dependence

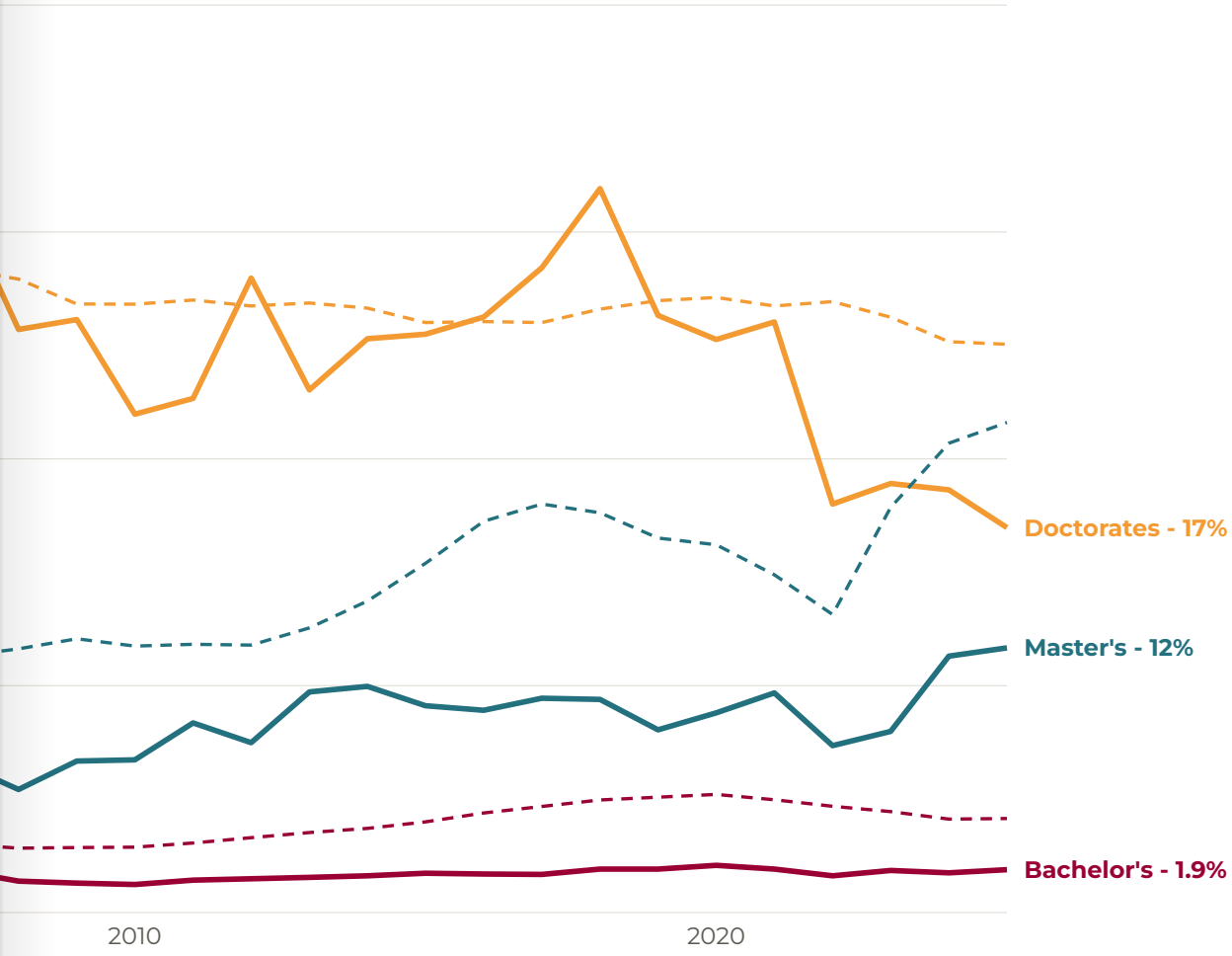
Figure 1 What Share of South Carolina's Degrees Go to International Students?



International share of degrees awarded, all fields; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions, 1985–2025

International students make up 10% of South Carolina's graduate enrollment and 1.2% of its undergraduates. Dependence climbs with each degree: 1.9% of bachelor's, 12% of master's and 17% of research doctorates go to international students.

In STEM the shares are higher still: 1.9% of STEM bachelor's, 39% of STEM master's and 41% of STEM doctorates. The state awards 0.4% of all U.S. international STEM master's, 35th of 51.



5.

10%

Int. share of grad students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **35th** of 51 · +0.1 pp since 2015

12%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

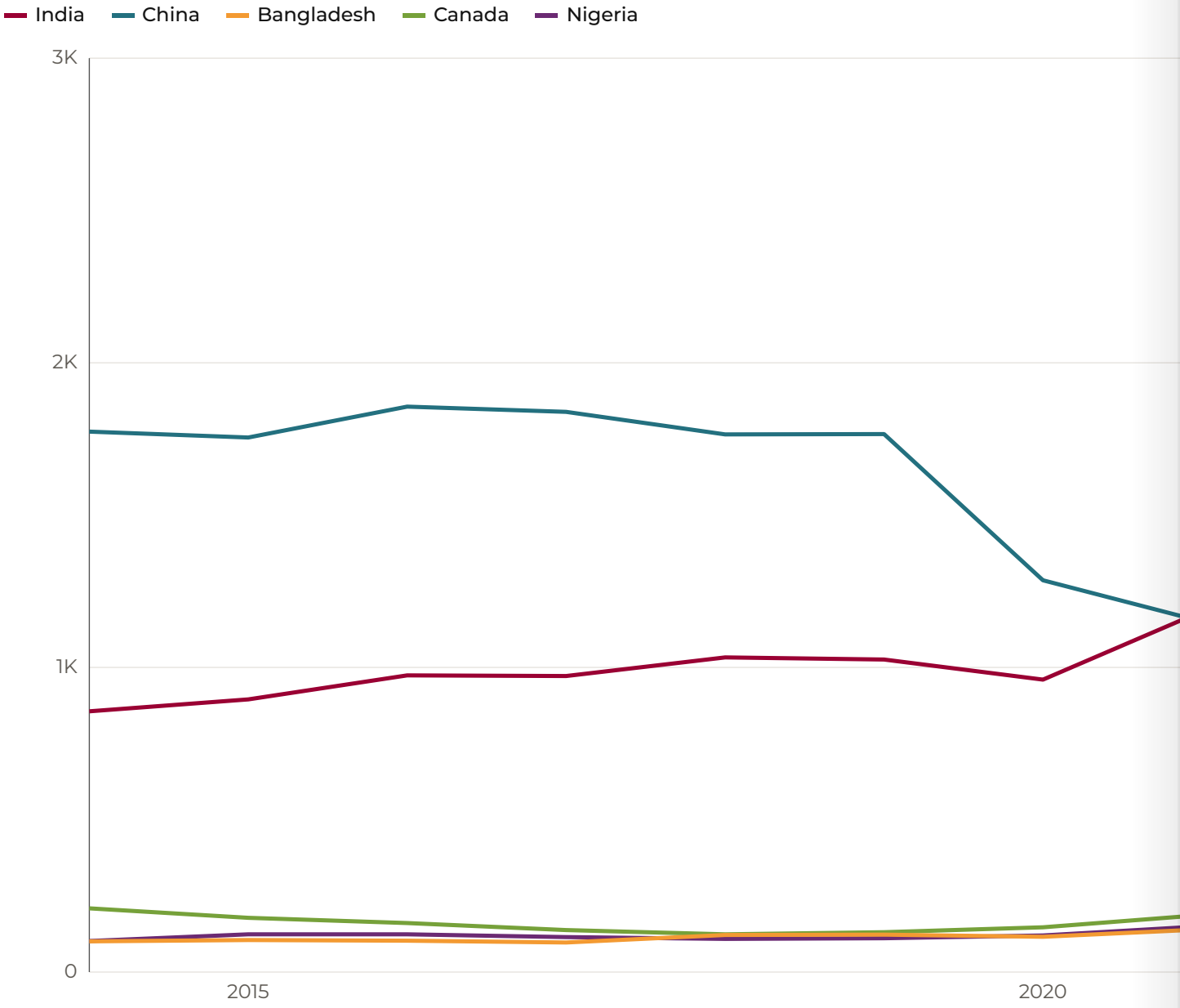
U.S. **22%** · **34th** of 51 · +2.6 pp since 2015

39%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **32nd** of 51 · +4.9 pp since 2015

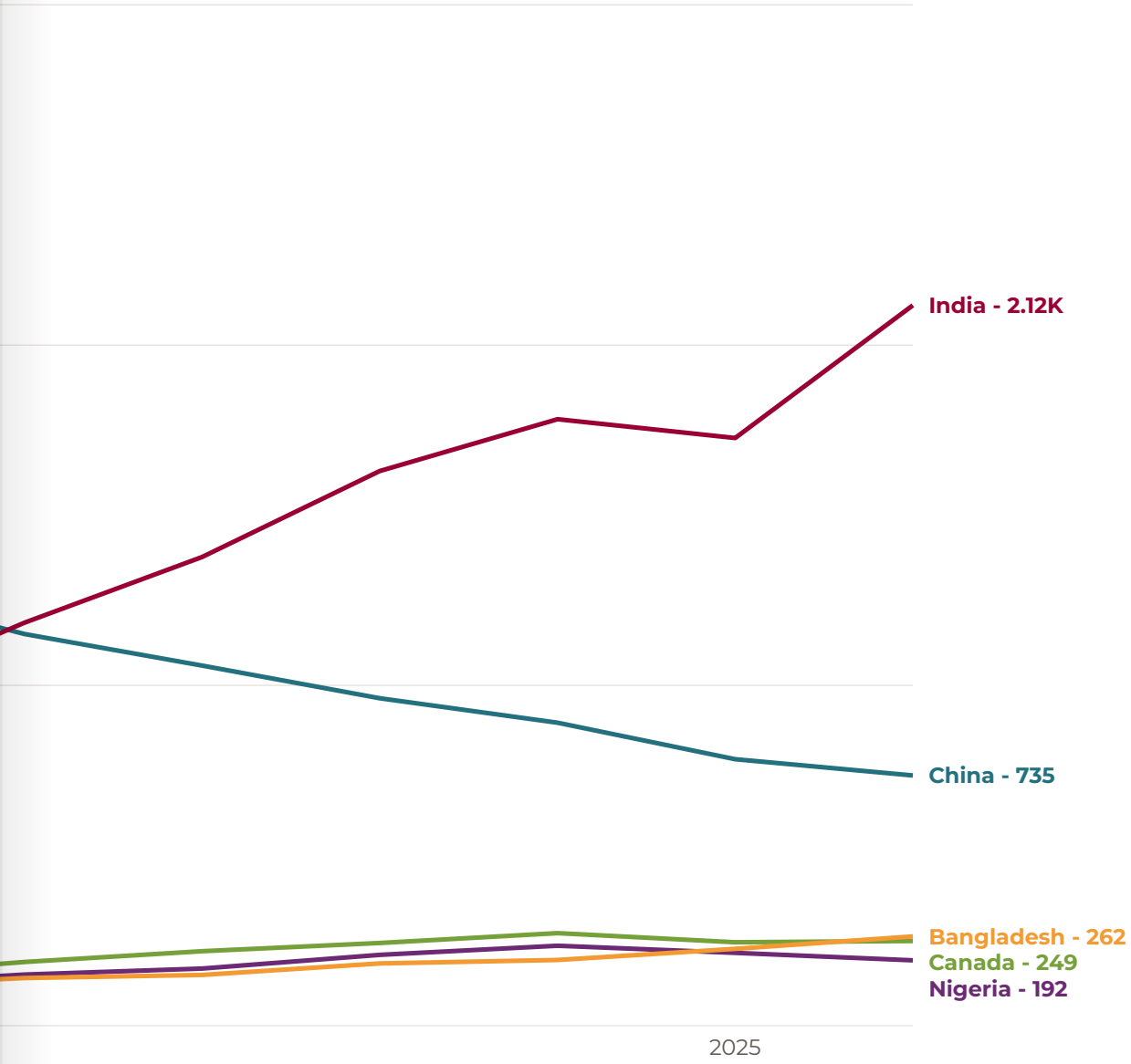
Figure 2 Where Do South Carolina's International Students Come From?



Active F-1 and M-1 students by country of citizenship, the five largest in October 2026; one snapshot per year (the latest m

In October 2026, South Carolina had 7.28K active international students in SEVIS, 34th of 51. India accounted for 29% of them and China for 10%, against 27% and 18% nationally.

Students came from 158 countries, but the two largest supplied 39%. The state's total is up 16% since 2014.



onth available), October 2014–October 2026. All education levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

7.28K

Active international students, October 2026

34th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

29%

From India

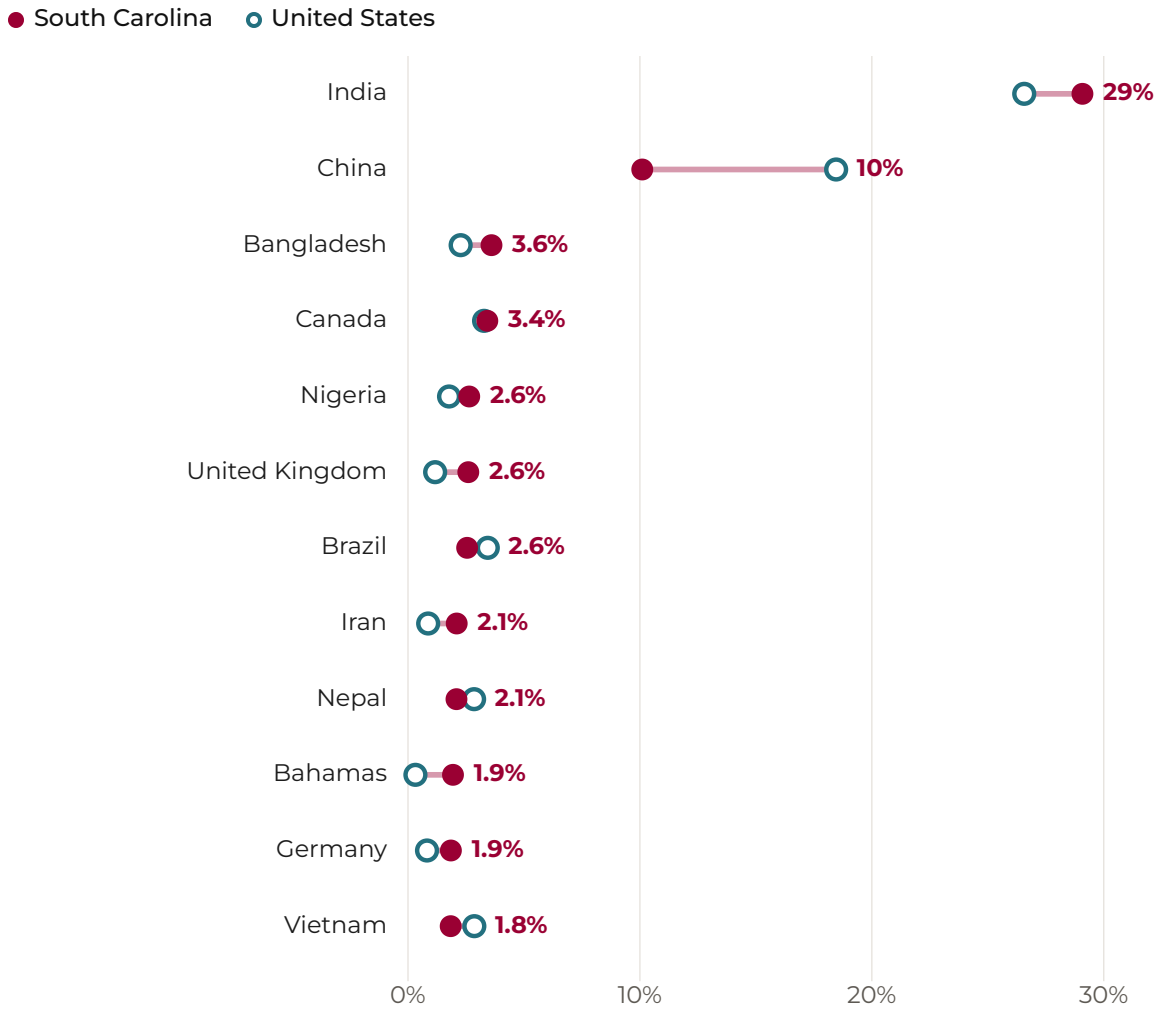
U.S. **27%**

53%

In STEM fields

U.S. **63%**

Figure 3 Is South Carolina's Mix of Countries Like the Nation's?



Share of active F-1 and M-1 students, all levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

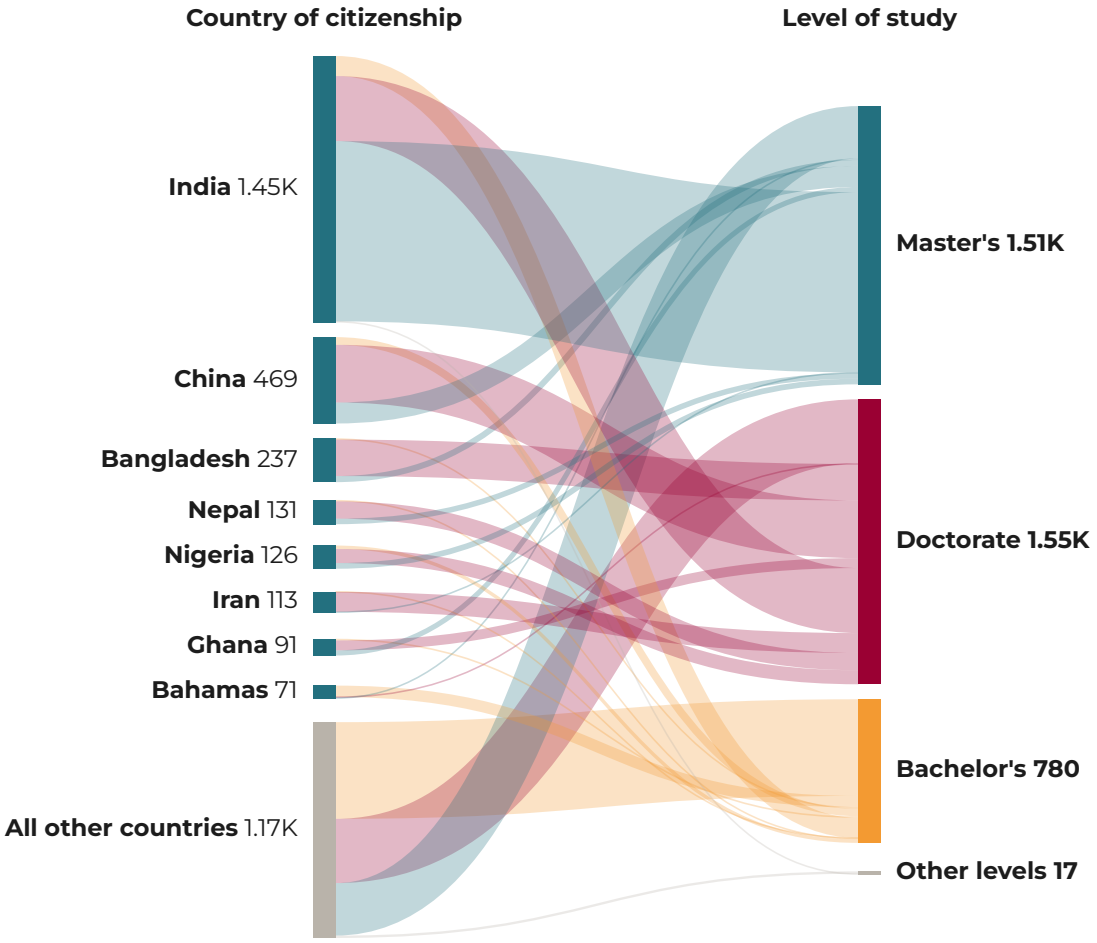
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each row is one of the 12 countries with the most active F-1 and M-1 student records in South Carolina in October 2026. The filled dot is the country's share of the state's international students; the open dot is its share of all international students in the United States. Students at every level, from secondary school to doctorate, are counted. Yearly counts are the latest month available in each year.

THE NUMBERS

- **All active international students**: 7.28K in October 2026, 34th of 51 states (U.S. 1.19M), up 7.1% from 6.8K in 2025, and up 16% since 2015 (6.28K).
- **India**: 29% of the state's international students (U.S. 27%); 2.12K students in 2026, up 23% from 1.73K in 2025, and up 137% since 2015 (895).
- **China**: 10% of the state's international students (U.S. 18%); 735 students in 2026, down 6.1% from 783 in 2025, and down 58% since 2015 (1.75K).
- **Bangladesh**: 3.6% of the state's international students (U.S. 2.3%); 262 students in 2026, up 16% from 226 in 2025, and up 150% since 2015 (105).

Figure 4 Which Countries Supply South Carolina's International STEM Students?



Active F-1 and M-1 students in STEM fields by country of citizenship and level, October 2026; the eight largest countries. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

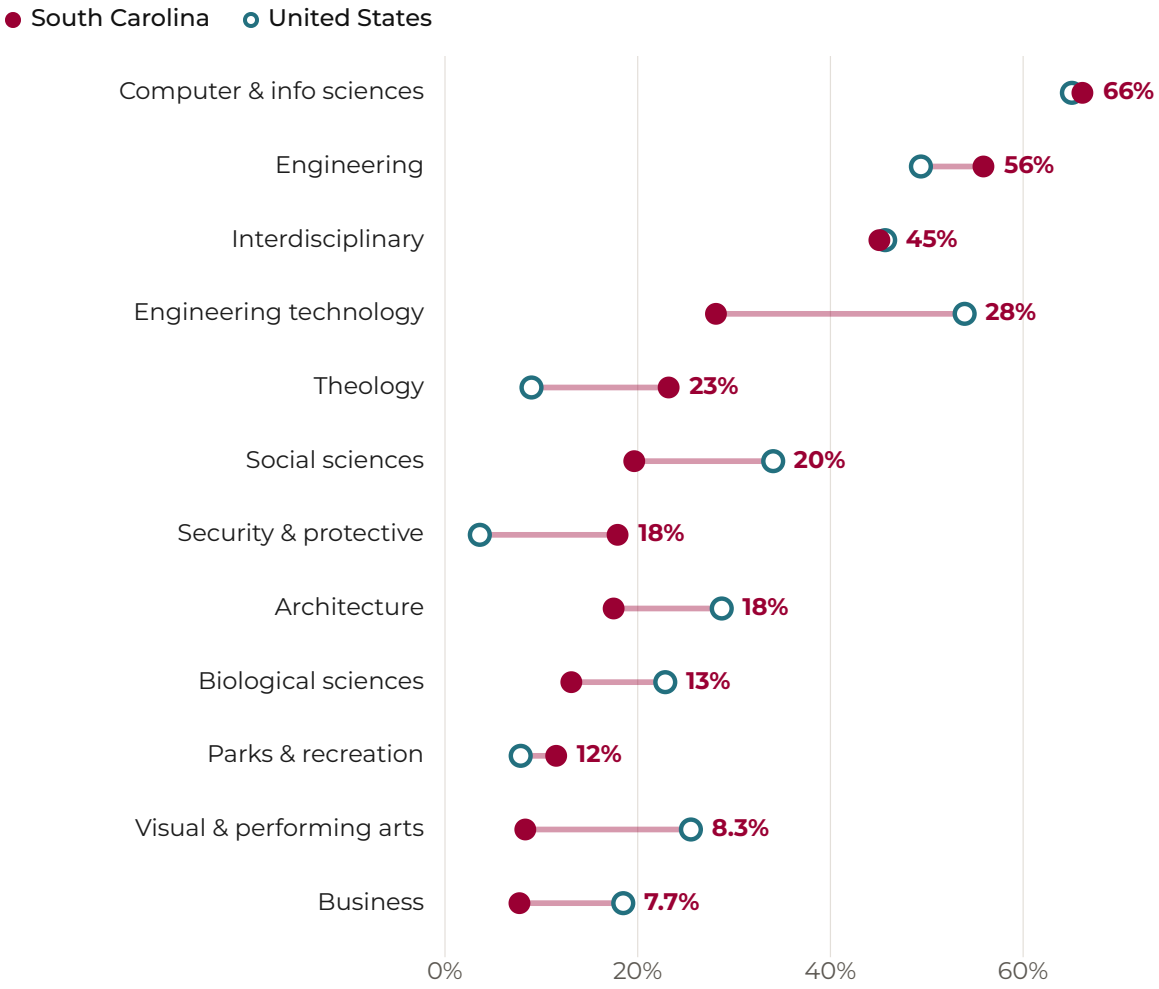
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each band runs from a country of citizenship on the left to a level of study on the right, for international students enrolled in STEM fields in October 2026. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. The eight largest countries are shown and the rest are grouped as all other countries.

THE NUMBERS

- **Share of international students in STEM fields**: 53% in October 2026 (U.S. 63%).
- **Master's level**: 1.51K students; largest countries India (979), China (114), Bangladesh (33).
- **Doctorate level**: 1.55K students; largest countries India (353), China (313), Bangladesh (198).
- **Bachelor's level**: 780 students; largest countries India (109), Bahamas (62), Saudi Arabia (44).
- **Active STEM students**: 3.85K in 2026 (U.S. 749K; 32nd of 51 states), down 1.5% from 3.91K in 2025, and up 41% since 2015 (2.73K).
- **Share of STEM master's students from India**: 65% in 2026 (U.S. 58%; 16th of 51 states), down 3.3 points from 68% in 2025, and up 4.2 points since 2015 (61%).

Figure 5 Which Master's Fields Depend Most on International Students?



International share of master's degrees by field, 2025; fields with 30+ graduates. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each row is a master's field with at least 30 graduates in South Carolina in 2025, ranked by the share of degrees earned by international students (U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas). The filled dot is the state's share; the open dot is the national share for the same field.

THE NUMBERS

- **Highest international shares**: computer & info sciences 66% (U.S. 65%); engineering 56% (U.S. 49%); interdisciplinary 45% (U.S. 46%).
- **All master's degrees**: 12% in 2025 (U.S. 22%; 34th of 51 states), up 0.4 points from 11% in 2024, and up 2.6 points since 2015 (9.1%).
- **STEM master's degrees**: 39% in 2025 (U.S. 52%; 32nd of 51 states), up 0.6 points from 38% in 2024, and up 4.9 points since 2015 (34%).
- **Computer and information sciences master's**: 66% in 2025 (U.S. 65%; 21st of 47 states), down 3.5 points from 70% in 2024, and up 15.5 points since 2015 (51%).

Table 1 How International Is Each STEM Field?

Field	Bachelor's	Master's	Doctorates
Computer & info sciences	3.2% / 8.6%	**66% / 65%**	50% / 56%
Engineering	1.5% / 7.2%	**56% / 49%**	54% / 55%
Engineering technology	2.5% / 4.5%	**28% / 54%**	– / 42%
Math & statistics	3.4% / 17%	**21% / 55%**	36% / 53%
Physical sciences	2.7% / 6.0%	**25% / 33%**	48% / 38%
Biological sciences	1.4% / 3.4%	**13% / 23%**	16% / 23%
Natural resources	0.0% / 2.0%	**5.1% / 17%**	– / 27%
Architecture	0.5% / 7.3%	**18% / 29%**	– / 55%

International share in South Carolina / U.S., 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

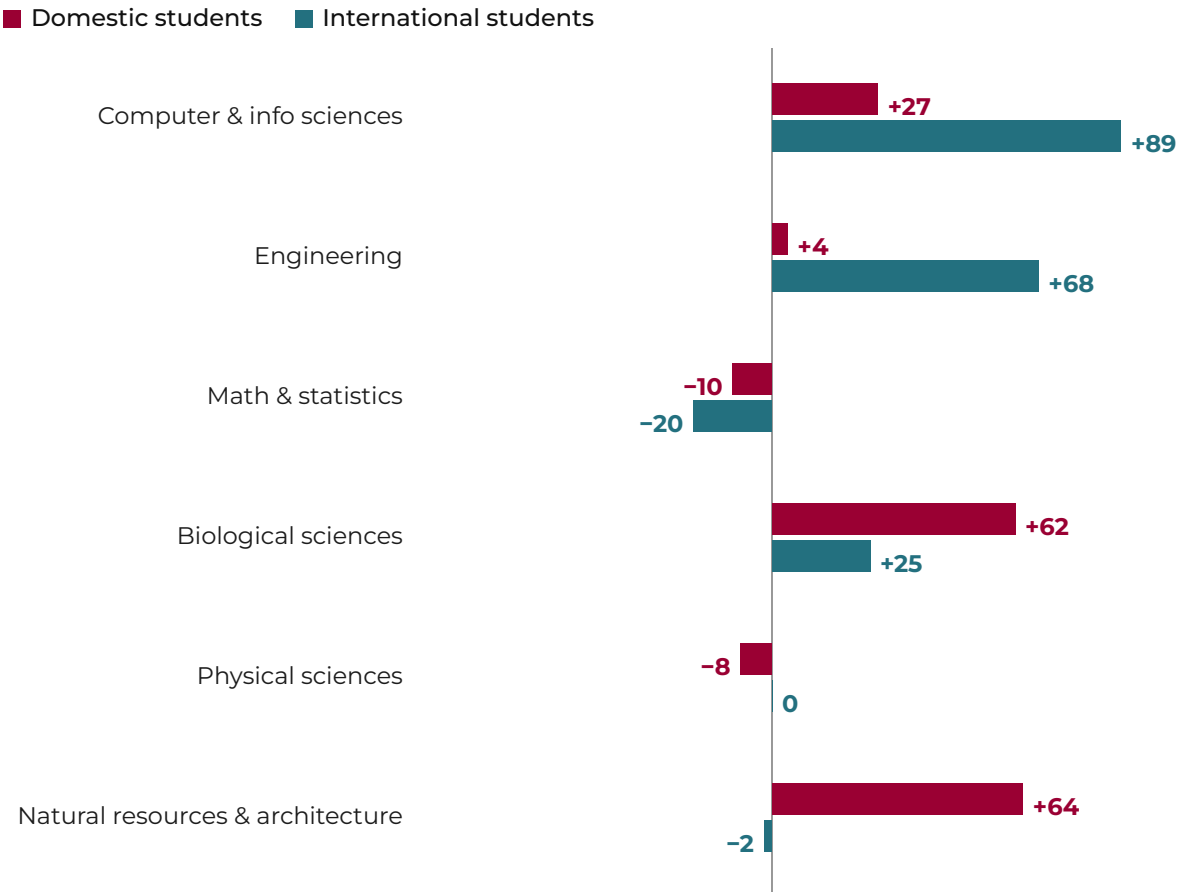
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The table gives the international share of degrees in each STEM field at three levels: South Carolina first, the United States after the slash. The master's column is highlighted. A dash means the state awarded no degrees in the field at that level.

THE NUMBERS

- **Highest international share among STEM master's fields**: computer & info sciences, 66% (U.S. 65%).
- **STEM fields where international students earn a majority of master's degrees**: 2.
- **International share of STEM bachelor's**: 1.9% in 2025 (U.S. 6.6%; 49th of 51 states), down 0.1 points from 2.0% in 2024, and down 0.1 points since 2015 (2.0%).
- **International share of STEM master's**: 39% in 2025 (U.S. 52%; 32nd of 51 states), up 0.6 points from 38% in 2024, and up 4.9 points since 2015 (34%).
- **International share of STEM research doctorates**: 41% in 2025 (U.S. 43%; 27th of 51 states), down 2.7 points from 43% in 2024, and down 6.3 points since 2015 (47%).

Figure 6 Where Did the STEM Master's Growth Come From?



Change in STEM master's degrees by field, 2015–2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each pair of bars is the change in the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in South Carolina between 2015 and 2025 in one field: to domestic students (U.S. citizens and permanent residents) and to international students. Bars to the left of the axis are declines.

THE NUMBERS

- **STEM master's degrees**: 1.19K in 2025, against 892 in 2015: +160 for international students and +139 for domestic students.
- **Computer & info sciences**: +27 for domestic students and +89 for international students.
- **Engineering**: +4 for domestic students and +68 for international students.
- **Math & statistics**: −10 for domestic students and −20 for international students.
- **International students' STEM master's degrees**: 462 in 2025 (U.S. 117K; 35th of 51 states), down 1.3% from 468 in 2024, and up 53% since 2015 (302).

Table 2 How Many STEM Master's Degrees Does Each Field Award?

Field	2015	2025	Change	International 2025	Int. share 2015	Int. share 2025
Computer & info sciences	79	**195**	+147%	129	51%	66%
Engineering	434	**506**	+17%	265	45%	52%
Math & statistics	59	**29**	−51%	6	44%	21%
Biological sciences	180	**267**	+48%	35	5.6%	13%
Physical sciences	44	**36**	−18%	9	20%	25%
Natural resources & architecture	96	**158**	+65%	18	21%	11%

STEM master's degrees awarded in South Carolina, all students and international students, 2015 and 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The table gives the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in South Carolina in each field in 2015 and 2025, the change between the two years, the number awarded to international students in 2025, and international students' share of the field's degrees in each year.

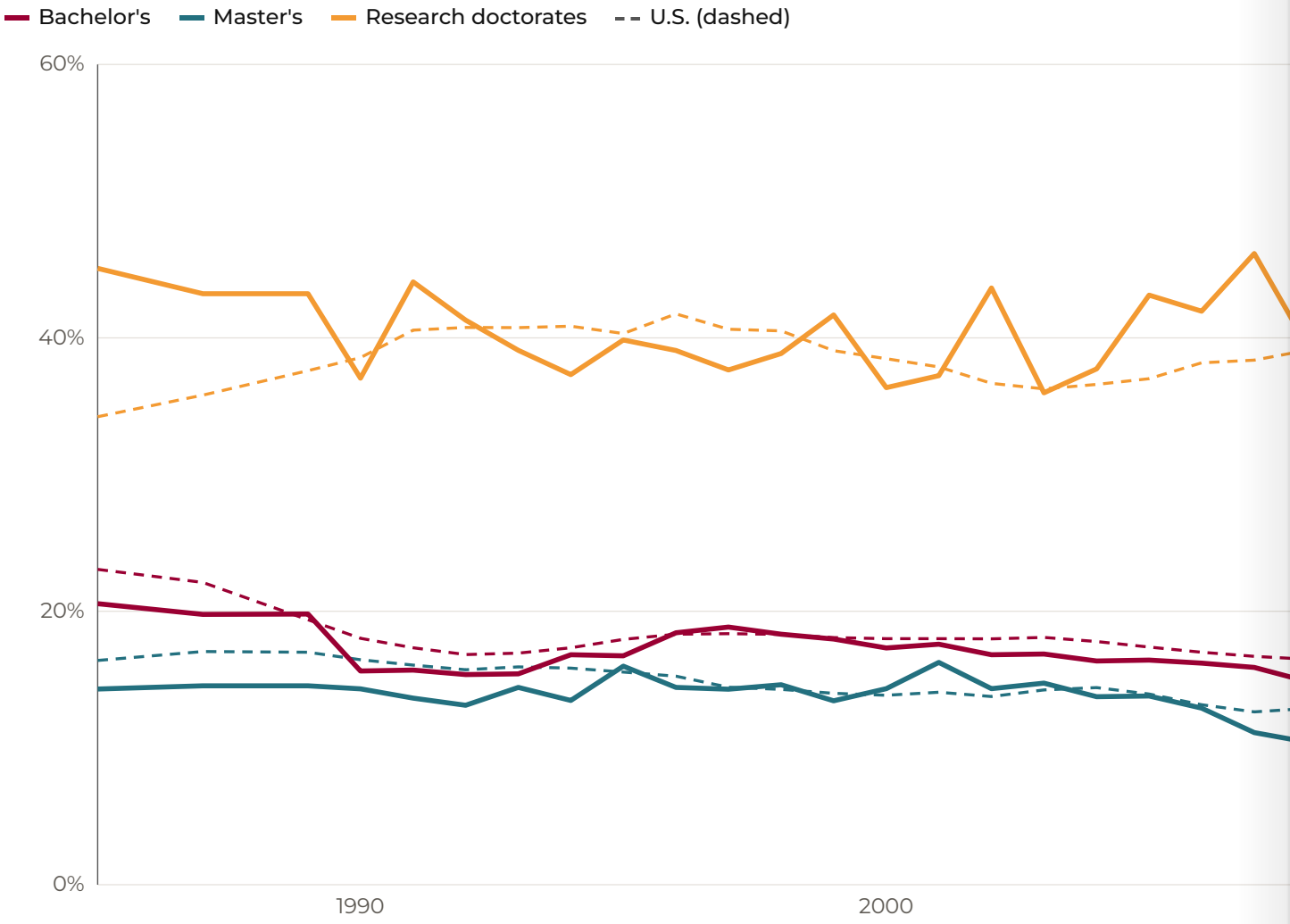
THE NUMBERS

- **STEM share of master's degrees**: 16% in 2025 (U.S. 23%; 40th of 51 states), down 0.3 points from 16% in 2024, and up 0.8 points since 2015 (15%).
- **Share of all U.S. international STEM master's**: 0.4% in 2025 (35th of 51 states), unchanged from 0.4% in 2024, and down 0.2 points since 2015 (0.6%).
- **STEM master's degrees per research doctorate**: 3.8 in 2025 (U.S. 6.4; 39th of 51 states), up 0.4 from 3.3 in 2024, and up 1.3 since 2015 (2.5).

SECTION 2

STEM Degrees

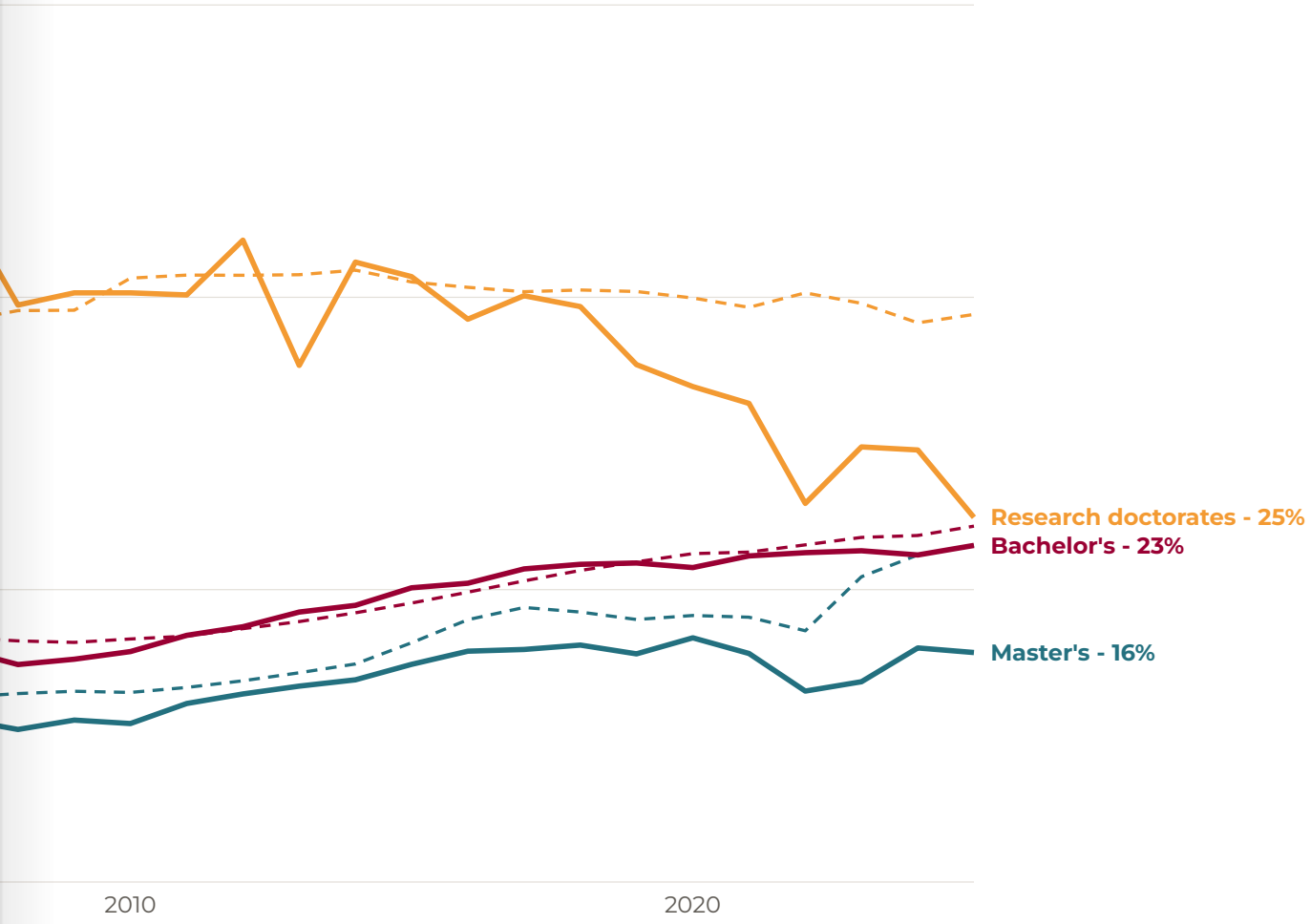
Figure 7 How Much of South Carolina's Degree Output Is STEM?



STEM share of degrees by level; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

STEM fields account for 23% of South Carolina's bachelor's degrees, 16% of its master's and 25% of its research doctorates (U.S. 24%, 23% and 39%).

The STEM share of master's degrees is up 0.8 points since 2015, and the state ranks 40th of 51 on it. On the STEM share of bachelor's degrees it ranks 26th of 51.



23%

STEM share of bachelor's, 2025

U.S. **24%** · **26th** of 51 · +2.9 pp since 2015

16%

STEM share of master's, 2025

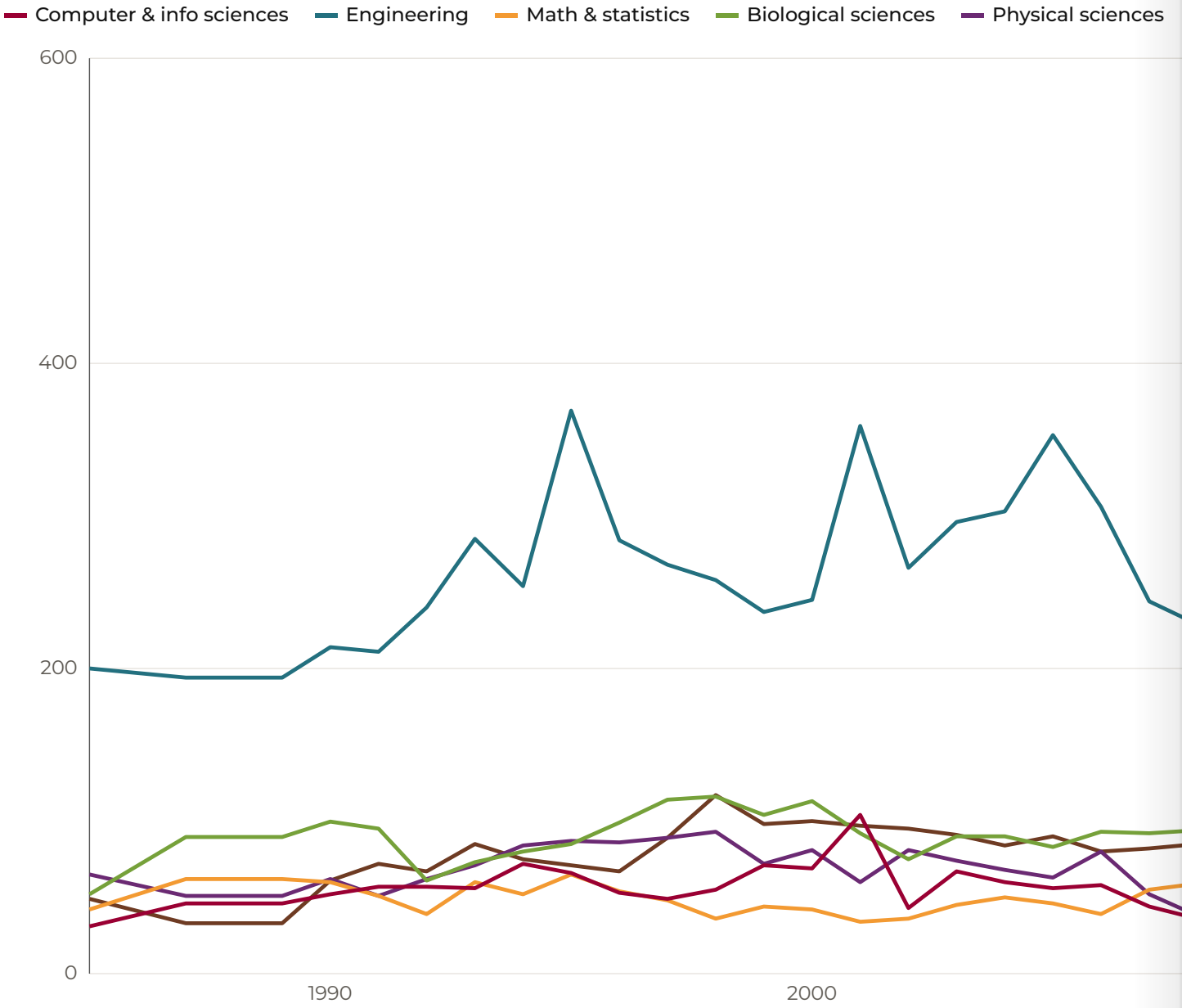
U.S. **23%** · **40th** of 51 · +0.8 pp since 2015

25%

STEM share of research doctorates, 2025

U.S. **39%** · **46th** of 51 · −16.5 pp since 2015

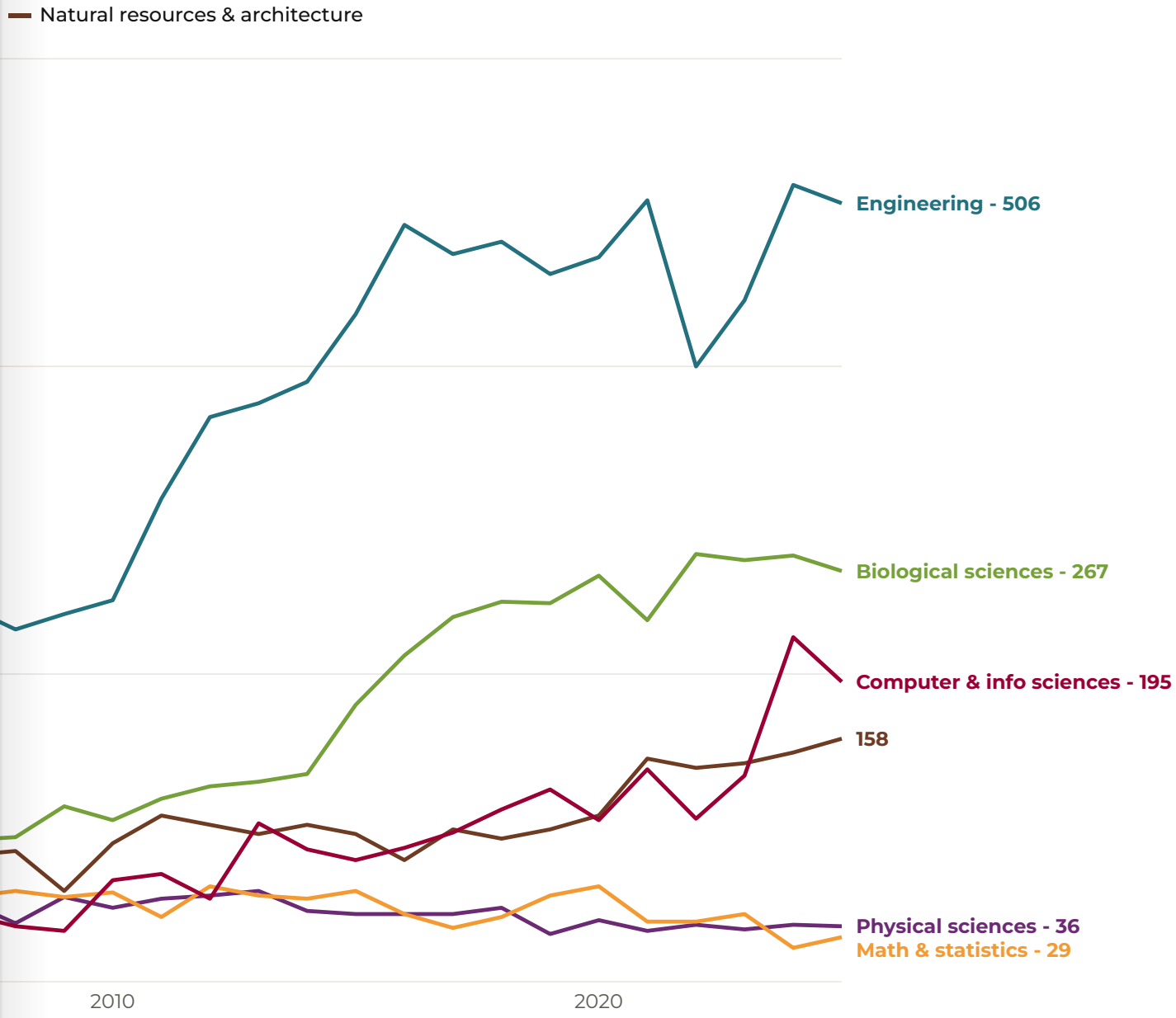
Figure 8 Which STEM Fields Produce South Carolina's Master's Degrees?



STEM master's degrees by field, all students. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Engineering produced the most STEM master's degrees in 2025, 506, followed by biological sciences (267) and computer & info sciences (195). Master's degrees in engineering are up 17% since 2015.

International students earned 462 of the state's STEM master's degrees in 2025, 0.4% of the national total (35th of 51).



462

International STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **117K** · **35th** of 51 · +53% since 2015

0.4%

Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025

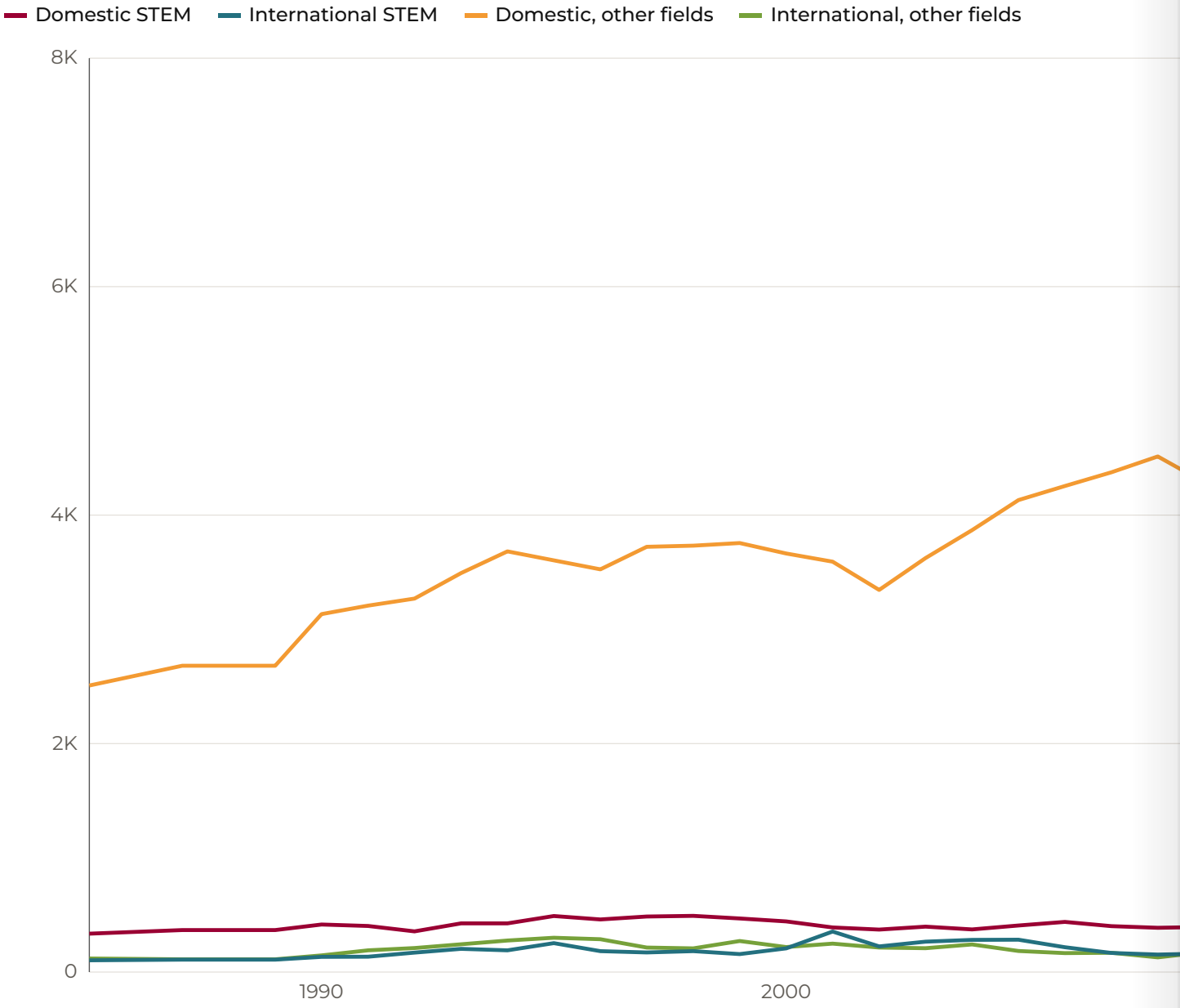
U.S. **100%** · **35th** of 51 · −0.2 pp since 2015

66%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

U.S. **65%** · **21st** of 47 · +15.5 pp since 2015

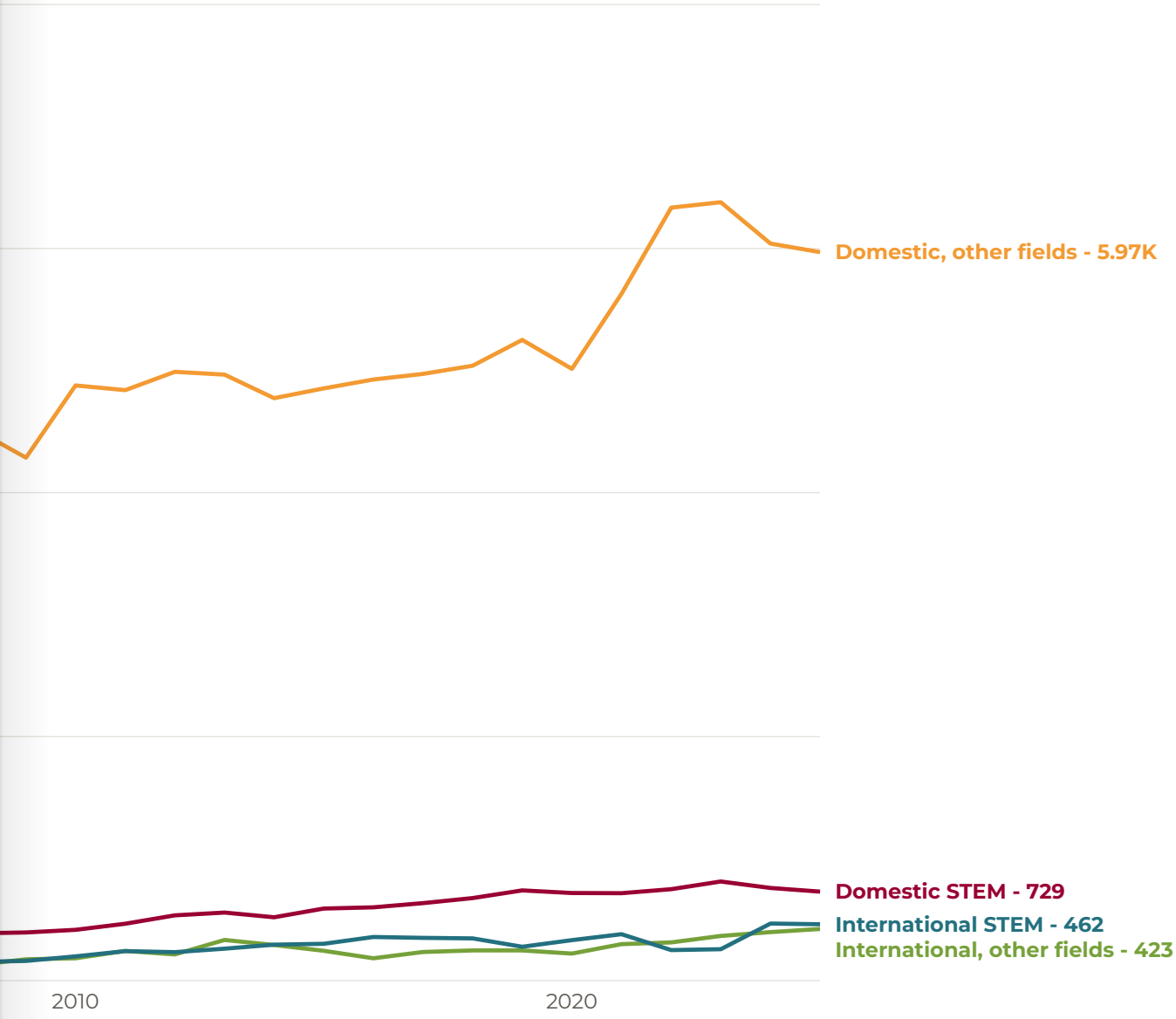
Figure 9 Who Earns South Carolina's Master's Degrees?



Master's degrees by student residency and field group. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Between 2015 and 2025, 160 more STEM master's degrees went to international students and 139 more to domestic students.

International students earn 39% of South Carolina's STEM master's but 6.6% of master's in other fields (U.S. 52% and 12%).



12%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

U.S. **22%** · **34th** of 51 · +2.6 pp since 2015

39%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **32nd** of 51 · +4.9 pp since 2015

3.8

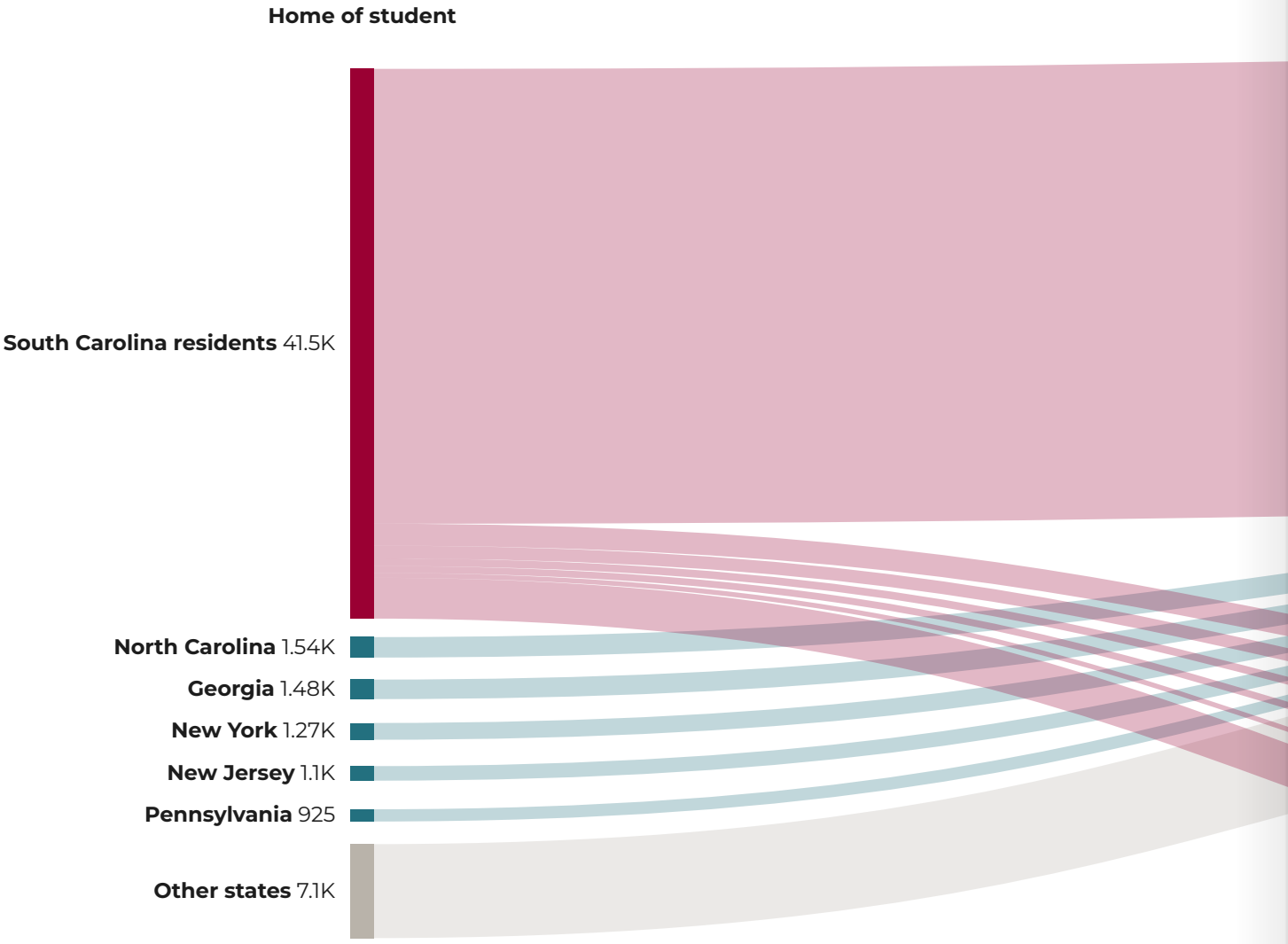
STEM master's per doctorate, 2025

U.S. **6.4** · **39th** of 51 · +1.3 since 2015

SECTION 3

Where Students Come From

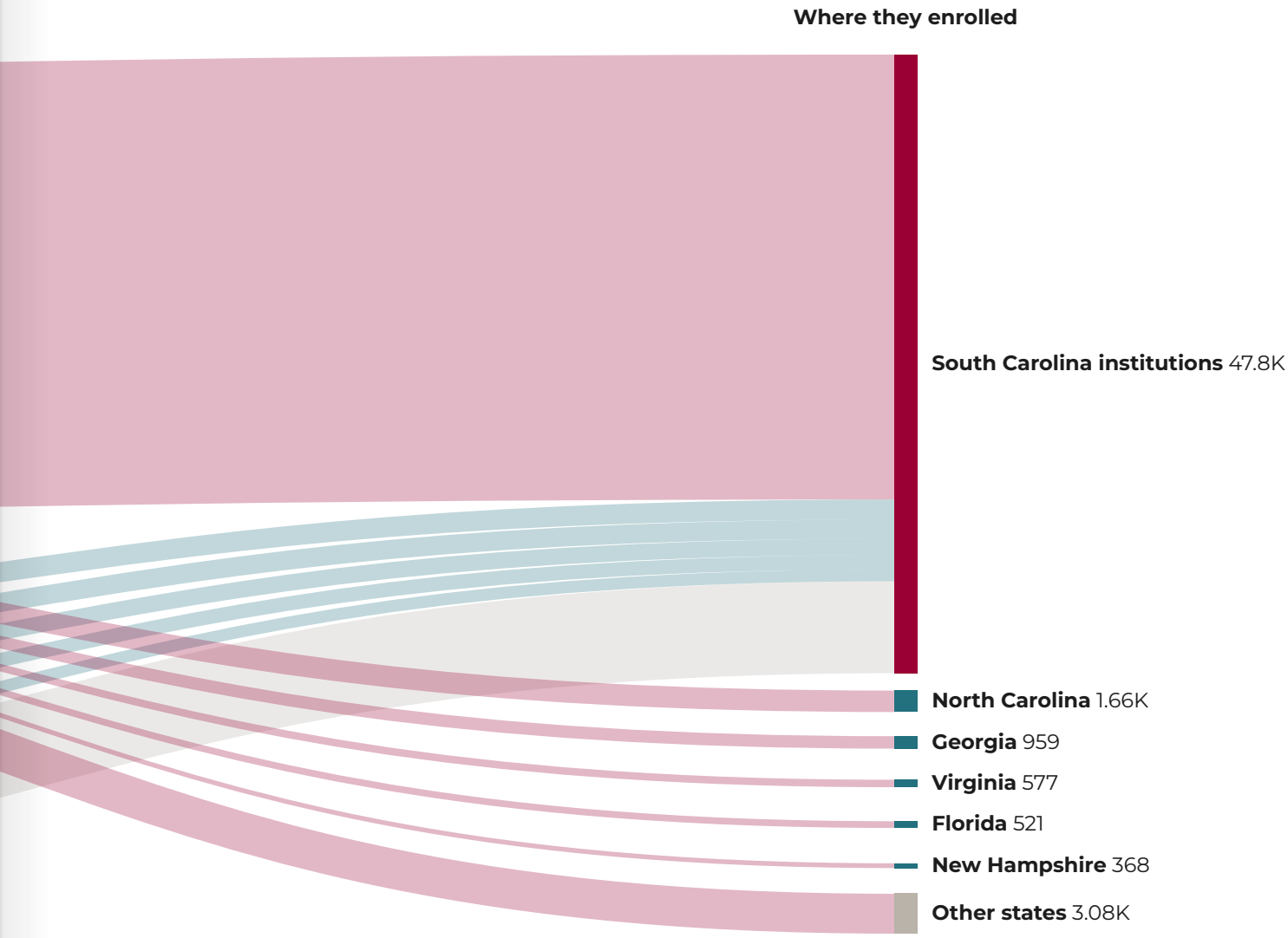
Figure 10 First-Time Students by Home and Destination, Fall 2024



Home of first-time degree-seeking undergraduates (left) and the state of the institution entered (right); the five largest s

34.3K residents stayed in South Carolina for college in fall 2024; 12.8K students arrived from other states and 615 from abroad, while 7.16K residents left.

Each band runs from a student's home on the left to the state where they enrolled on the right. 72% of the state's first-time students are residents (U.S. –).



ources and destinations, the rest grouped. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

72%

First-time students from in state, 2024

· **27th** of 51 · −4.1 pp since 2016

1.3%

First-time students from abroad, 2024

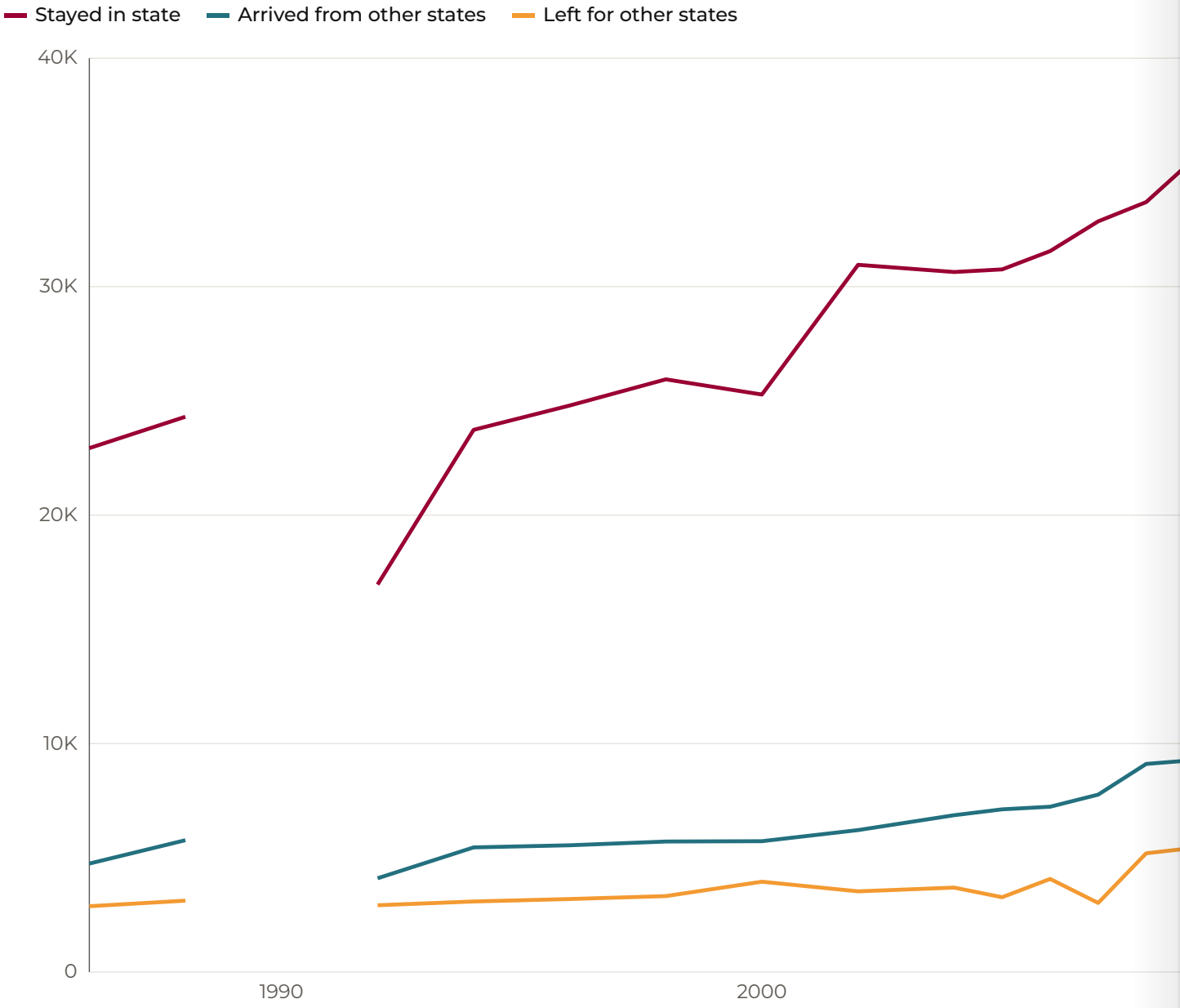
U.S. **3.1%** · **43rd** of 51 · +0.2 pp since 2016

+14

Net migration per 100 residents, 2024

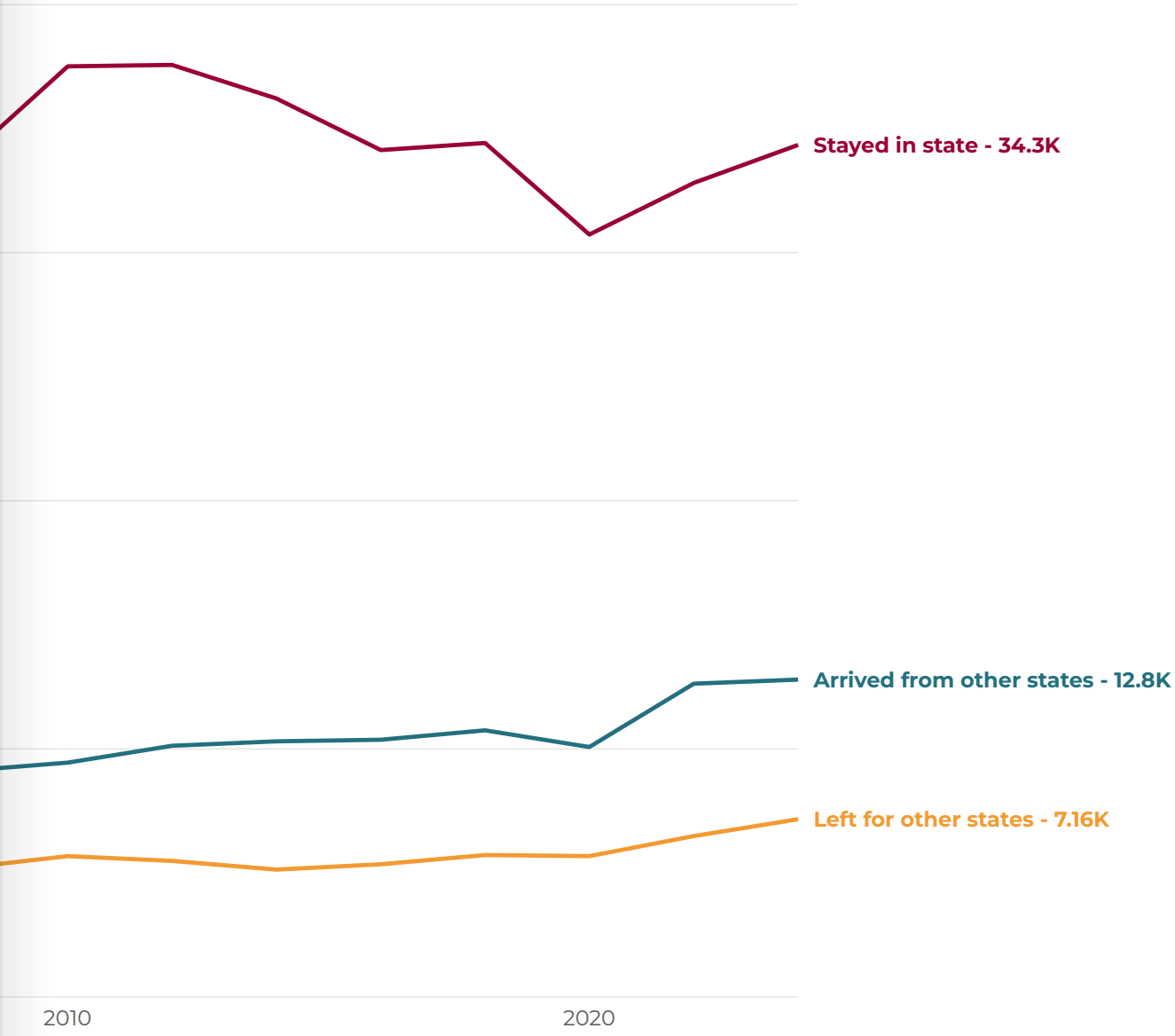
· **19th** of 51 · +0.8 since 2016

Figure 11 How Have the Flows Changed?



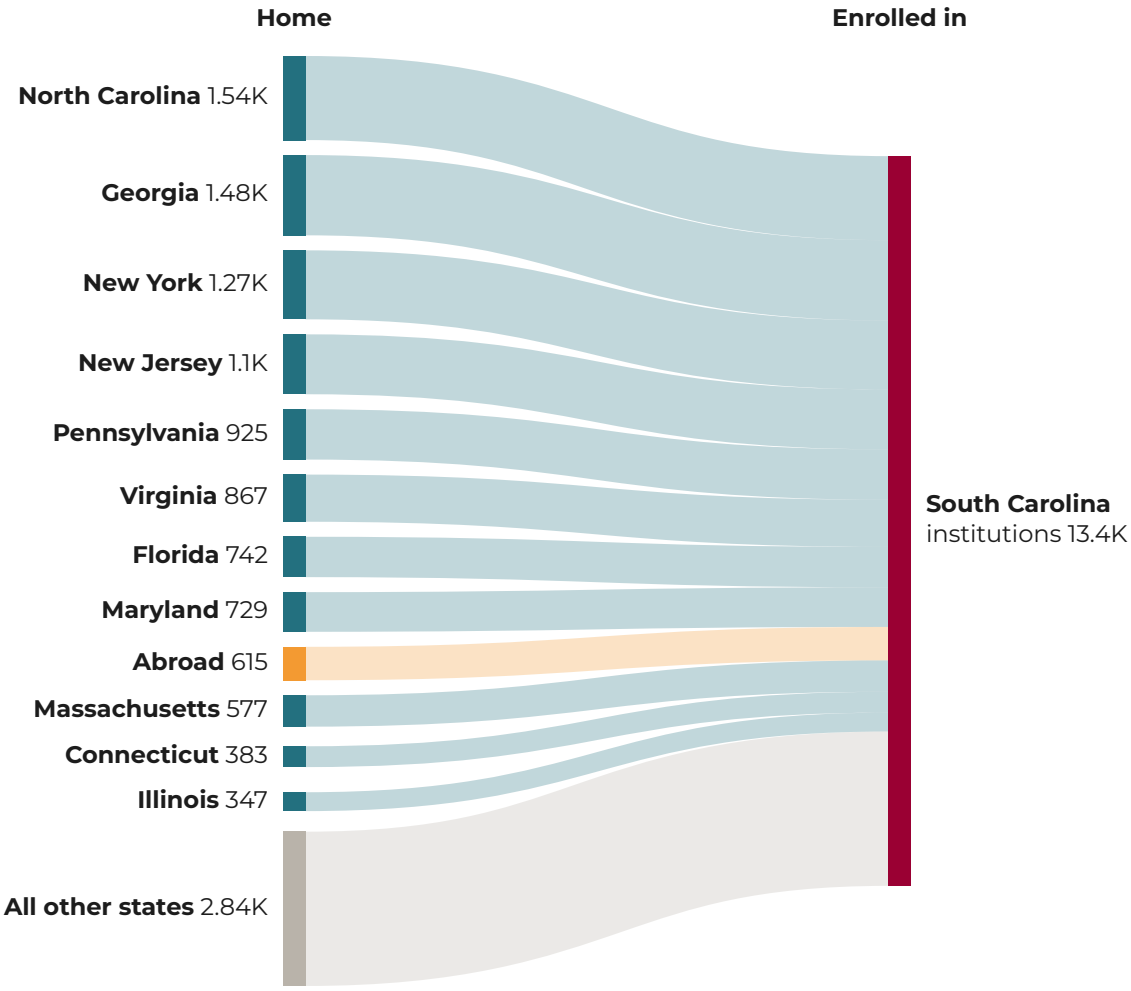
First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by flow; even years before 2001. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Since 2015, the number of residents staying in state for college is roughly flat, arrivals from other states are up 23%, and residents leaving are up 34%.



Net migration was +14 per 100 resident first-time students (19th of 51). The top destination for residents who left was North Carolina (1.66K).

Figure 12 Where Do South Carolina's Newcomers Come From?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

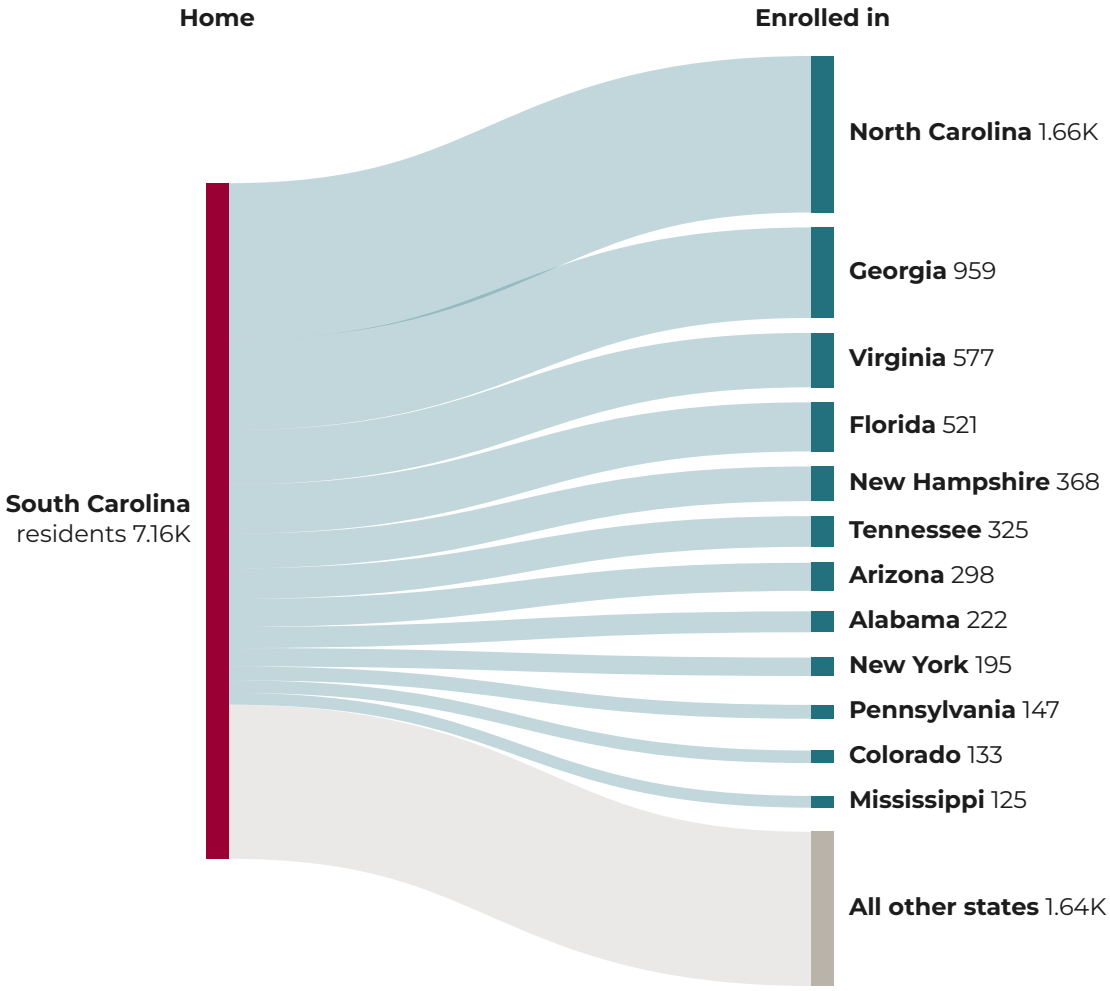
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The bands show where first-time degree-seeking undergraduates who enrolled at South Carolina's institutions in fall 2024 but did not live in the state came from: the 12 largest home states and students from abroad, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Home is the state where the student lived when admitted.

THE NUMBERS

- **Students arriving from other states**: 12.8K in fall 2024, up 1.3% from 12.6K in fall 2022, and up 23% since fall 2016 (10.4K).
- **Students arriving from abroad**: 615 in fall 2024.
- **Largest home states**: North Carolina (1.54K), Georgia (1.48K), New York (1.27K).
- **Share of first-time students from outside the U.S.**: 1.3% in 2024 (U.S. 3.1%; 43rd of 51 states), unchanged from 1.3% in 2022, and up 0.2 points since 2016 (1.1%).

Figure 13 Where Do South Carolina's Residents Go When They Leave?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The bands show where South Carolina residents who left the state to start college in fall 2024 enrolled: the 12 largest destination states, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Residents who enrolled in the state are not shown.

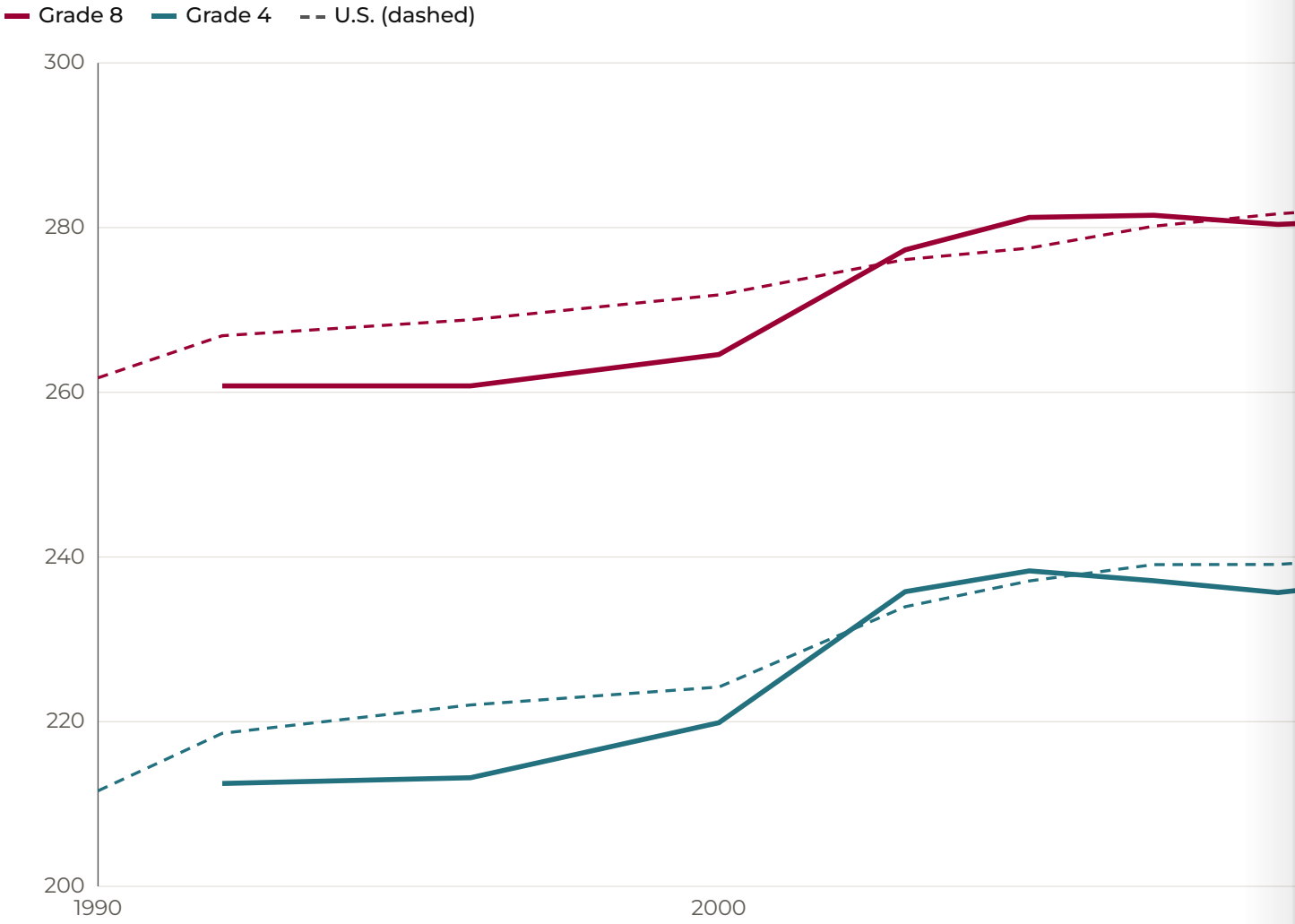
THE NUMBERS

- **Residents leaving for other states**: 7.16K in fall 2024, up 10% from 6.49K in fall 2022, and up 34% since fall 2016 (5.35K).
- **Residents staying in the state**: 34.3K in fall 2024, up 4.7% from 32.8K in fall 2022, and up 0.6% since fall 2016 (34.1K).
- **Largest destinations**: North Carolina (1.66K), Georgia (959), Virginia (577).
- **Net migration per 100 resident first-time students**: +14 in 2024 (19th of 51 states), down 2 from +16 in 2022, and up 1 since 2016 (+13).
- **Share of first-time students who are residents**: 72% in 2024 (27th of 51 states), up 0.6 points from 71% in 2022, and down 4.1 points since 2016 (76%).

SECTION 4

K-12 Preparation

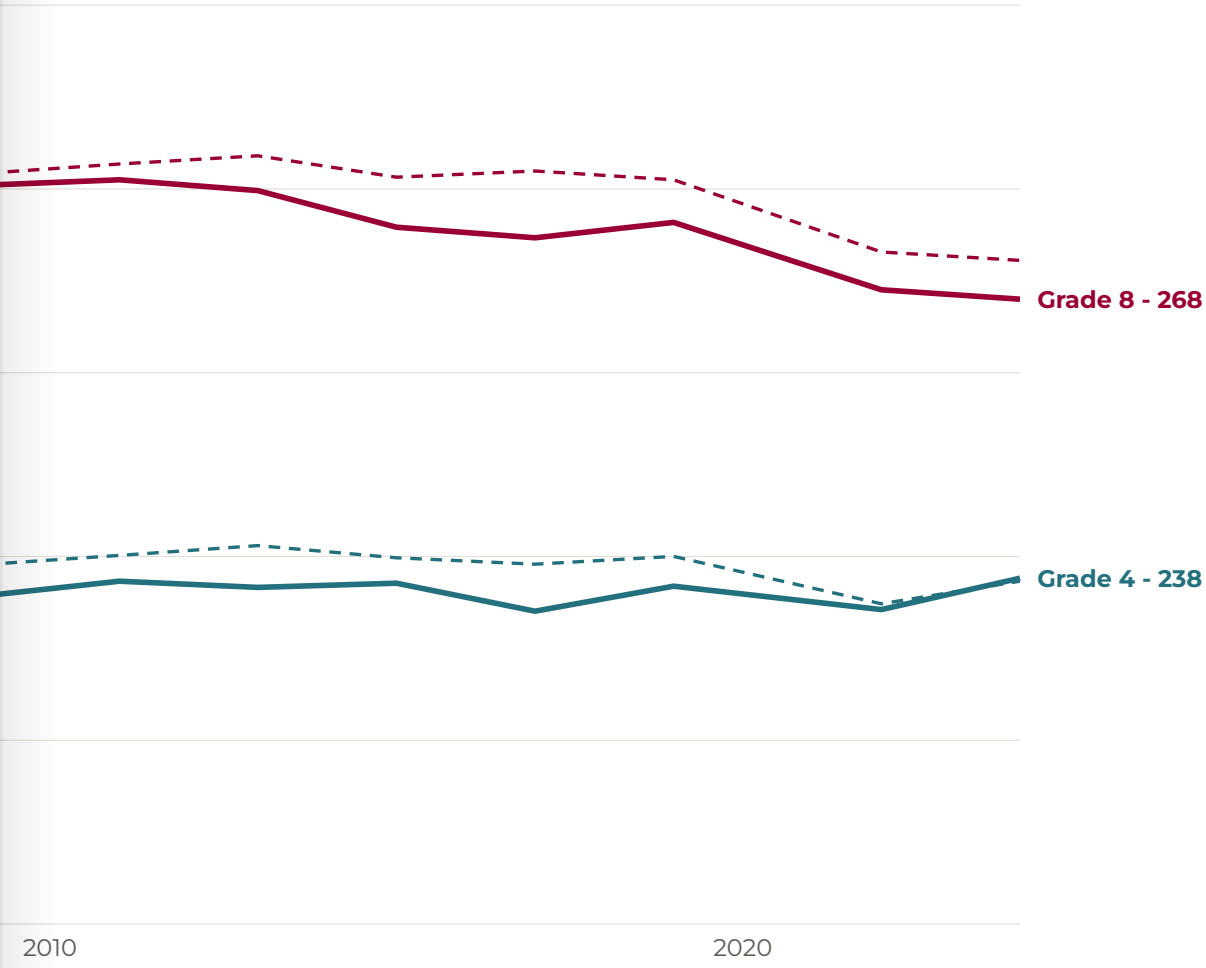
Figure 14 How Well Prepared in Mathematics Are South Carolina's Students?



Average NAEP mathematics score, public schools, 0–500 scale; state solid, U.S. public schools dashed. Data from NCES, N

The talent pipeline starts in school. South Carolina's eighth graders averaged 268 in mathematics on the 2024 NAEP, against 272 for U.S. public schools, 39th of 51 among the states.

24% scored at or above the Proficient level (U.S. 27%). Differences of a point or two are often within the margin of error.



lational Assessment of Educational Progress.

268

Grade 8 math score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **272** · **39th** of 51 · −7.8 since 2015

24%

Grade 8 math, at or above Proficient, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **35th** of 51 · −2.0 pp since 2015

254

Grade 8 reading score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **257** · **40th** of 51 · −6.6 since 2015

SECTION 5

Graduate Research

Figure 15 How Many of South Carolina's Science and Engineering Graduate Students H



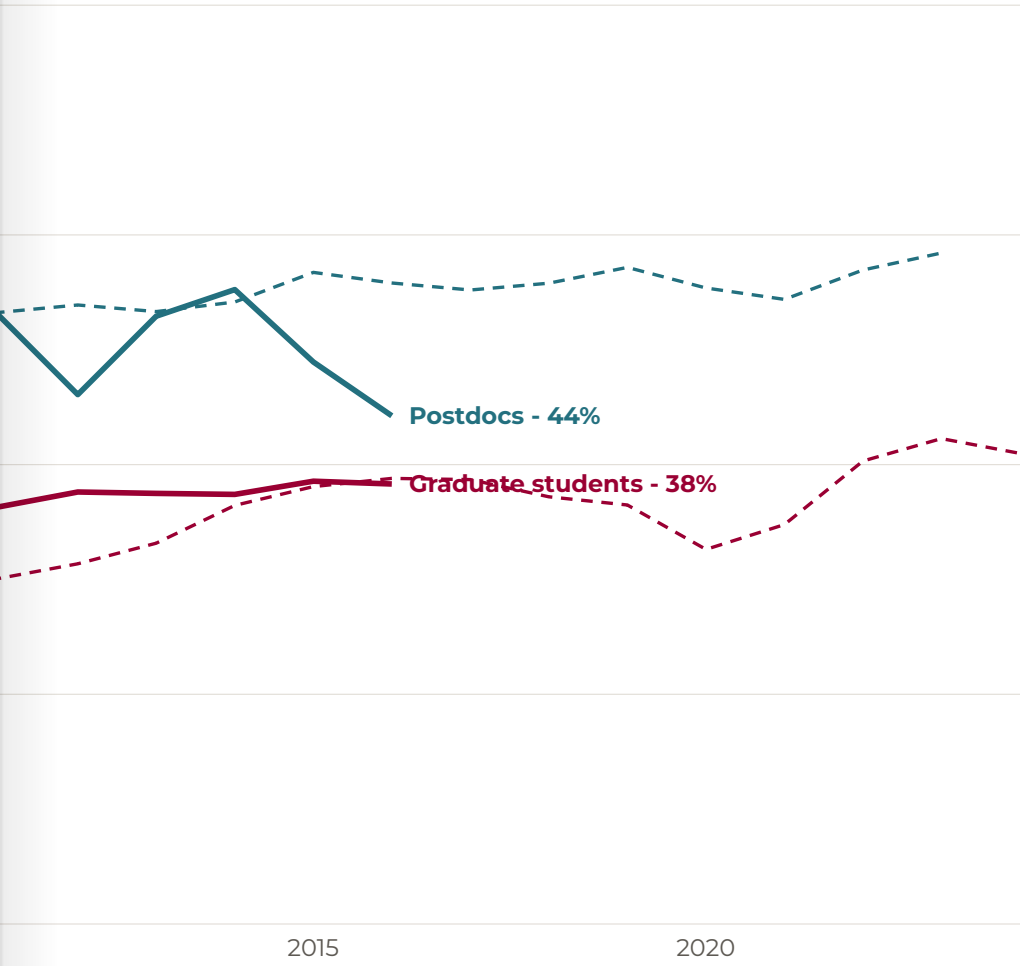
Temporary-visa share of science and engineering graduate students and postdoctoral appointees, by the institution's sta
Students and Postdoctorates.

In 2016, the last year NSF published state tables, 38% of South Carolina's science and engineering graduate students held temporary visas (U.S. 39%; 18th of 51).

Among postdoctoral researchers, the share was 44% (U.S. 56%). Postdocs are the stage of research training most dependent on international talent, and IPEDS does not count them.

The state's institutions awarded 580 research doctorates in 2025, 1.0% of the U.S. total (Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates; NSF publishes doctorates by citizenship only for the nation).

lold Temporary Visas?



te; state solid, U.S. dashed. NSF stopped publishing state tables after 2016. Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Graduate

38%

S&E grad students on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **39%** · **18th** of 51 · −0.3 pp since 2015

44%

S&E postdocs on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **56%** · **41st** of 51 · −4.7 pp since 2015

580

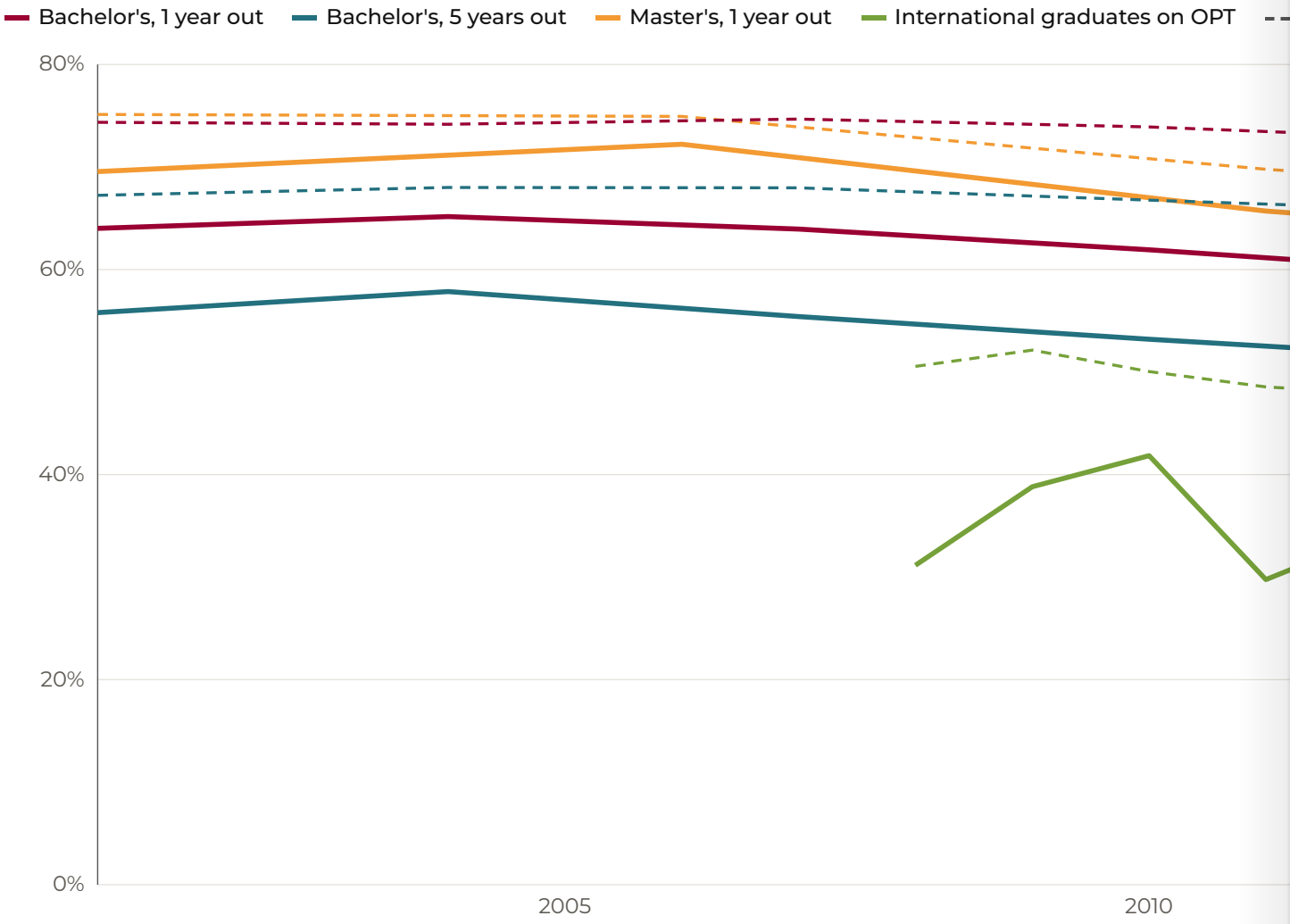
Research doctorates awarded (NSF SED), 2025

U.S. **59K** · **27th** of 51 · −1.0% since 2015

SECTION 6

Do Graduates Stay?

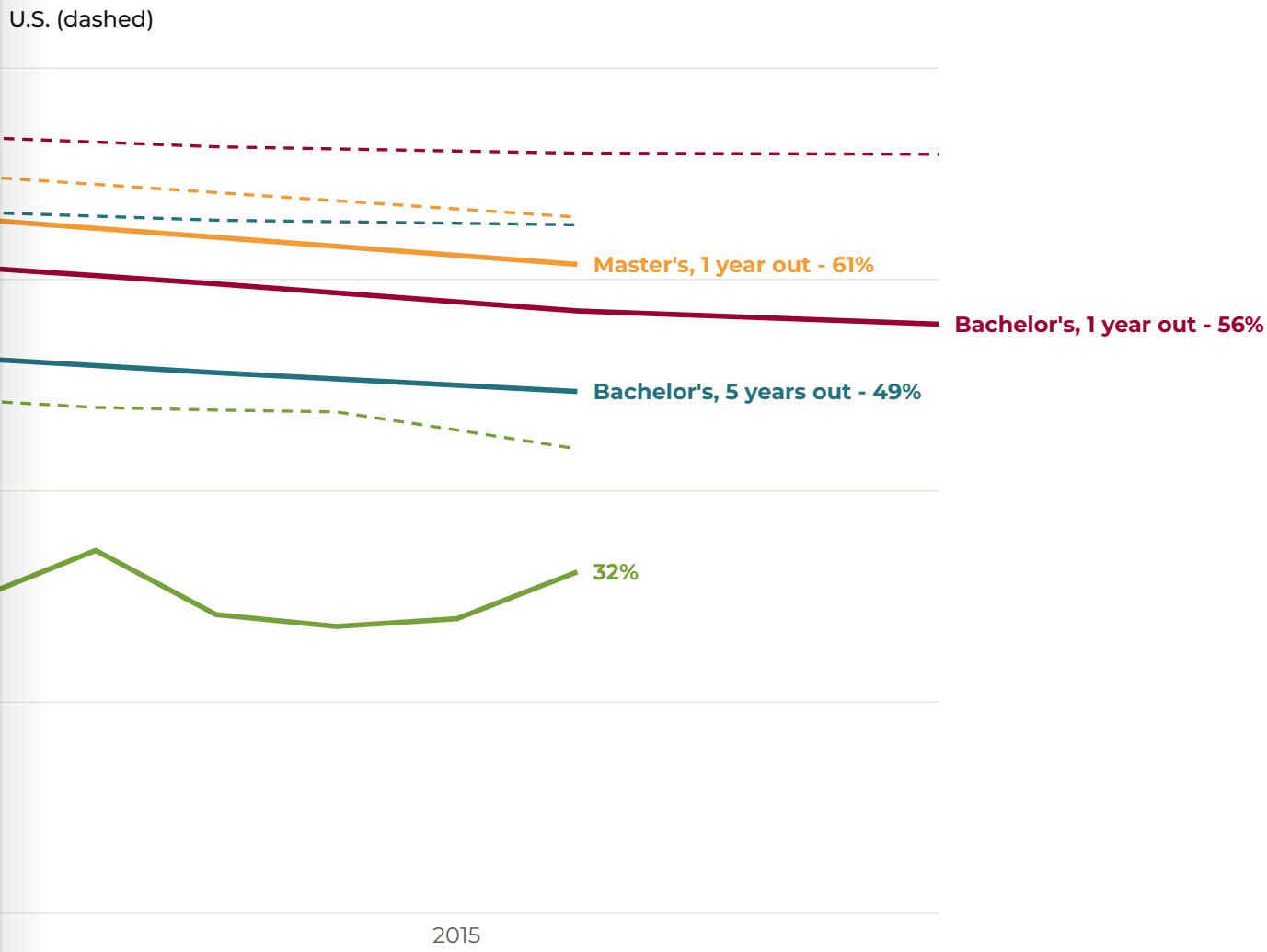
Figure 16 How Many of South Carolina's Graduates Go On to Work in the State?



Share of employed graduates working in the state of their institution, by graduating cohort (Data from U.S. Census Burea
state where they studied (Data from ICE, SEVIS FOIA releases; shares only, the file is truncated). State solid, U.S. or particip

Of South Carolina's bachelor's graduates who were working a year after graduating, 56% worked in the state (participating states 72%). Five years out the share was 49%.

Among international graduates on Optional Practical Training in 2016, 32% worked in the state where they studied (U.S. 44%). Through migration between states, the state gained 17.4 bachelor's-plus adults per 1,000 such residents in 2025 (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey).



au, Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes; participating institutions only); international graduates' OPT jobs in the
pating states dashed.

56%

Bachelor's grads working in-state, 1 year out, 2019

U.S. **72%** · **26th** of 33 · −1.2 pp since 2016

32%

OPT graduates working in the state, 2016

U.S. **44%** · **31st** of 51 · +4.4 pp since 2015

+17.4

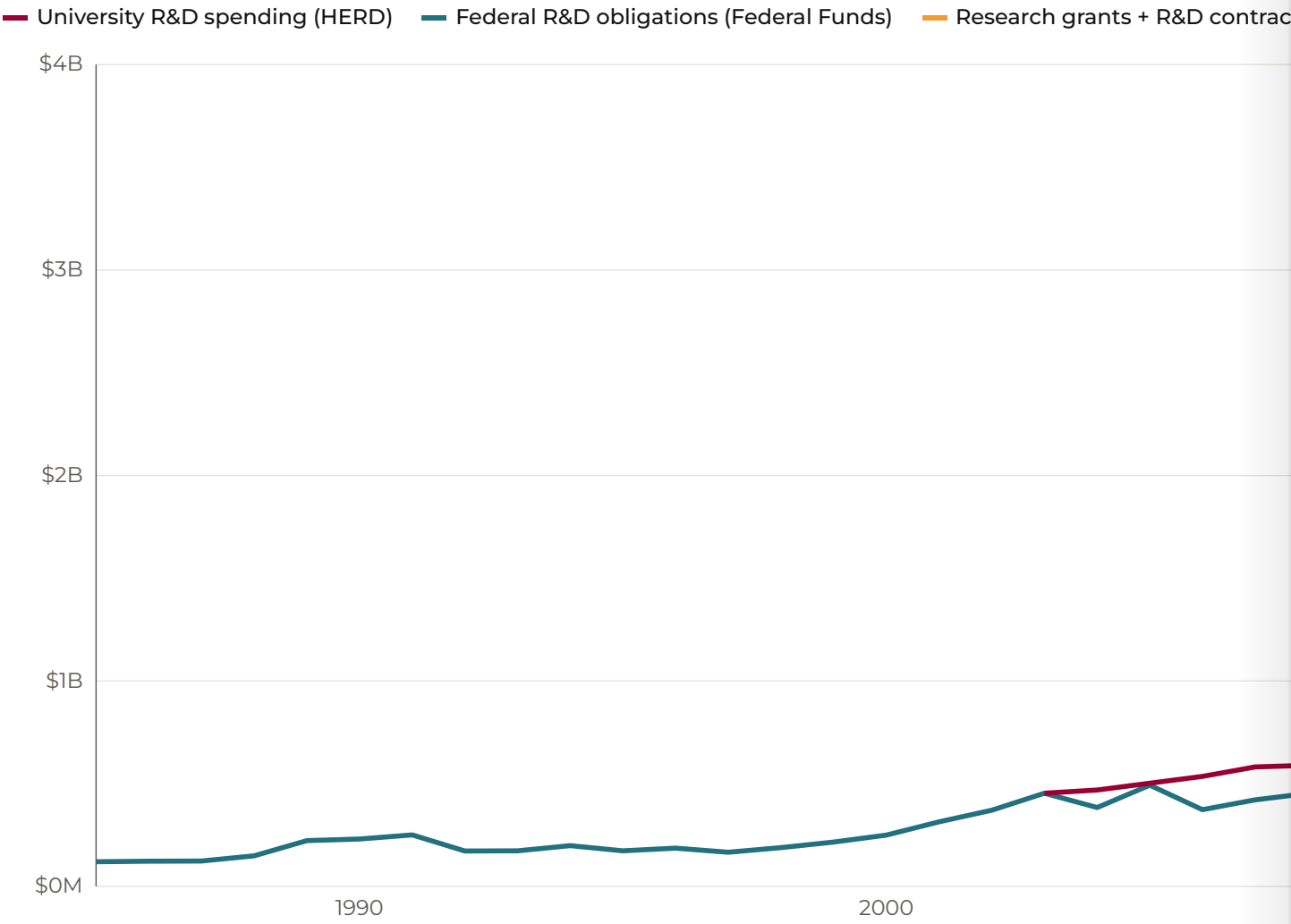
Net migration, bachelor's-plus, per 1,000, 2025

· **1st** of 51 · +4.1 since 2015

SECTION 7

Research Funding

Figure 17 How Much Research Money Flows Into South Carolina?

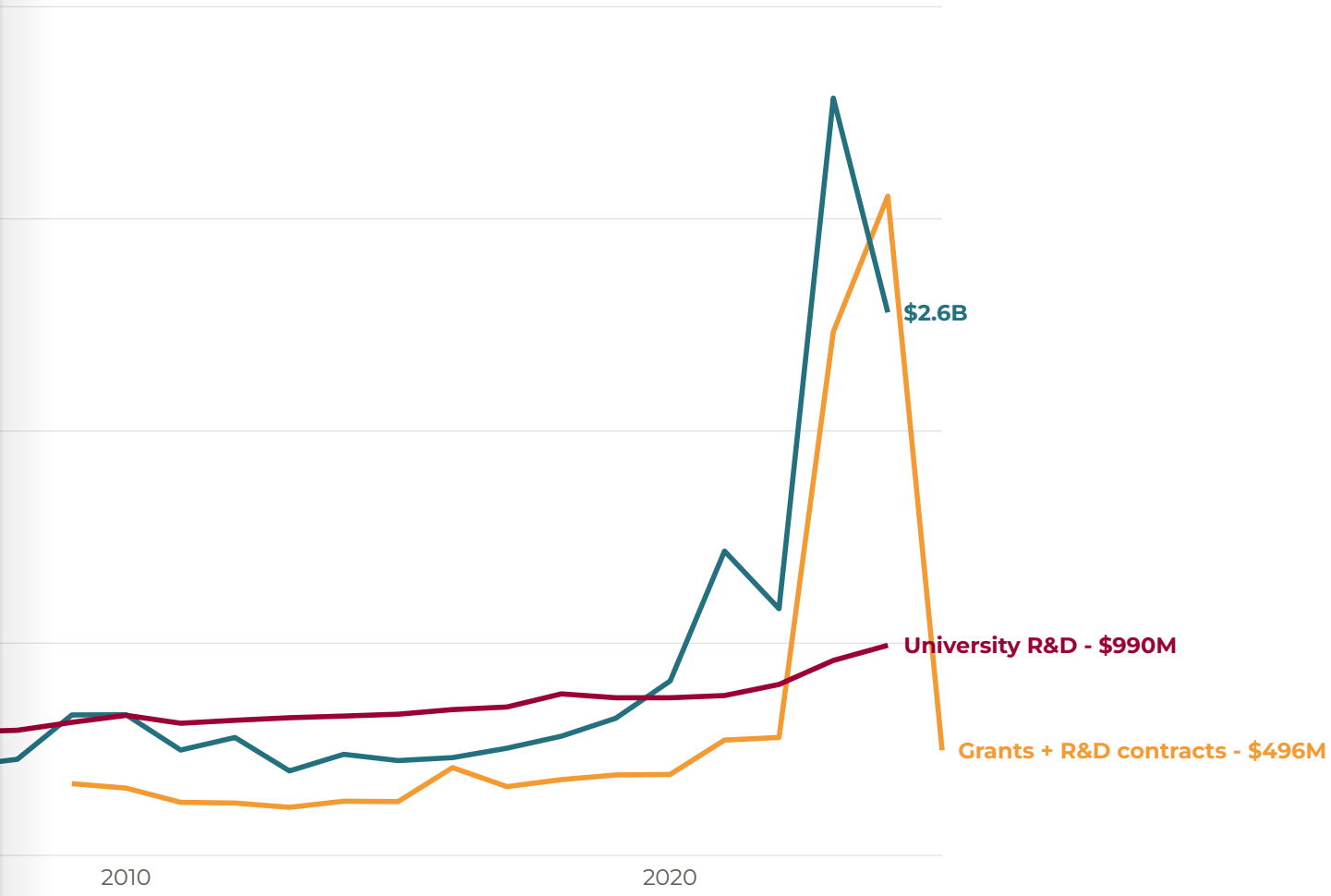


Millions of nominal dollars, fiscal years. University R&D: Data from NSF NCSES, Higher Education Research and Developm
Survey of Federal Funds for R&D (coverage widens in FY2021). Grants from NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science plus R&D co

South Carolina's universities spent $990M on research and development in FY2024, 31st of 51 among the states; 52% of it was federally funded (U.S. 55%).

Federal agencies obligated $2.56B for R&D performed in the state in FY2024. Research funding drives demand for graduate students and postdocs, the stage of training most dependent on international talent.

ts (USAspending)



nent Survey (FY2003-09 predecessor survey). Federal R&D obligations by state of performance: Data from NSF NCSES, ntracts: Data from USAspending.gov.

$990M

University R&D spending, 2024

U.S. **$118B** · **31st** of 51 · +49% since 2015

52%

Federal share of university R&D, 2024

U.S. **55%** · **29th** of 51 · +9.4 pp since 2015

$2.56B

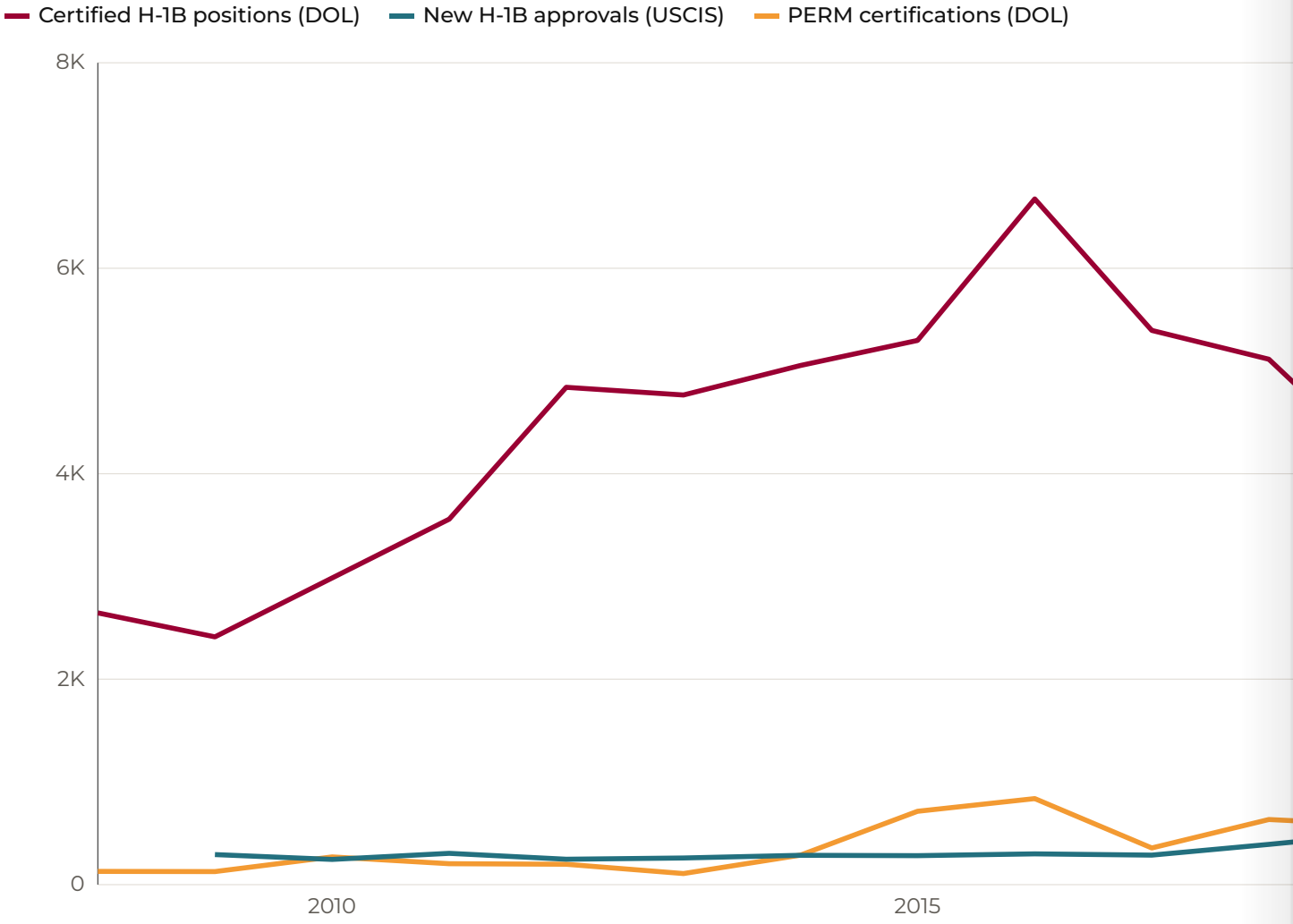
Federal R&D obligations, 2024

U.S. **$193B** · **21st** of 51 · 5.73× since 2015

SECTION 8

H-1B Jobs and Green Cards

Figure 18 How Many Skilled-Visa Jobs and Green-Card Certifications Does South Caroli

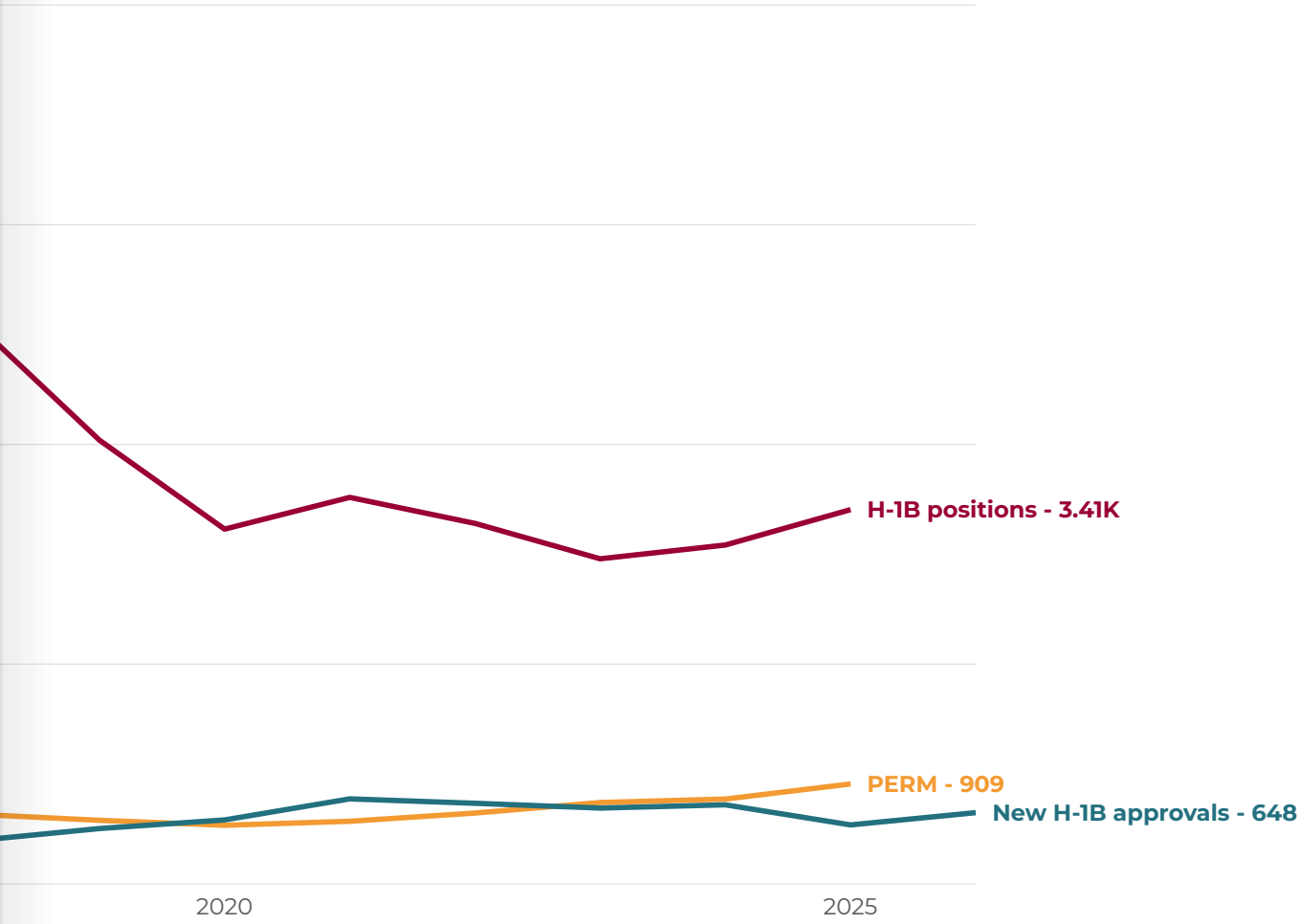


Certified H-1B positions on labor condition applications by worksite and certified PERM green-card applications, by fiscal
from USCIS, H-1B Employer Data Hub).

Employers were certified for 3.41K H-1B positions at South Carolina worksites in FY2025, 28th of 51 among the states. A labor certification comes before the petition, so this overstates hires; USCIS approved 648 new H-1B petitions from employers in the state in FY2026.

DOL certified 909 PERM applications, the employer's step toward an employment-based green card, for jobs in the state in FY2025. In FY2024, 20% were for workers still on F-1 student visas (U.S. 8.7%): the most direct link from classroom to permanent residence.

ina Generate?



year (Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification); new H-1B petition approvals by the employer's address (Data

3.41K

Certified H-1B positions (worksite), 2025

U.S. **914K** · **28th** of 51 · −36% since 2015

909

PERM green-card certifications, 2025

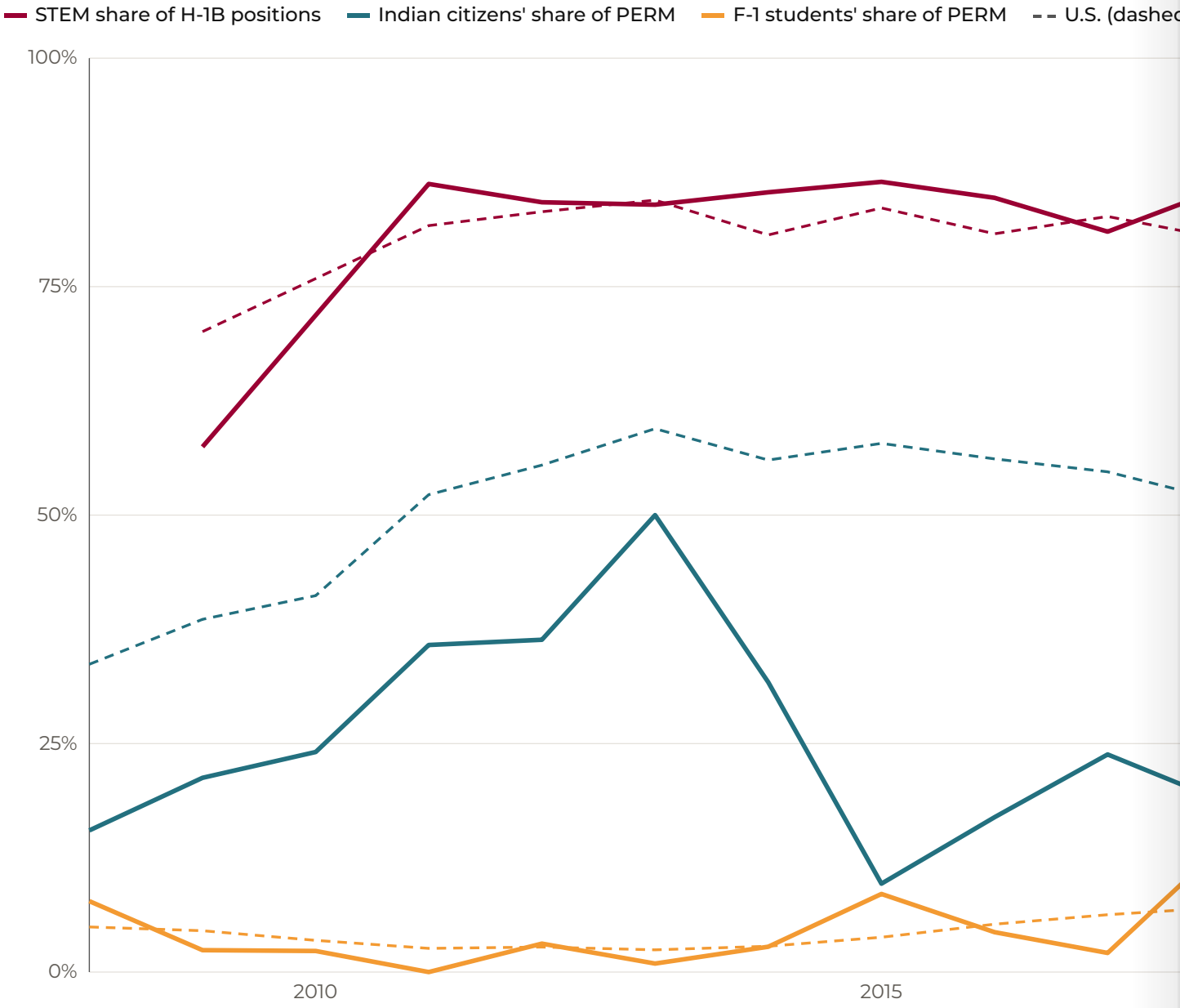
U.S. **138K** · **26th** of 51 · +27% since 2015

20%

PERM workers on F-1 student visas, 2024

U.S. **8.7%** · **5th** of 51 · +11.2 pp since 2015

Figure 19 Who Holds South Carolina's Skilled-Visa Jobs?

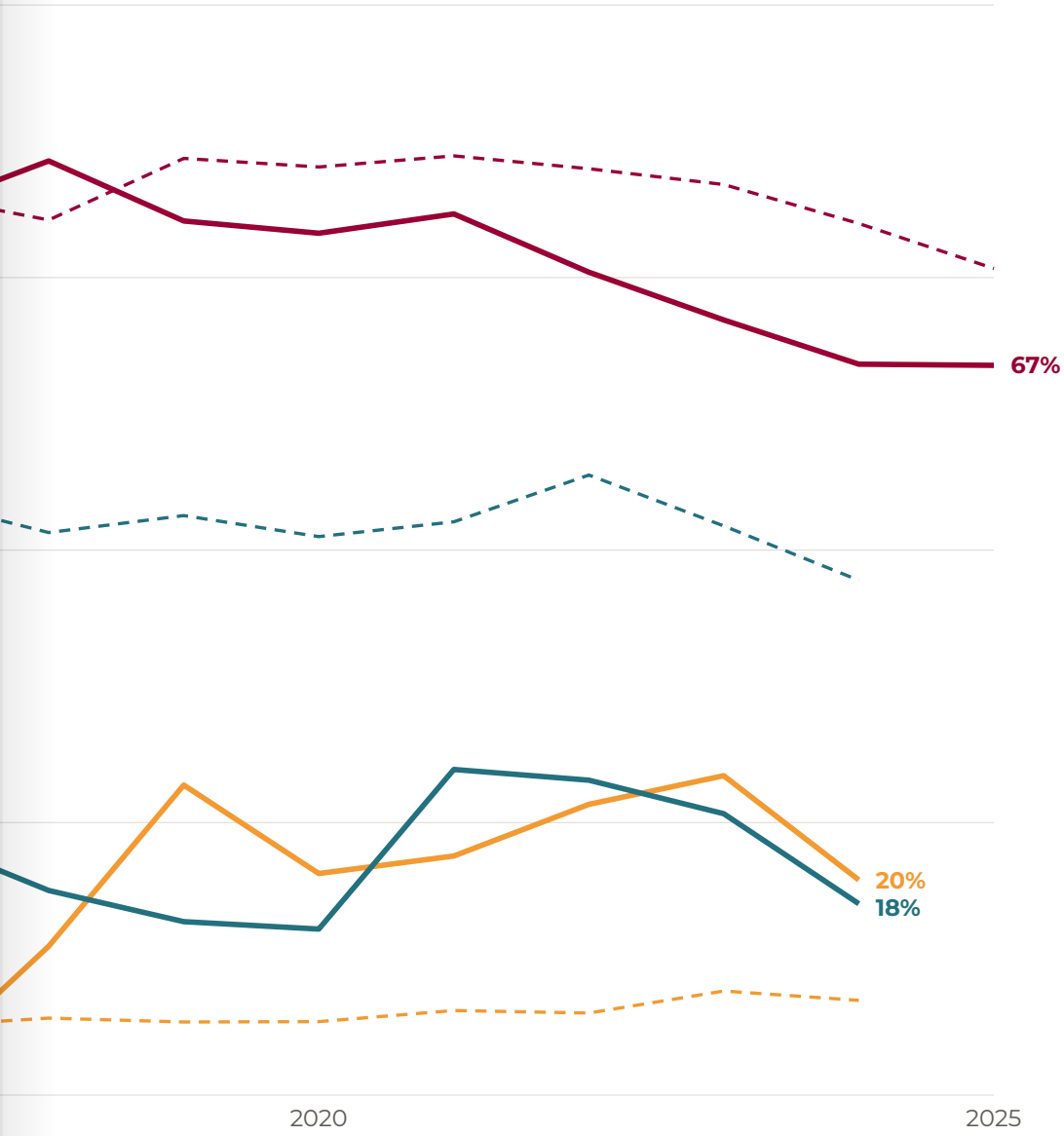


State solid, U.S. dashed. PERM citizenship and class of admission are not on the form DOL uses from FY2025. Data from D

67% of the state's certified H-1B positions were in STEM occupations in FY2025 (U.S. 76%).

Citizens of India held 18% of the state's PERM certifications in FY2024 (U.S. 47%). Under per-country caps they face the longest waits for a green card, so this share measures the state's exposure to the backlog.

d)



OL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification.

67%

STEM share of H-1B positions, 2025

U.S. **76%** · **26th** of 51 · −19.5 pp since 2015

18%

PERM certifications for Indian citizens, 2024

U.S. **47%** · **42nd** of 51 · +7.9 pp since 2015

$95K

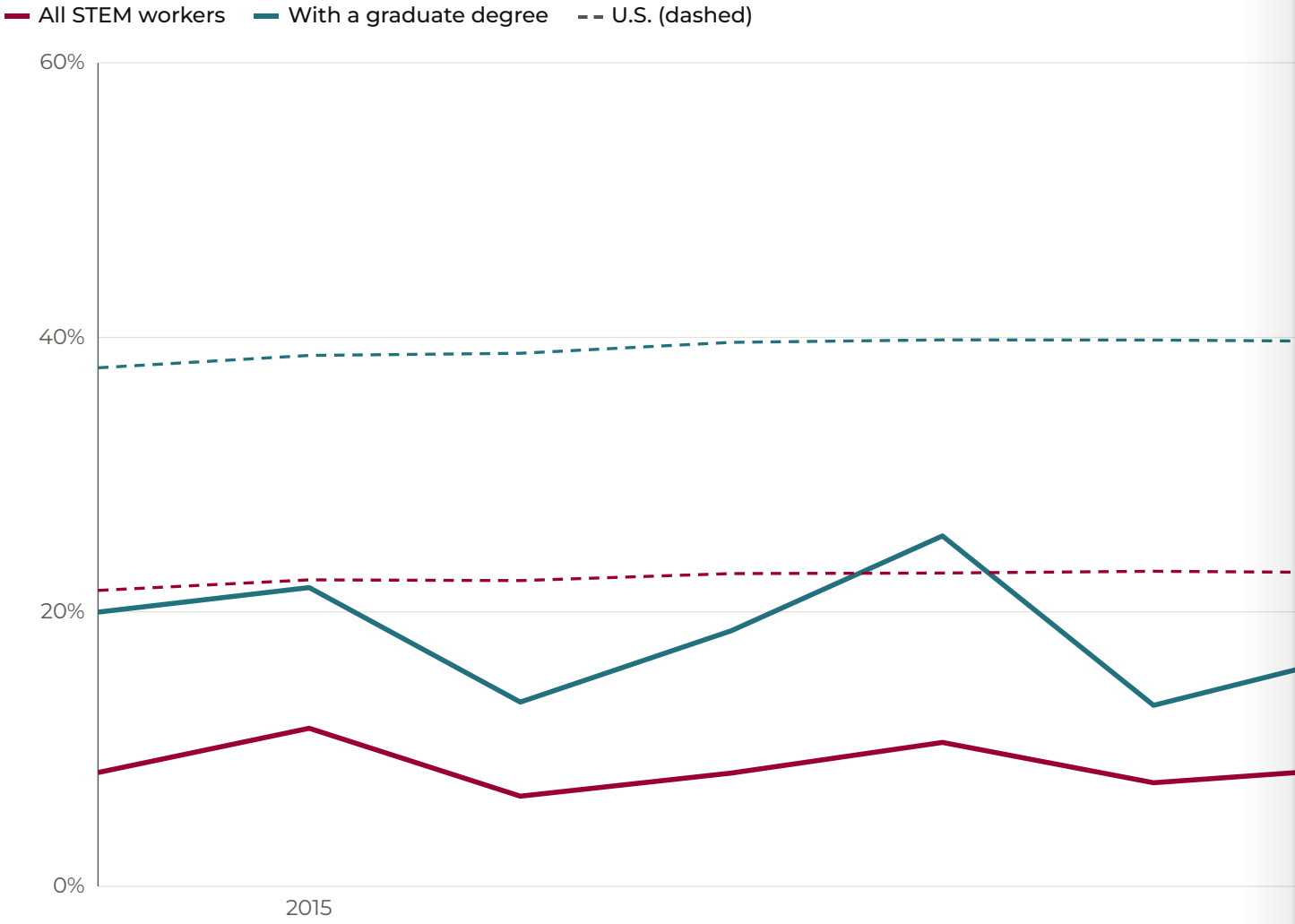
Median offered H-1B wage (nominal), 2025

U.S. **$119K** · **34th** of 51 · +51% since 2015

SECTION 9

STEM Workforce

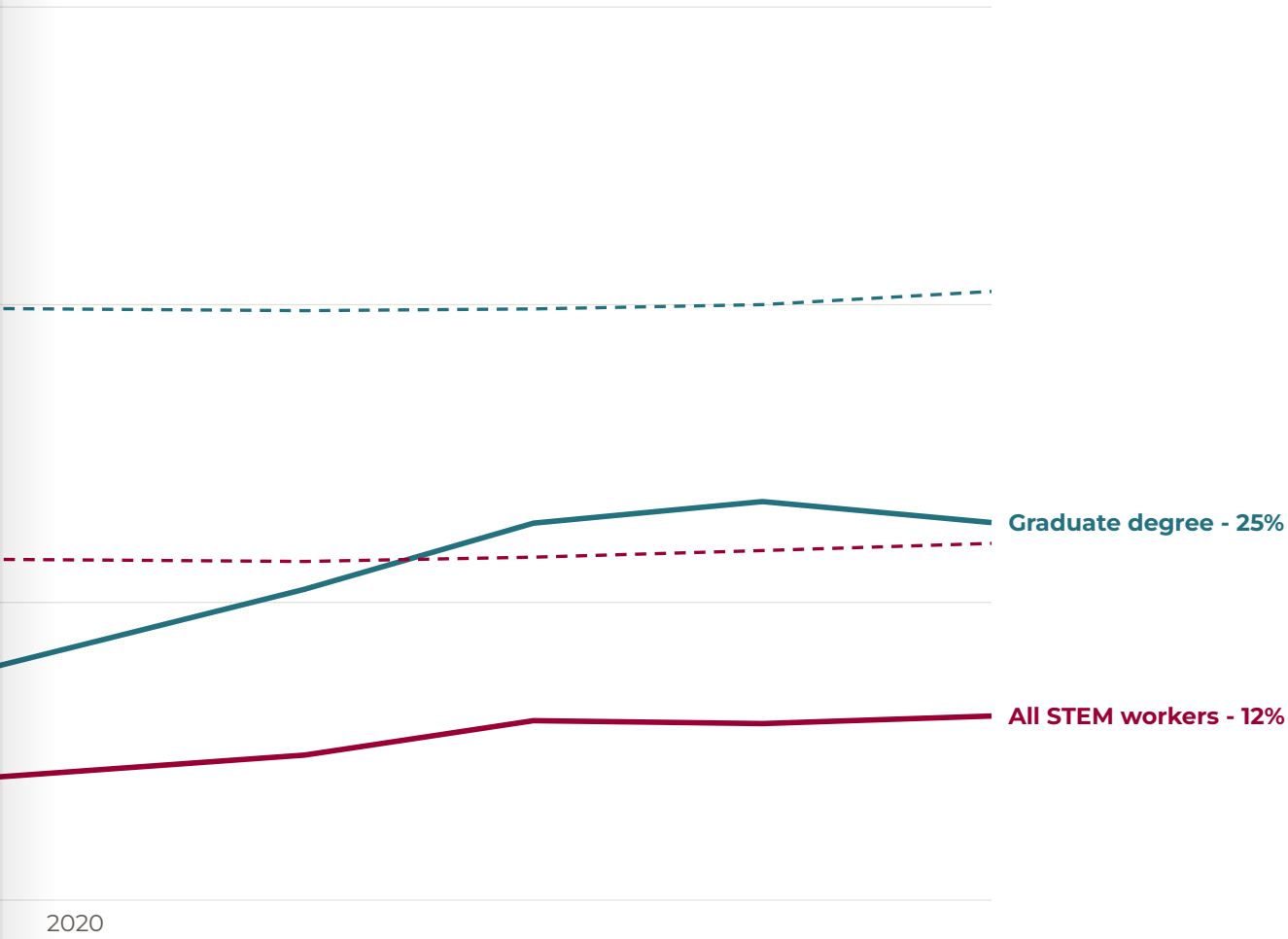
Figure 20 How Much of South Carolina's STEM Workforce Was Born Abroad?



Foreign-born share of employed workers in STEM occupations, by state of residence; state solid, U.S. dashed. Shares resti
Community Survey.

In 2024, 12% of the people working in STEM occupations in South Carolina were born abroad (U.S. 24%; 29th of 51).

The share rises with education: 25% of STEM workers with a graduate degree were foreign-born (U.S. 41%). 6.0% of all STEM workers were not U.S. citizens.



ng on fewer than 100 survey records are left out. No 2020 (experimental data). Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American

12%

Foreign-born share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **24%** · **29th** of 51 · +0.9 pp since 2015

25%

Foreign-born, STEM workers with grad degrees, 2024

U.S. **41%** · **28th** of 44 · +3.6 pp since 2015

6.0%

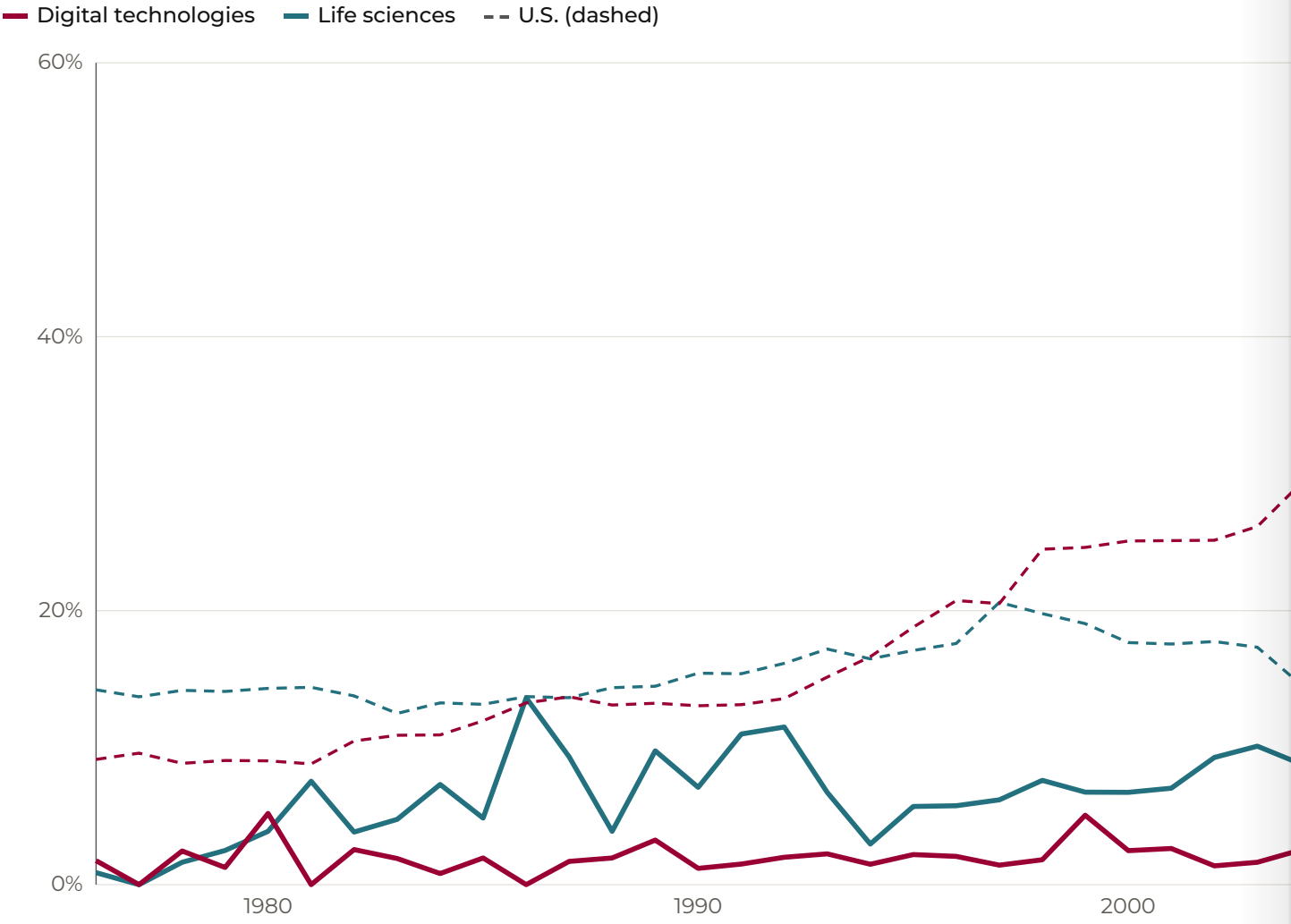
Noncitizen share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **11%** · **33rd** of 51 · −0.8 pp since 2015

SECTION 10

Patents

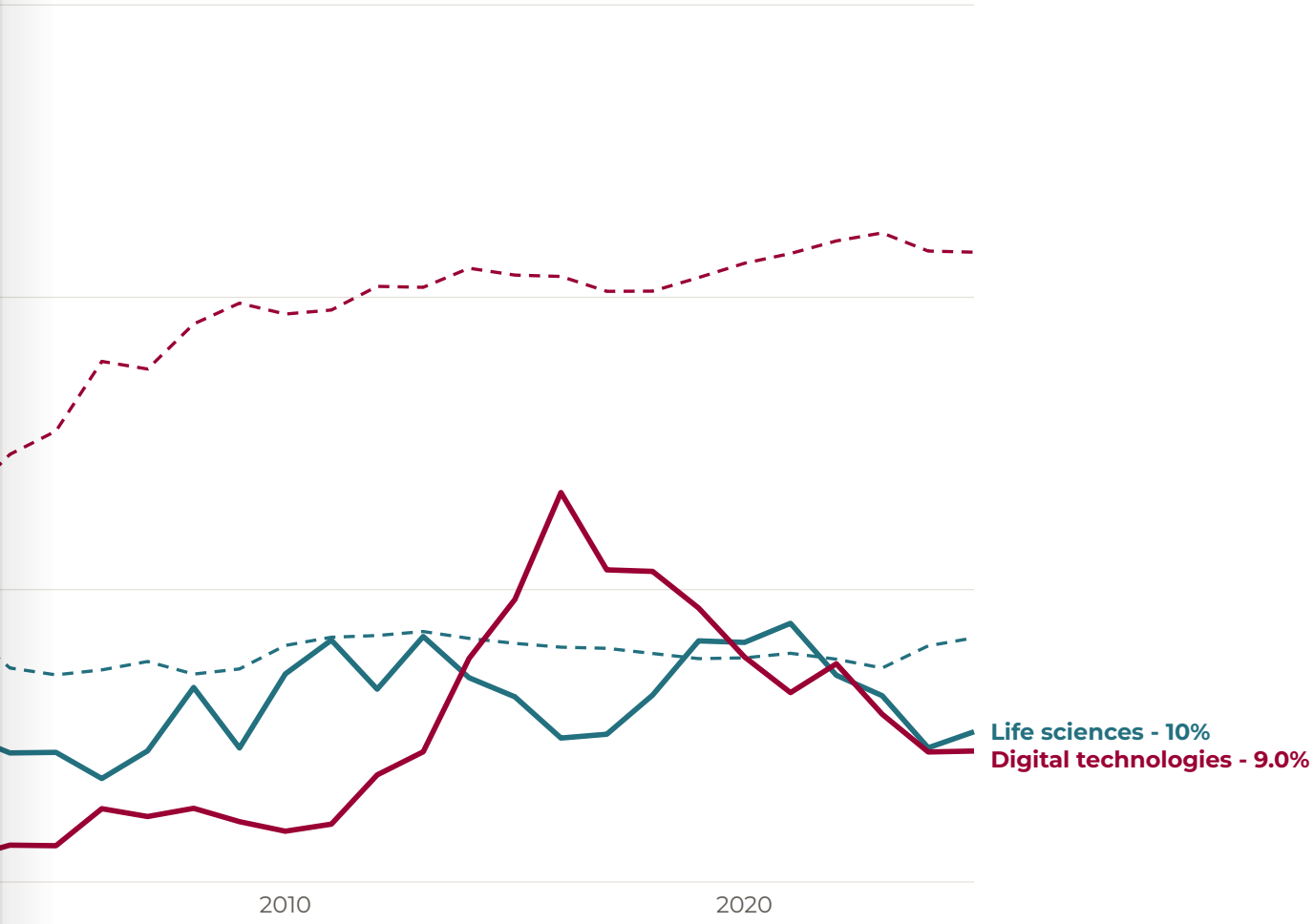
Figure 21 What Kinds of Technology Does South Carolina Patent?



Share of patents granted to owners in the state, by WIPO technology field of the first classification; state solid, U.S. dashed

Organizations and people in South Carolina were granted 669 U.S. patents in 2025, 0.5% of all patents with a U.S. owner (30th of 51).

9.0% were in digital technologies (U.S. 43%) and 10% in the life sciences (U.S. 17%).



d. Fractional counts by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live. Data from USPTO, PatentsView.

669

Patents granted to owners in the state, 2025

U.S. **135K** · **30th** of 51 · +51% since 2015

9.0%

Patents in digital technologies, 2025

U.S. **43%** · **45th** of 51 · −10.4 pp since 2015

10%

Patents in life sciences, 2025

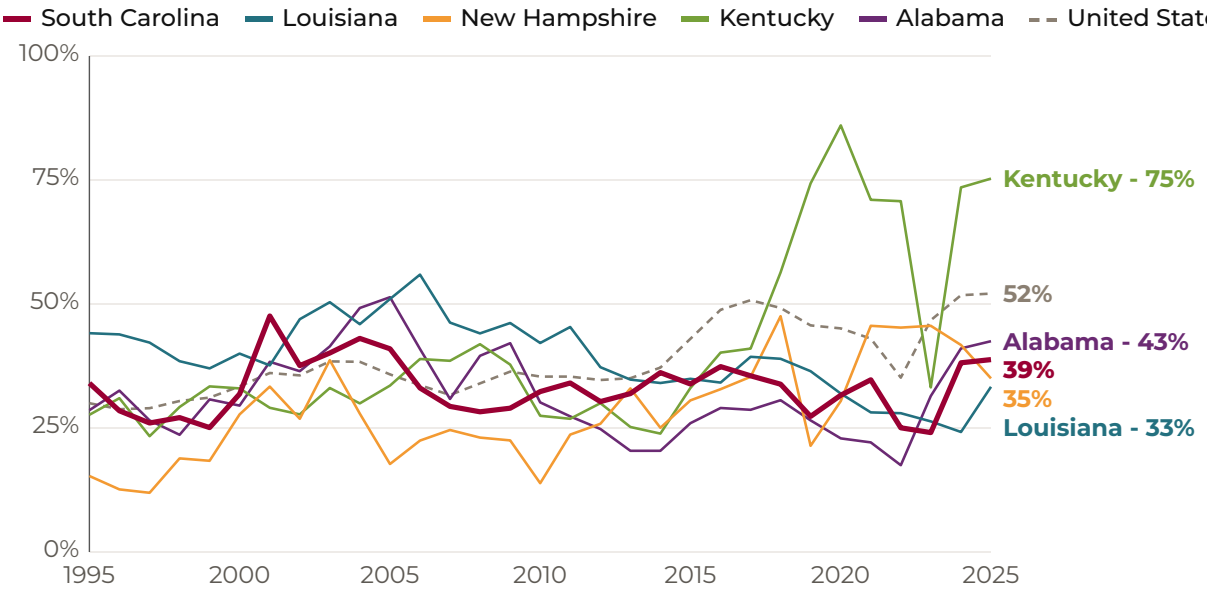
U.S. **17%** · **41st** of 51 · −2.4 pp since 2015

SECTION 11

Competitors

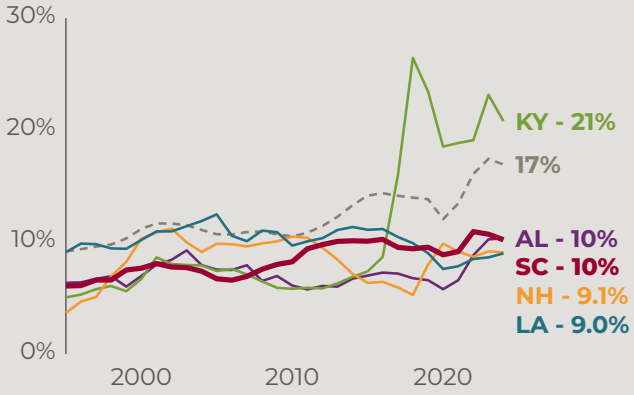
The four states closest in size are Louisiana, New Hampshire, Kentucky, Alabama. South Carolina ranks 3rd of the five on the international share of STEM master's; Kentucky is the most dependent at 75%.

Figure 22 How Dependent Are South Carolina and Its Peers on International STEM Master's?



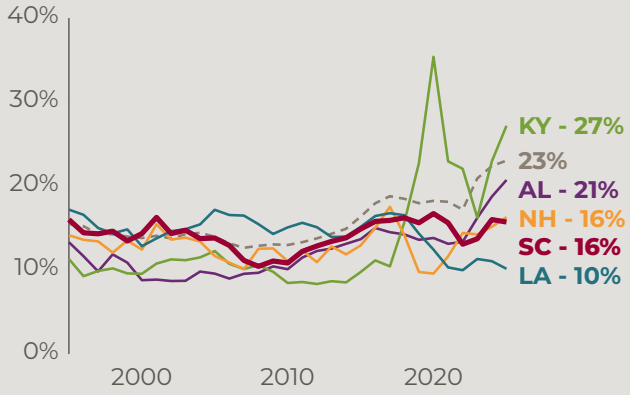
Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Figure 23 Int. share of grad students



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 24 STEM share of master's



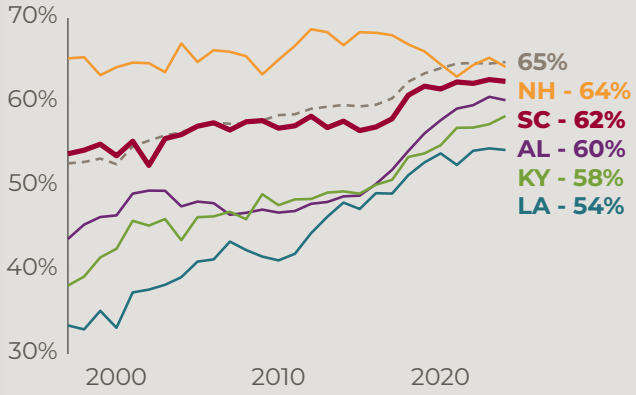
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Table 3 How Does South Carolina Compare With States of Similar Size?

Measure	SC	LA	NH	KY	AL	U.S.
Students enrolled	**256K**	255K	241K	290K	311K	19.7M
Graduate share of students	**12%**	16%	15%	21%	18%	17%
STEM share of bachelor's	**23%**	21%	18%	17%	24%	24%
STEM share of master's	**16%**	10%	16%	27%	21%	23%
International STEM master's	**462**	391	682	4.04K	1.47K	117K
Share of U.S. international STEM master's	**0.4%**	0.3%	0.6%	3.5%	1.3%	100%
Int. share of STEM master's	**39%**	33%	35%	75%	43%	52%
Int. share of STEM research doctorates	**41%**	46%	35%	44%	49%	43%
Int. share of grad students	**10%**	9.0%	9.1%	21%	10%	17%
Int. share of undergraduate enrollment	**1.2%**	2.0%	0.9%	1.4%	1.5%	3.0%
Six-year graduation rate	**62%**	54%	64%	58%	60%	65%
In-state tuition, public 4-year	**$12.8K**	$10.1K	$17.4K	$11.9K	$11.6K	$9.71K
Appropriations per student	**$9.11K**	$6.94K	$6.3K	$7.45K	$11.4K	$11.4K
Average faculty salary	**$83.9K**	$81.1K	$117K	$76.7K	$86.4K	$106K
First-time students from in state	**72%**	78%	21%	77%	68%	–
Net migration per 100 residents	**+14**	+4	+155	+7	+23	–

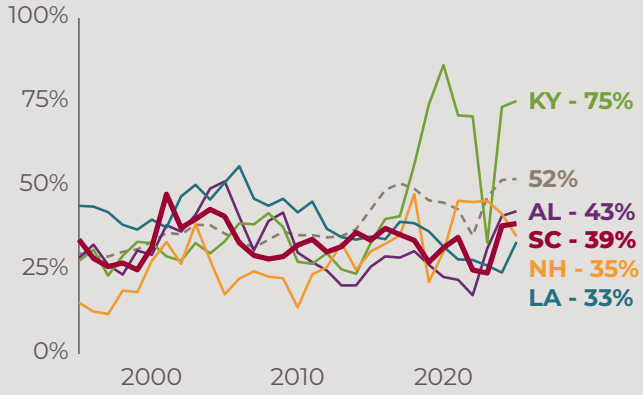
Latest year for each measure. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 25 Six-year graduation rate



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 26 Int. share of STEM master's

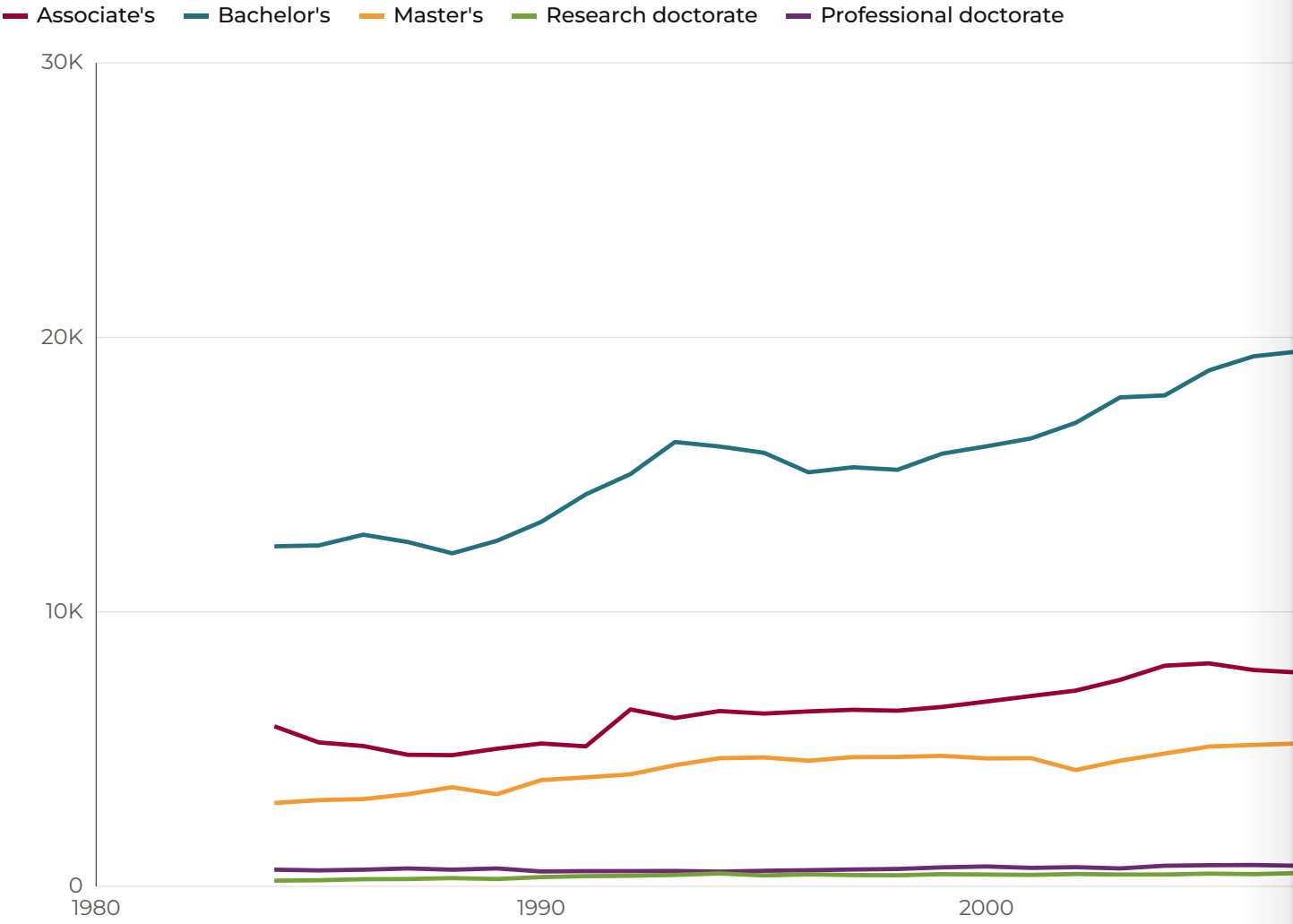


Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 12

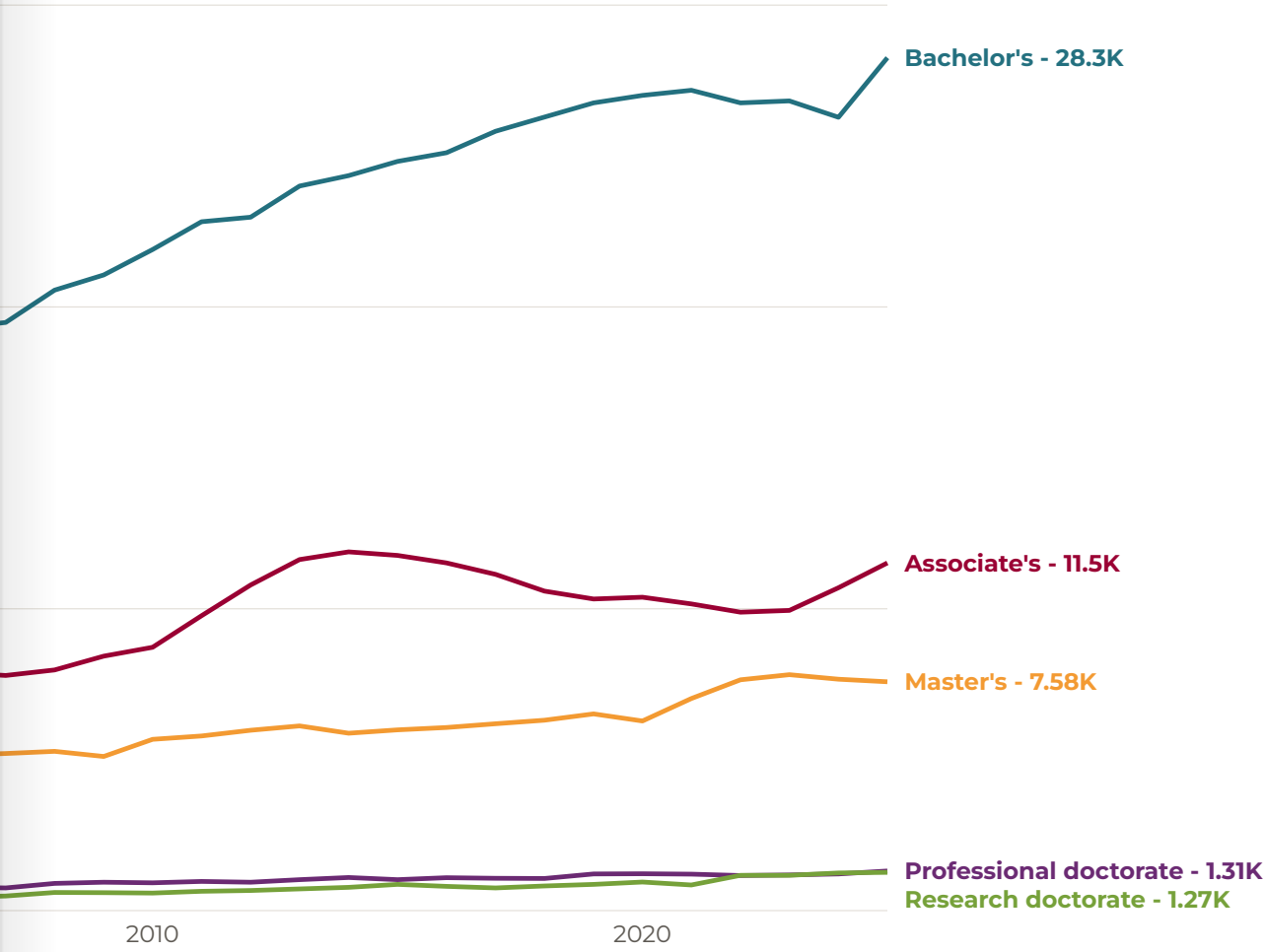
Fields of Study

Figure 27 How Many Degrees Does South Carolina Award?



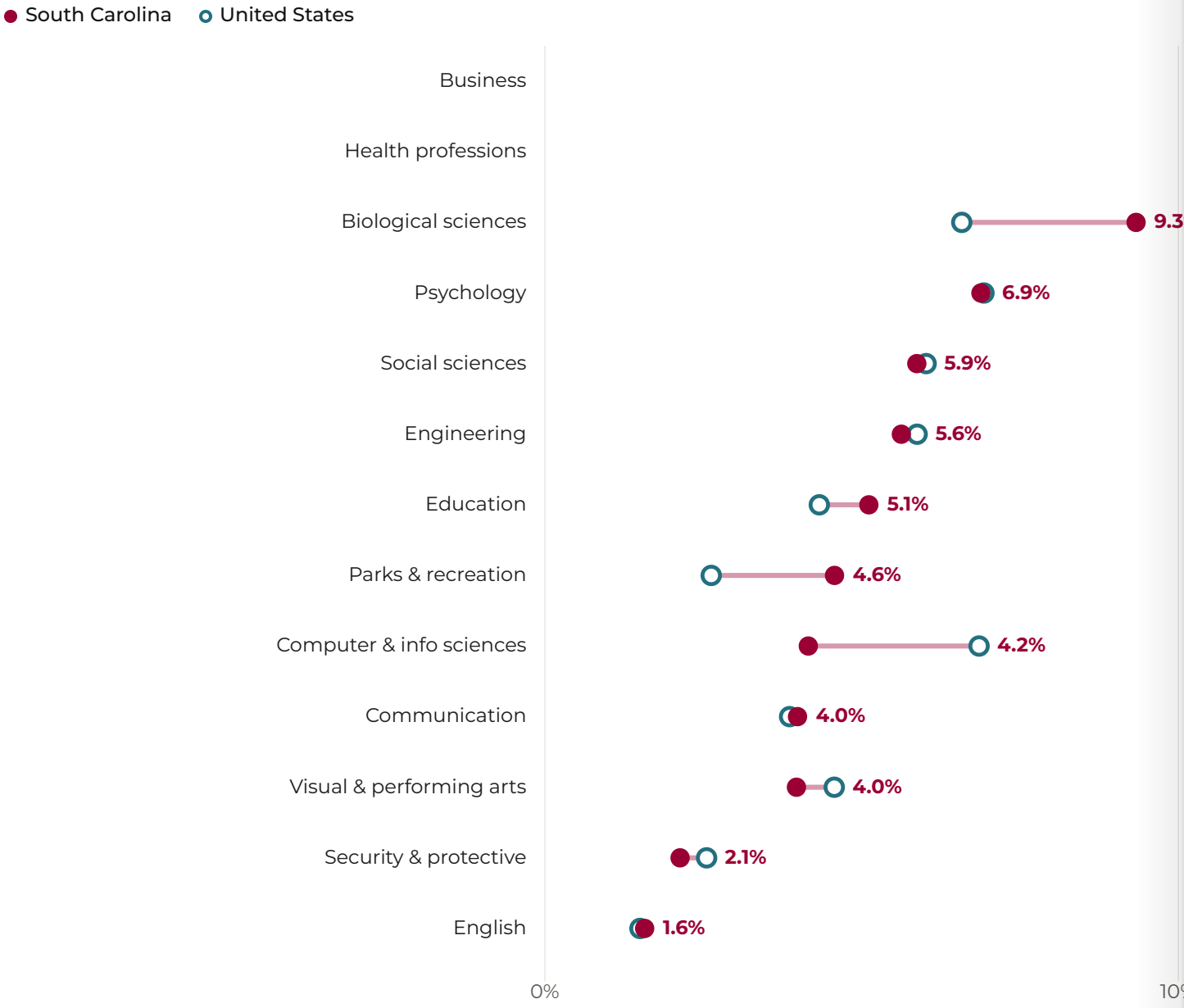
Degrees awarded by level, first majors. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

In 2025, South Carolina's institutions awarded 11.5K associate's degrees, 28.3K bachelor's degrees, 7.58K master's degrees, 1.27K research doctorate degrees, 1.31K professional doctorate degrees.



Since 2015: associate's down 2%; bachelor's up 14%; master's up 27%; research doctorate up 46%; professional doctorate up 28%. The state awards 12.6 bachelor's degrees for every 100 undergraduates (U.S. 12.3).

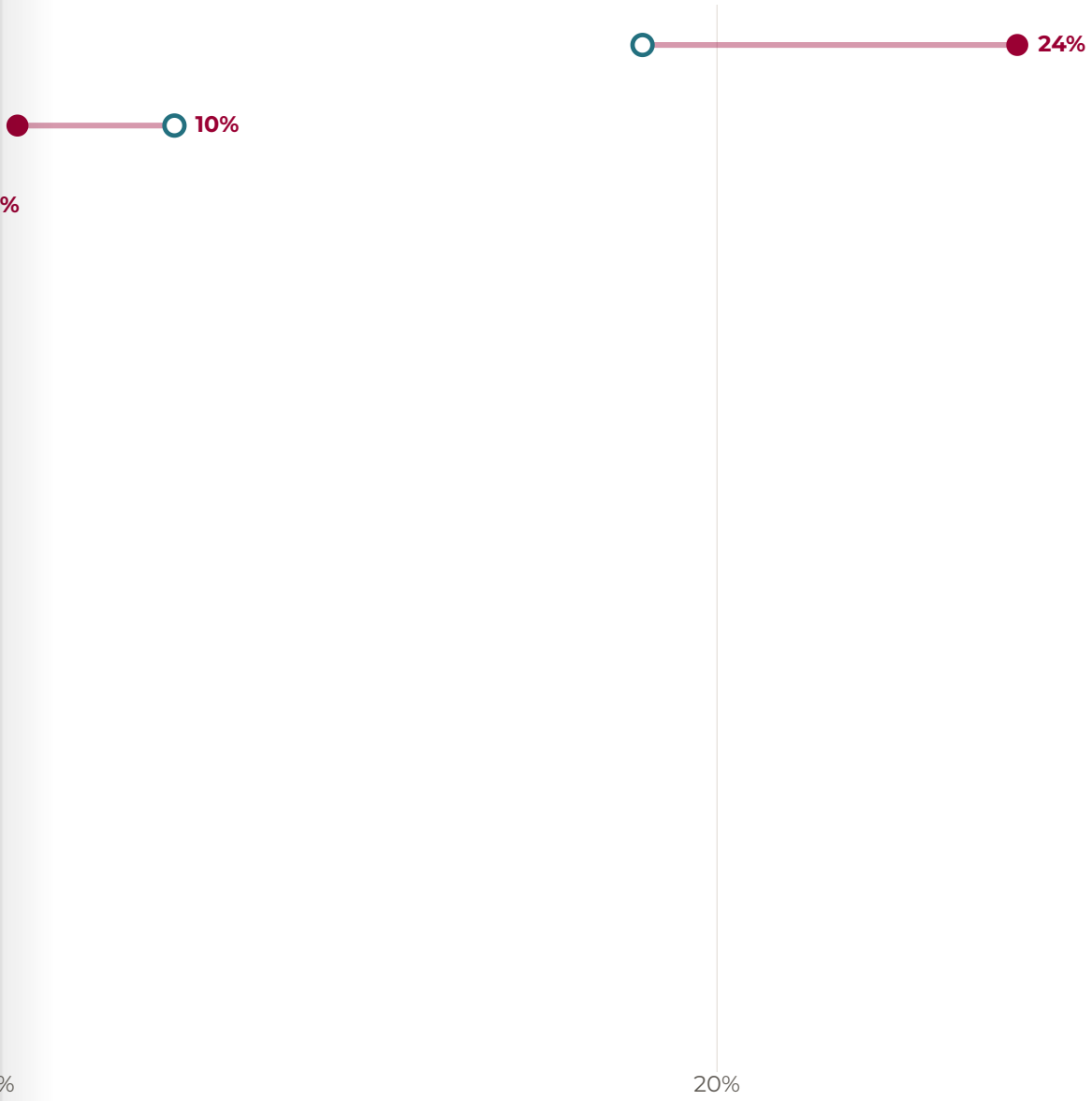
Figure 28 What Do South Carolina's Bachelor's Graduates Study?



Share of bachelor's degrees by field, 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

South Carolina's largest bachelor's fields are business (24%; U.S. 19%), health professions (10%; U.S. 13%), biological sciences (9.3%; U.S. 6.6%).

Relative to the nation, South Carolina's bachelor's degrees are most concentrated in military technologies (5.67× the U.S. share), parks & recreation (1.74× the U.S. share), biological sciences (1.42× the U.S. share).



4.2%

Bachelor's in computer science, 2025

U.S. **6.9%** · **36th** of 51 · +1.7 pp since 2015

6.2%

Bachelor's in engineering, 2025

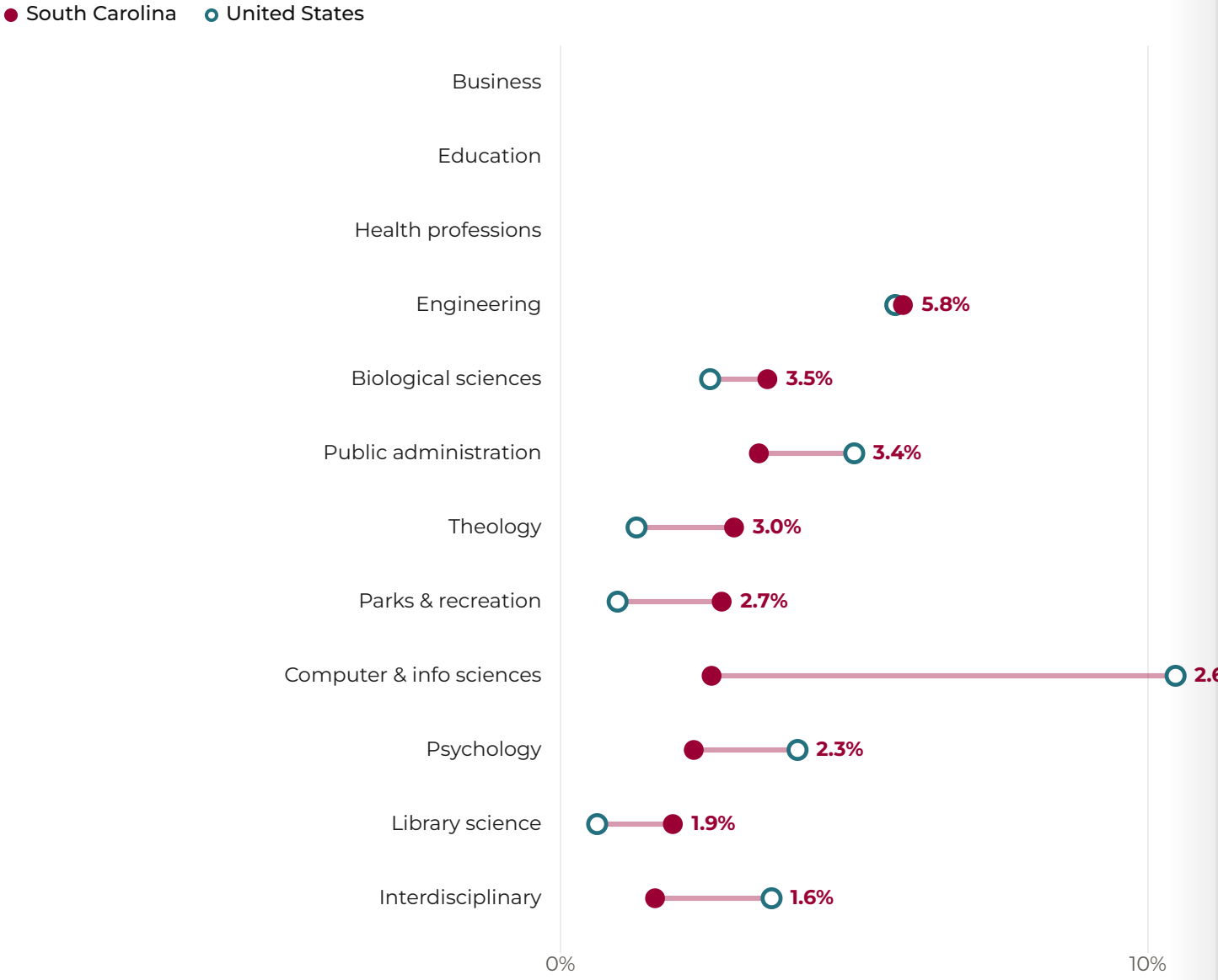
U.S. **6.8%** · **28th** of 51 · +0.9 pp since 2015

24%

Bachelor's in business, 2025

U.S. **19%** · **5th** of 51 · +1.9 pp since 2015

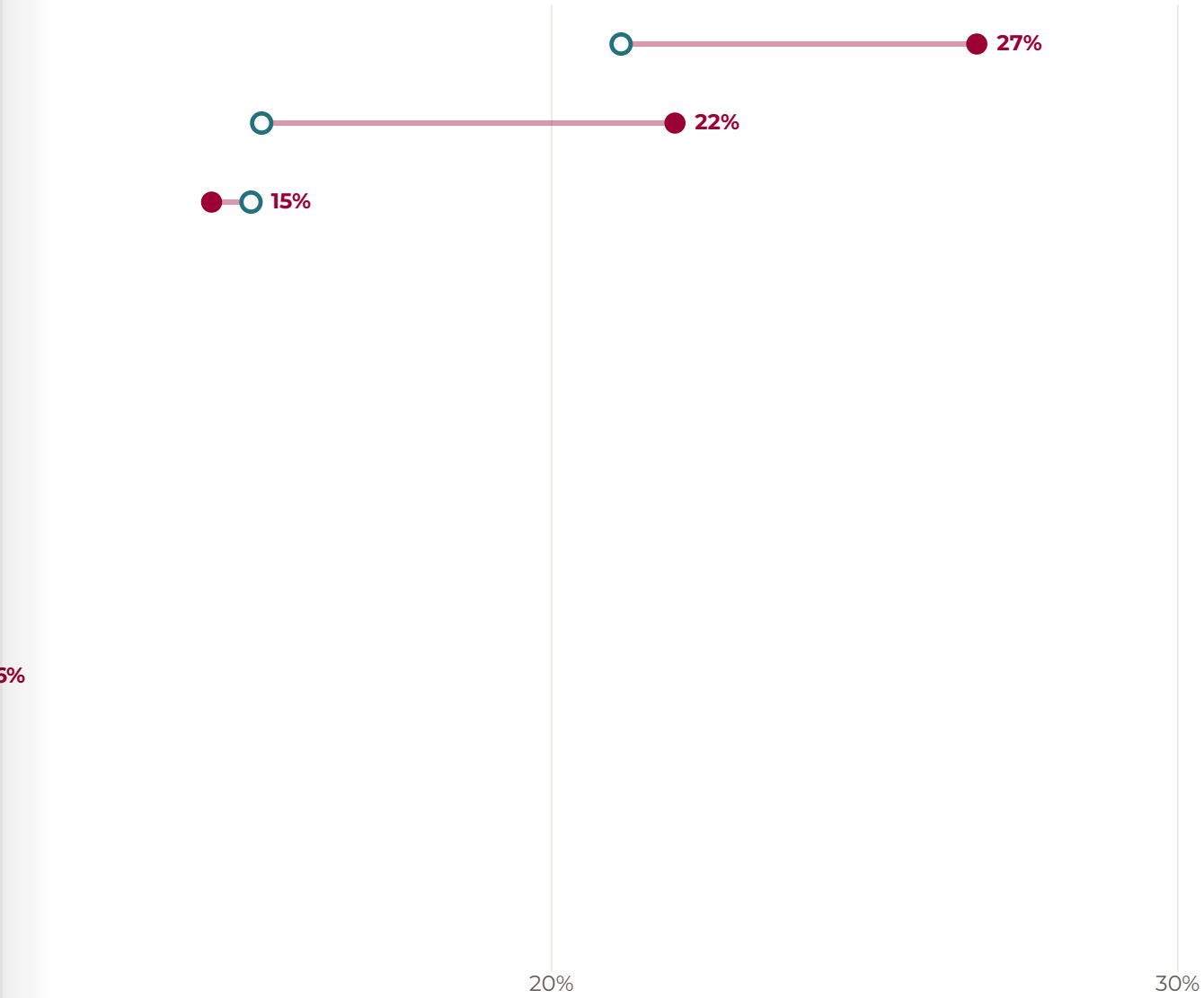
Figure 29 What Do South Carolina's Master's Graduates Study?



Share of master's degrees by field, 2025; largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

South Carolina's largest master's fields are business (27%; U.S. 21%), education (22%; U.S. 15%), health professions (15%; U.S. 15%).

International students earn 12% of all master's degrees in the state (U.S. 22%), and STEM fields account for 16% of them.



16%

STEM share of master's, 2025

U.S. **23%** · **40th** of 51 · +0.8 pp since 2015

12%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

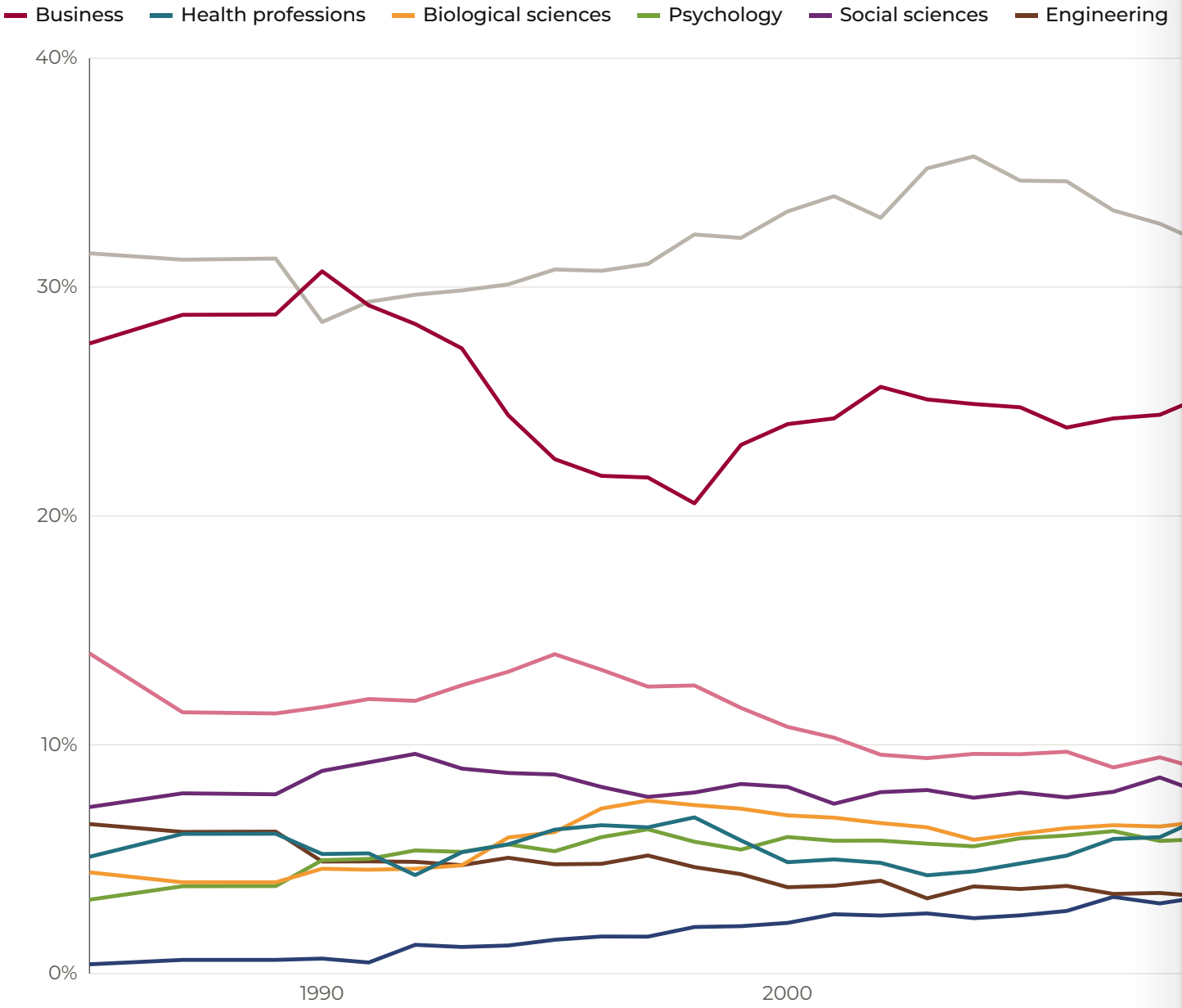
U.S. **22%** · **34th** of 51 · +2.6 pp since 2015

66%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

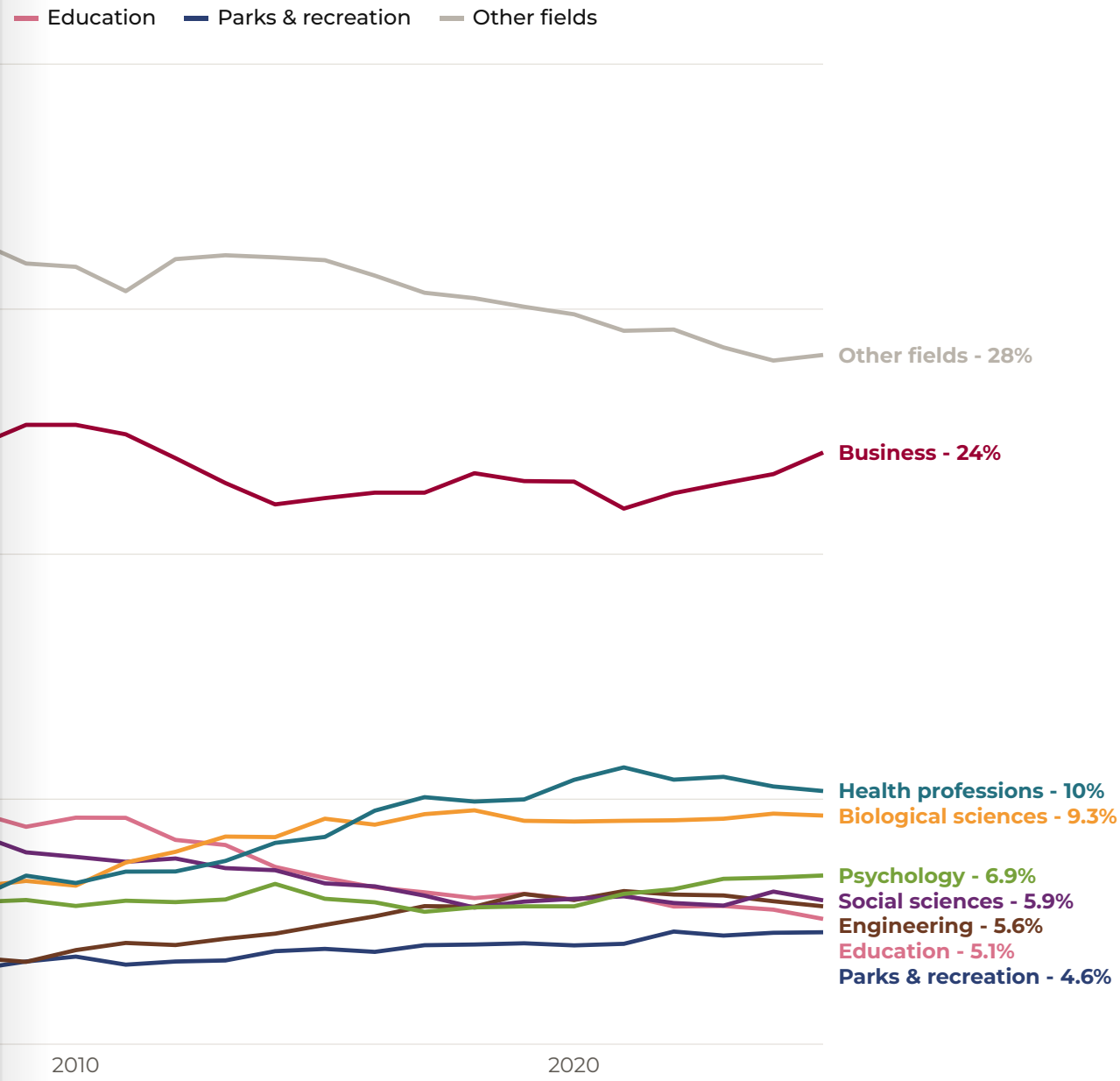
U.S. **65%** · **21st** of 47 · +15.5 pp since 2015

Figure 30 How Has South Carolina's Bachelor's Field Mix Changed?



Share of bachelor's degrees in the largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Since 2015, health professions has gained the most ground, 1.9 points of the state's bachelor's degrees, while education lost the most (1.7 points).



The chart follows the share of bachelor's degrees in each of the state's largest fields; smaller fields are grouped as other fields.

Table 4 Where Is South Carolina Most Specialized?

Field	Location quotient	State share	U.S. share	Degrees
Military technologies	**5.67**	0.5%	0.1%	141
Parks & recreation	**1.74**	4.6%	2.6%	1.29K
Biological sciences	**1.42**	9.3%	6.6%	2.64K
Languages	**1.29**	0.7%	0.6%	211
Business	**1.27**	24%	19%	6.82K
Education	**1.18**	5.1%	4.3%	1.45K
Architecture	**1.17**	0.7%	0.6%	188
Agriculture	**1.16**	1.2%	1.0%	336
History	**1.09**	1.1%	1.0%	318
English	**1.05**	1.6%	1.5%	445

Bachelor's degrees; location quotient = state share ÷ U.S. share; fields with 50+ degrees. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

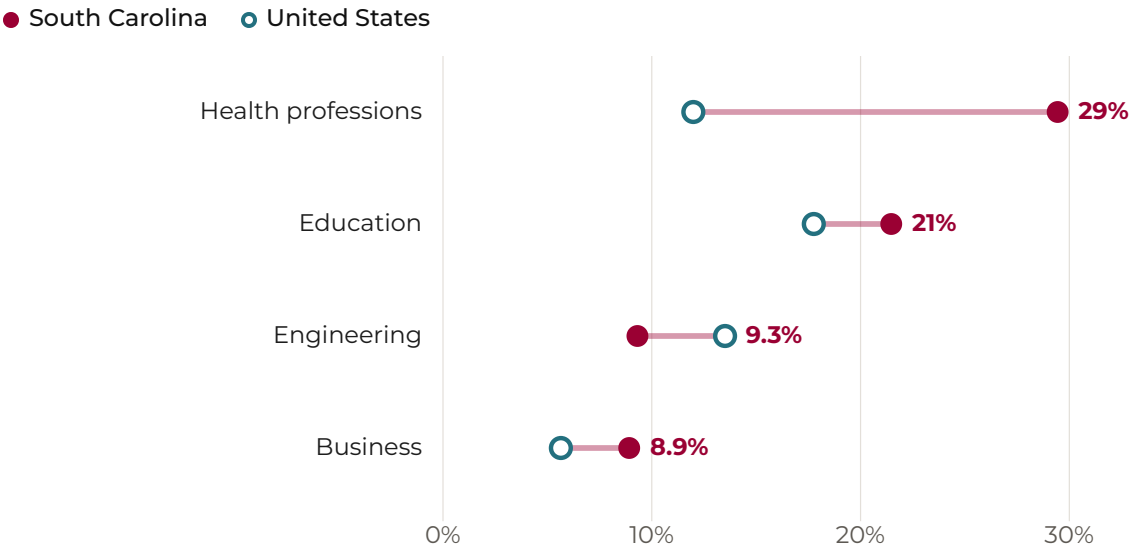
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The location quotient divides a field's share of South Carolina's bachelor's degrees by its share of all U.S. bachelor's degrees in 2025. A quotient of 1.00 means the same share as the nation; 2.00 means twice the national share. The table lists the ten fields with the highest quotients among fields with at least 50 degrees.

THE NUMBERS

- **Highest location quotients**: military technologies 5.67 (0.5% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 0.1%); parks & recreation 1.74 (4.6% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 2.6%); biological sciences 1.42 (9.3% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 6.6%).
- **STEM share of bachelor's degrees**: 23% in 2025 (U.S. 24%; 26th of 51 states), up 0.7 points from 22% in 2024, and up 2.9 points since 2015 (20%).
- **Computer and information sciences**: 4.2% in 2025 (U.S. 6.9%; 36th of 51 states), up 0.5 points from 3.7% in 2024, and up 1.7 points since 2015 (2.4%).
- **Engineering**: 6.2% in 2025 (U.S. 6.8%; 28th of 51 states), down 0.3 points from 6.5% in 2024, and up 0.9 points since 2015 (5.3%).

Figure 31 What Do South Carolina's Doctoral Graduates Study?



Share of research doctorates by field, 2025; fields with 20+ doctorates. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each row is a field's share of the research doctorates awarded in South Carolina in 2025 (filled dot), against its share nationally (open dot), for the ten largest fields with at least 20 doctorates. Research doctorates exclude professional doctorates such as the M.D. and J.D.

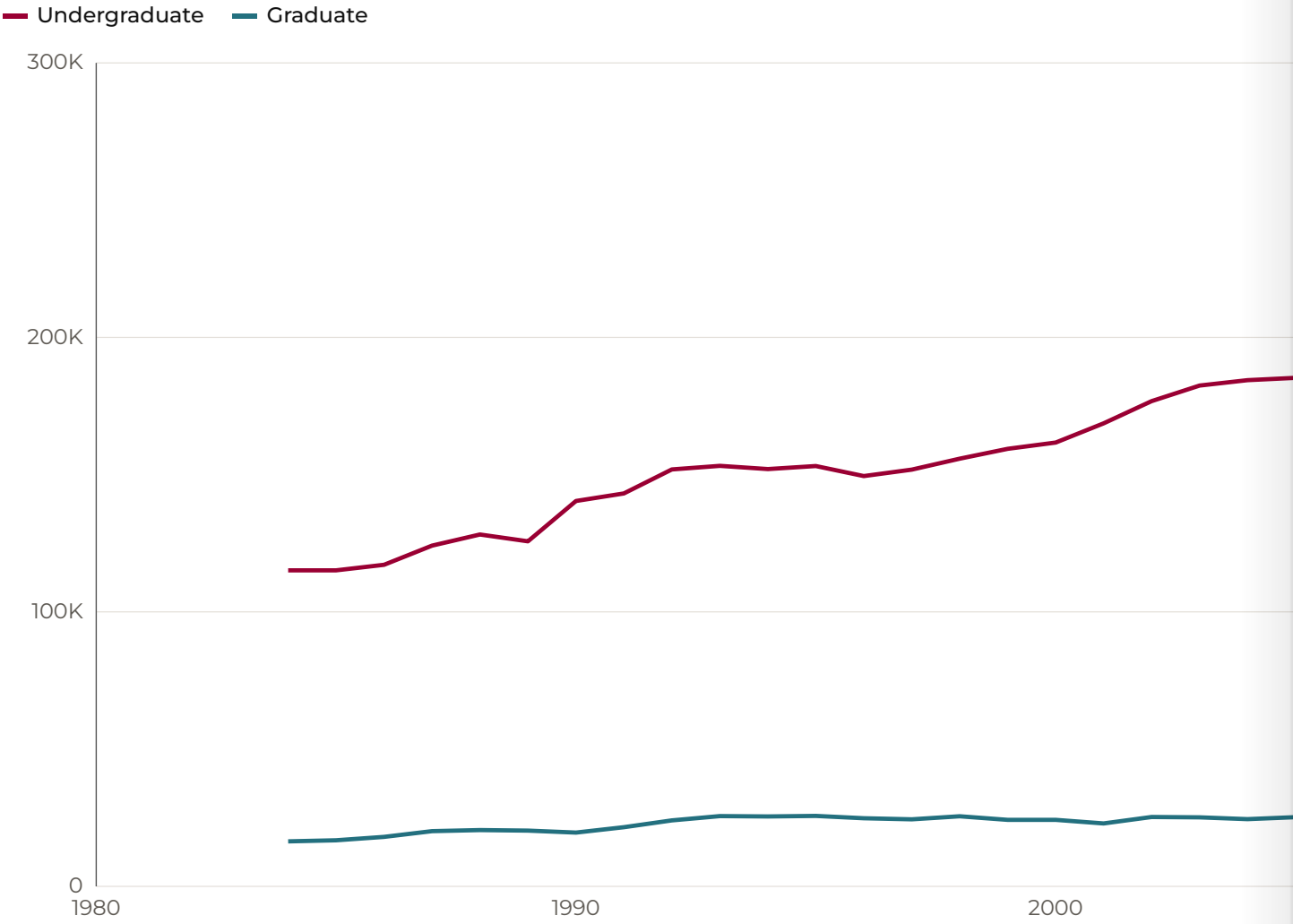
THE NUMBERS

- **Largest doctoral fields**: health professions 29% (U.S. 12%); education 21% (U.S. 18%); engineering 9.3% (U.S. 14%).
- **STEM share of research doctorates**: 25% in 2025 (U.S. 39%; 46th of 51 states), down 4.6 points from 30% in 2024, and down 16.5 points since 2015 (41%).
- **International share of research doctorates**: 17% in 2025 (U.S. 25%; 41st of 51 states), down 1.7 points from 19% in 2024, and down 8.5 points since 2015 (25%).
- **International share of STEM research doctorates**: 41% in 2025 (U.S. 43%; 27th of 51 states), down 2.7 points from 43% in 2024, and down 6.3 points since 2015 (47%).

SECTION 13

Students and Money

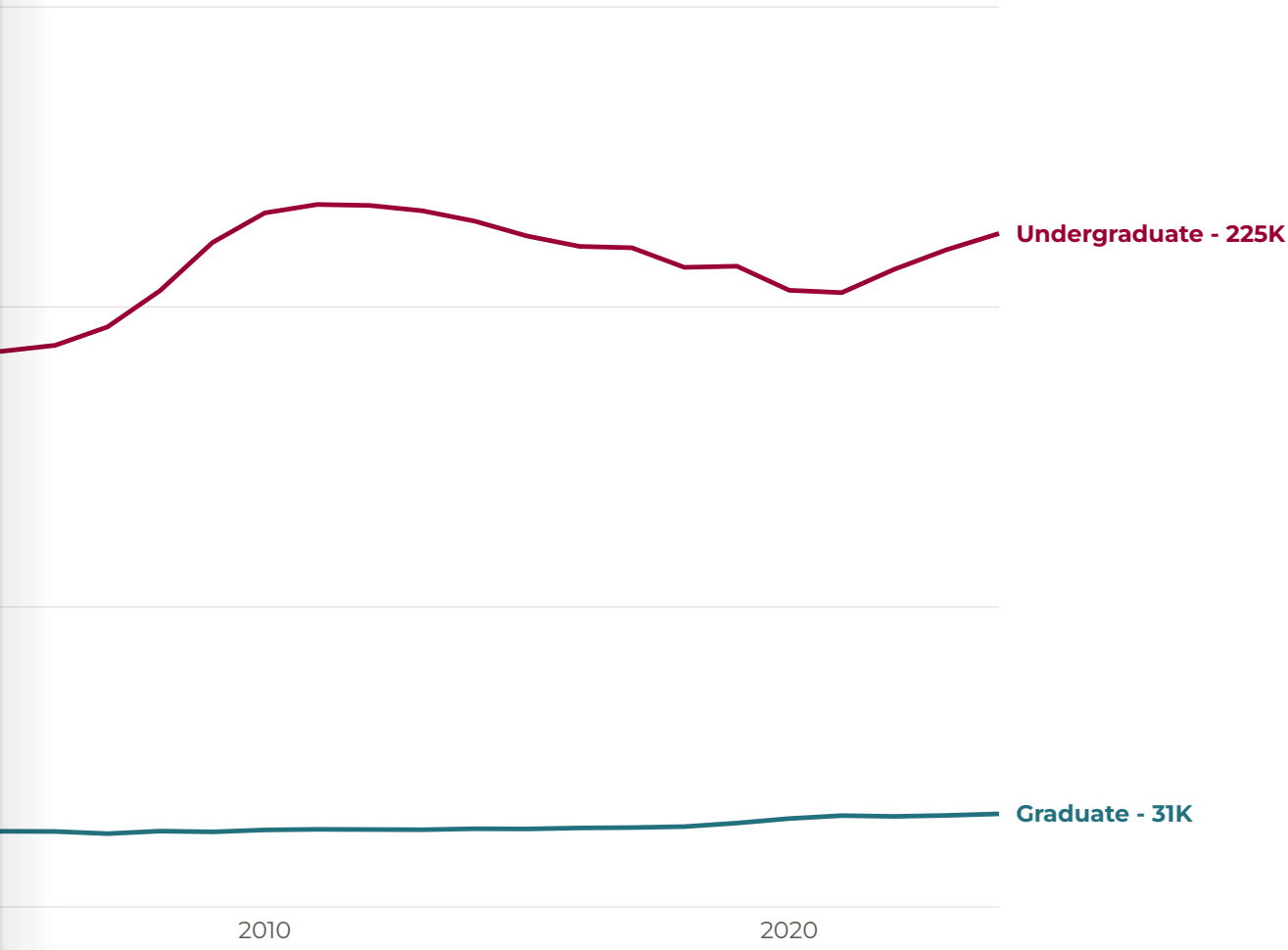
Figure 32 How Has Enrollment Changed?



Fall headcount enrollment. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

In fall 2024, South Carolina enrolled 225K undergraduates and 31K graduate students, 256K in all (26th of 51).

Undergraduate enrollment is roughly flat since 2015 and graduate enrollment up 19% since 2015. Graduate students are 12% of all students (U.S. 17%).



256K

Students enrolled, 2024

U.S. **19.7M** · **26th** of 51 · +2.4% since 2015

12%

Graduate share of students, 2024

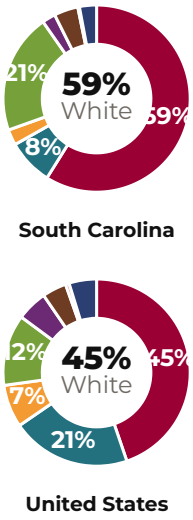
U.S. **17%** · **44th** of 51 · +1.7 pp since 2015

32%

Students attending part-time, 2024

U.S. **39%** · **41st** of 51 · +0.9 pp since 2015

Figure 33 Who Enrolls in South Carolina?



	South Carolina	United States
White	**59%**	45%
Hispanic	**7.9%**	21%
Asian / Pacific Islander	**2.7%**	7.4%
Black	**21%**	12%
International	**2.3%**	5.3%
Two or more	**4.1%**	4.2%
American Indian	**0.3%**	0.6%
Unknown	**2.9%**	4.8%

Share of fall 2024 enrollment by race and ethnicity. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

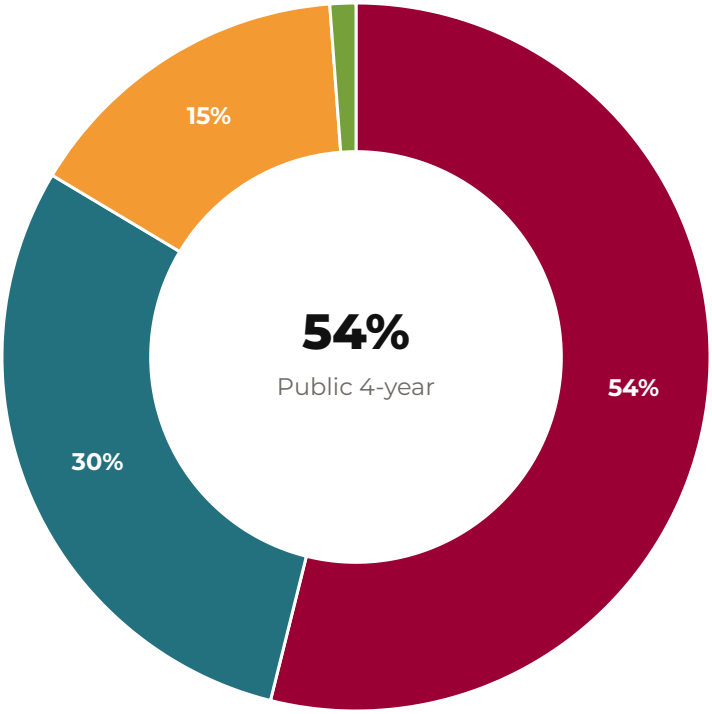
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The rings divide fall 2024 headcount enrollment at South Carolina's degree-granting institutions by race and ethnicity, with the nation for comparison. "International" counts U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, whatever their race; "Unknown" is students whose race was not reported.

THE NUMBERS

- **White**: 59% in fall 2024 (U.S. 45%), down 0.2 points from 59% in fall 2023, and down 2.5 points since fall 2015 (61%).
- **Black**: 21% in fall 2024 (U.S. 12%), down 0.3 points from 21% in fall 2023, and down 4.5 points since fall 2015 (25%).
- **Hispanic**: 7.9% in fall 2024 (U.S. 21%), up 0.6 points from 7.3% in fall 2023, and up 4.0 points since fall 2015 (4.0%).
- **Two or more**: 4.1% in fall 2024 (U.S. 4.2%), up 0.2 points from 3.9% in fall 2023, and up 1.6 points since fall 2015 (2.6%).
- **Unknown**: 2.9% in fall 2024 (U.S. 4.8%), down 0.7 points from 3.6% in fall 2023, and up 0.3 points since fall 2015 (2.6%).

Figure 34 Where Do Students Enroll?



	Share
Public 4-year	54%
Public 2-year	30%
Private nonprofit	15%
For-profit	1.2%

Share of fall 2024 enrollment by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

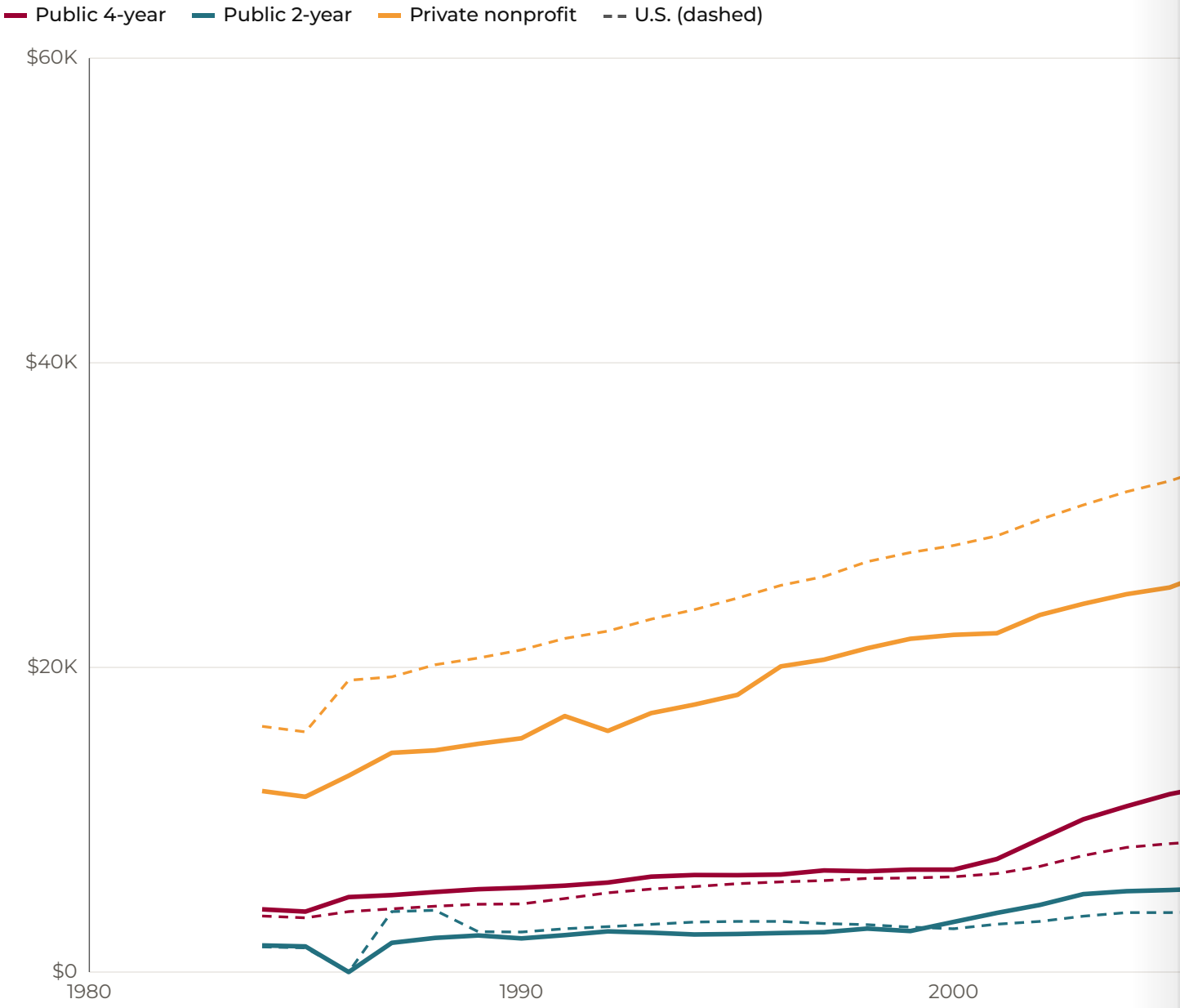
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The ring divides fall 2024 headcount enrollment in South Carolina among public four-year, public two-year, private nonprofit and for-profit institutions.

THE NUMBERS

- **Public 4-year share of enrollment**: 54% in fall 2024, up 0.8 points from 53% in fall 2023, and up 9.1 points since fall 2015 (45%).
- **Public 2-year share of enrollment**: 30% in fall 2024, down 0.1 points from 30% in fall 2023, and down 6.6 points since fall 2015 (36%).
- **Private nonprofit share of enrollment**: 15% in fall 2024, up 0.2 points from 15% in fall 2023, and up 1.4 points since fall 2015 (14%).
- **For-profit share of enrollment**: 1.2% in fall 2024, down 0.9 points from 2.1% in fall 2023, and down 3.8 points since fall 2015 (5.0%).

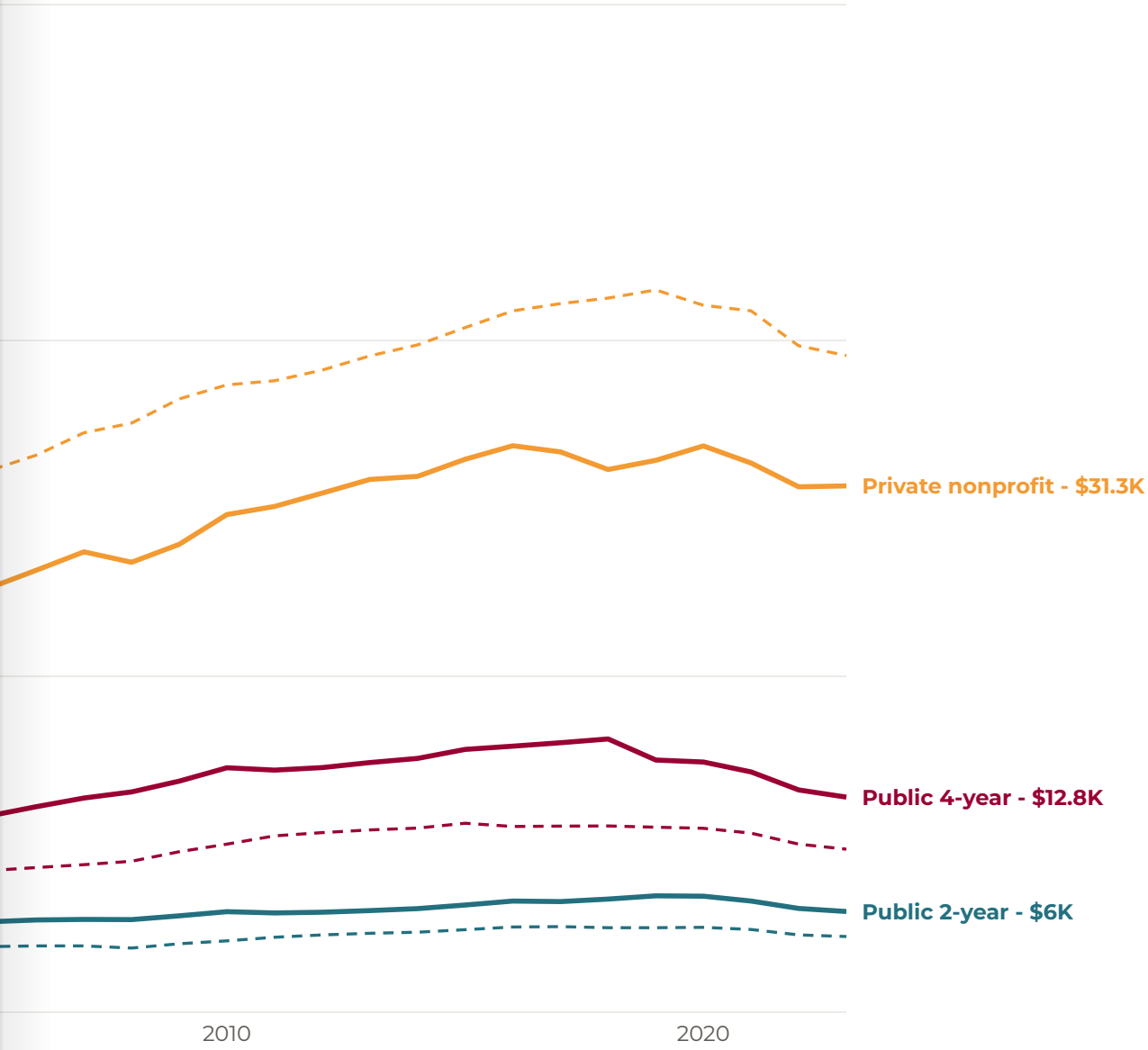
Figure 35 What Does In-State Tuition Cost?



Published in-state tuition and fees, 2024 dollars (CPI-U); state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

In-state tuition and fees at South Carolina's public four-year institutions are $12.8K (2023, 2024 dollars), 32% above the U.S. ($9.71K); the state ranks 12th of 51.

State and local appropriations come to $9.11K per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions (38th of 51), and tuition makes up 57% of their core revenue (U.S. 43%).



$12.8K

In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023

U.S. **$9.71K** · **12th** of 51 · –18% since 2015

$9.11K

Appropriations per student, 2024

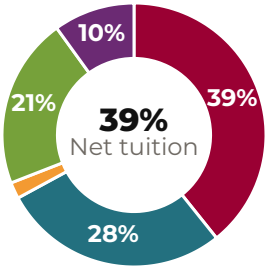
U.S. **$11.4K** · **38th** of 51 · +71% since 2015

57%

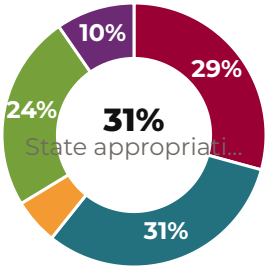
Tuition share of public revenue, 2024

U.S. **43%** · **11th** of 51 · –12.9 pp since 2015

Figure 36 How Are Public Institutions Funded?



South Carolina



United States

	South Carolina	United States
Net tuition	**39%**	29%
State appropriations	**28%**	31%
Local appropriations	**2.0%**	5.6%
Federal grants & appropriations	**21%**	24%
Private gifts & grants	**10.0%**	9.6%

Core revenue per FTE student, public institutions. Data from NCES, IPEDS Finance.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The rings divide the core revenue of South Carolina's public institutions per full-time-equivalent (FTE) student by source, with the nation for comparison. Values are in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Net tuition is tuition and fees after institutional discounts and allowances.

THE NUMBERS

- **Net tuition per FTE student**: $12K in FY2024 (U.S. $8.96K), down 2.0% from $12.2K in FY2023, and down 2.4% since FY2015 ($12.3K).
- **State appropriations per FTE student**: $8.5K in FY2024 (U.S. $9.64K), up 18% from $7.19K in FY2023, and up 78% since FY2015 ($4.78K).
- **Local appropriations per FTE student**: $613 in FY2024 (U.S. $1.71K), down 2.3% from $627 in FY2023, and up 13% since FY2015 ($544).
- **Federal grants & appropriations per FTE student**: $6.4K in FY2024 (U.S. $7.36K), down 6.9% from $6.87K in FY2023, and up 1.3% since FY2015 ($6.31K).

Table 5 Money and Results

Measure	Year	South Carolina	U.S.	Rank	Change since 2015
In-state tuition, public 4-year	2023	**$12.8K**	$9.71K	12th of 51	−18%
Appropriations per student	2024	**$9.11K**	$11.4K	38th of 51	+71%
Tuition share of public revenue	2024	**57%**	43%	11th of 51	−12.9 pp
Six-year graduation rate	2024	**62%**	65%	24th of 51	+5.8 pp
Average faculty salary	2024	**$83.9K**	$106K	40th of 51	−7.5%

Rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Dollars in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The table brings together five measures of what public higher education costs and what it produces in South Carolina: in-state tuition at public four-year institutions, state and local appropriations per full-time-equivalent student, tuition's share of public institutions' core revenue, the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, and the average full-time faculty salary.

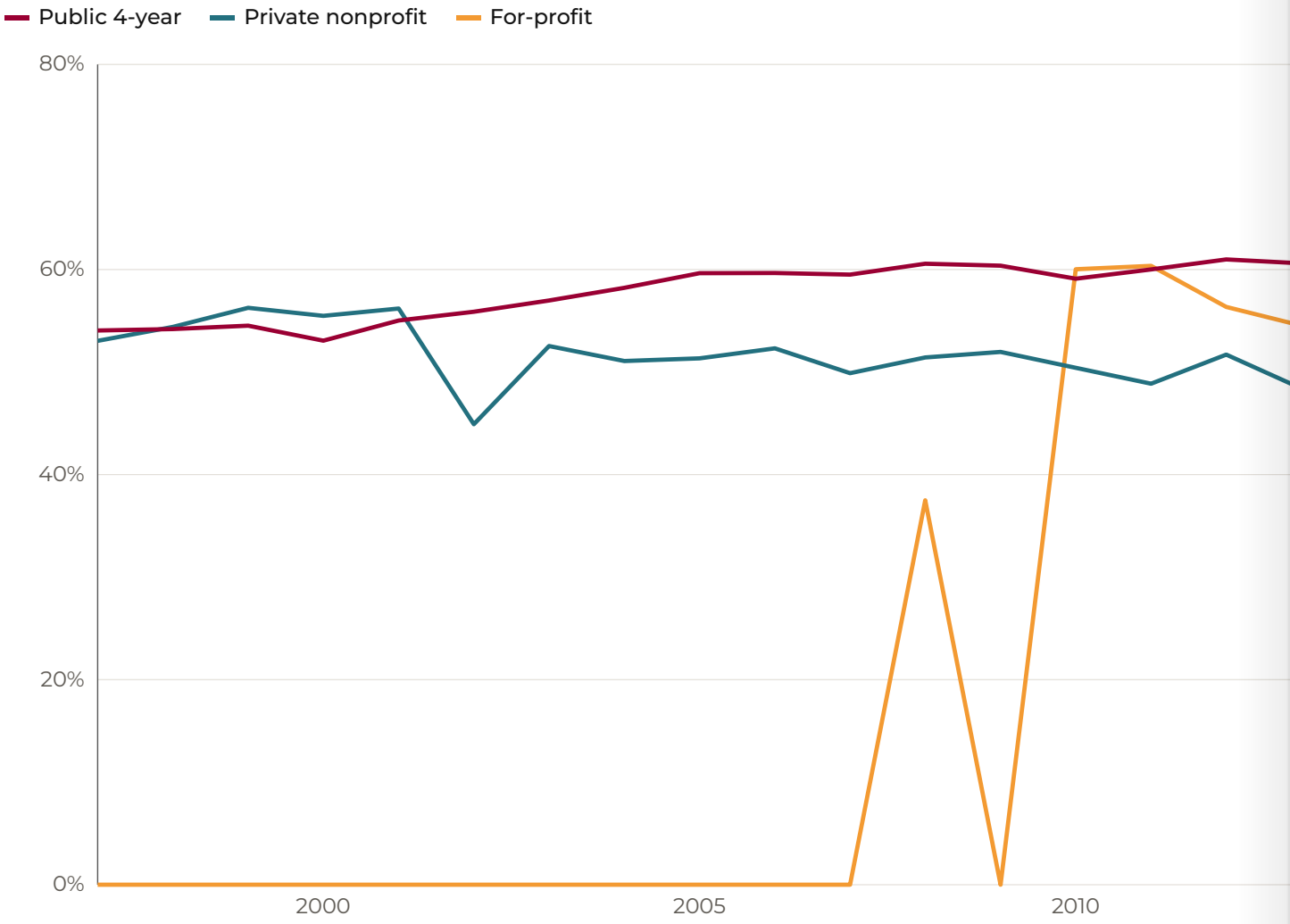
THE NUMBERS

- **In-state tuition, public 4-year**: $12.8K in 2023 (U.S. $9.71K; 12th of 51 states), down 3.3% from $13.2K in 2022, and down 18% since 2015 ($15.7K).
- **Appropriations per student**: $9.11K in 2024 (U.S. $11.4K; 38th of 51 states), up 17% from $7.82K in 2023, and up 71% since 2015 ($5.33K).
- **Tuition share of public revenue**: 57% in 2024 (U.S. 43%; 11th of 51 states), down 4.2 points from 61% in 2023, and down 12.9 points since 2015 (70%).
- **Six-year graduation rate**: 62% in 2024 (U.S. 65%; 24th of 51 states), down 0.2 points from 63% in 2023, and up 5.8 points since 2015 (57%).

SECTION 14

Student Outcomes

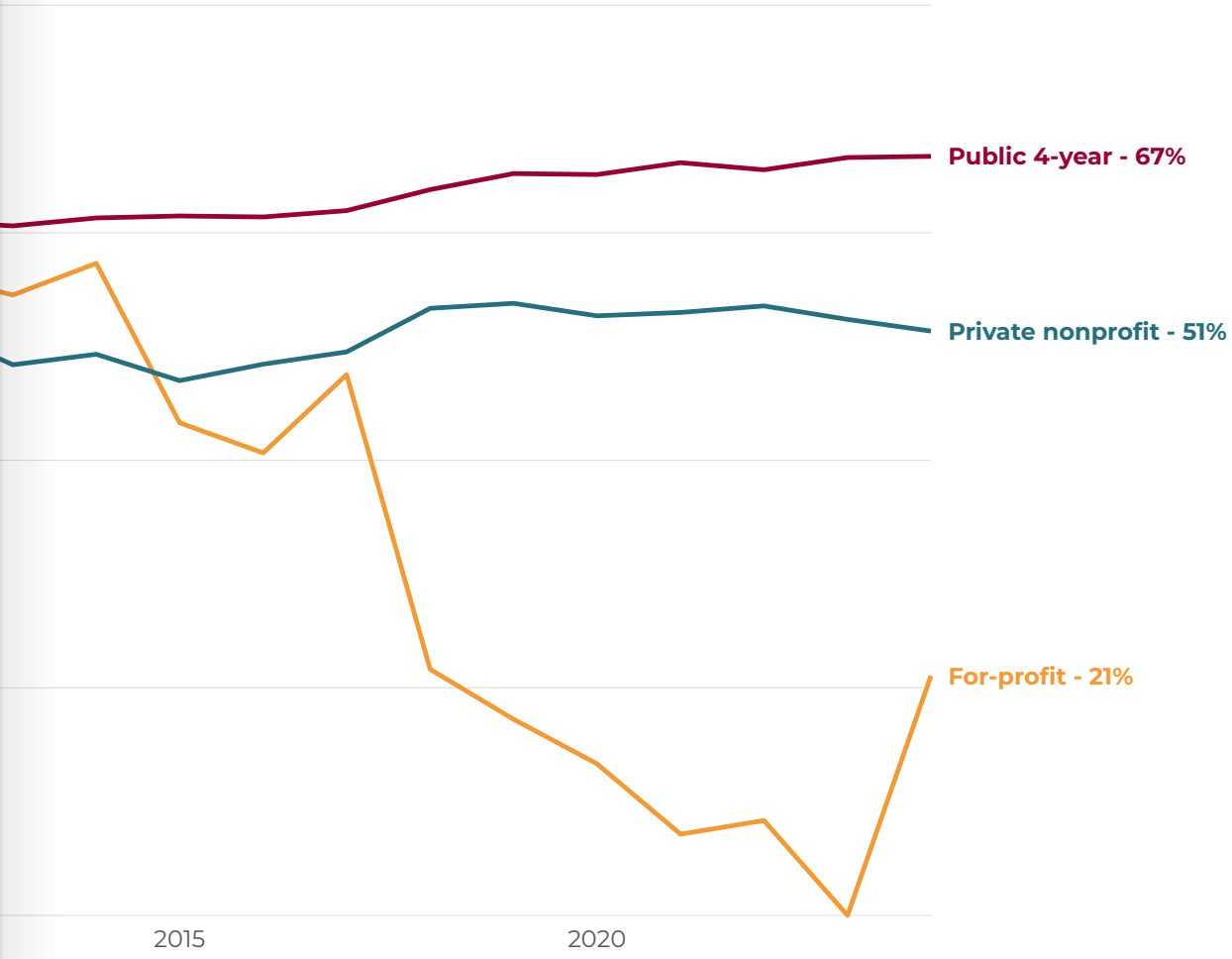
Figure 37 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Sector?



Six-year bachelor's graduation rate by sector of institution. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

62% of students who started a bachelor's degree at a four-year institution in South Carolina graduated within six years (2024), 2.3 points below the U.S. (65%); the state ranks 24th of 51.

By sector: public 4-year 67%, private nonprofit 51%, for-profit 21%. At two-year institutions, 34% complete within 150% of normal time (U.S. 41%).



62%

Six-year graduation rate, 2024

U.S. **65%** · **24th** of 51 · +5.8 pp since 2015

34%

Two-year completion rate, 2024

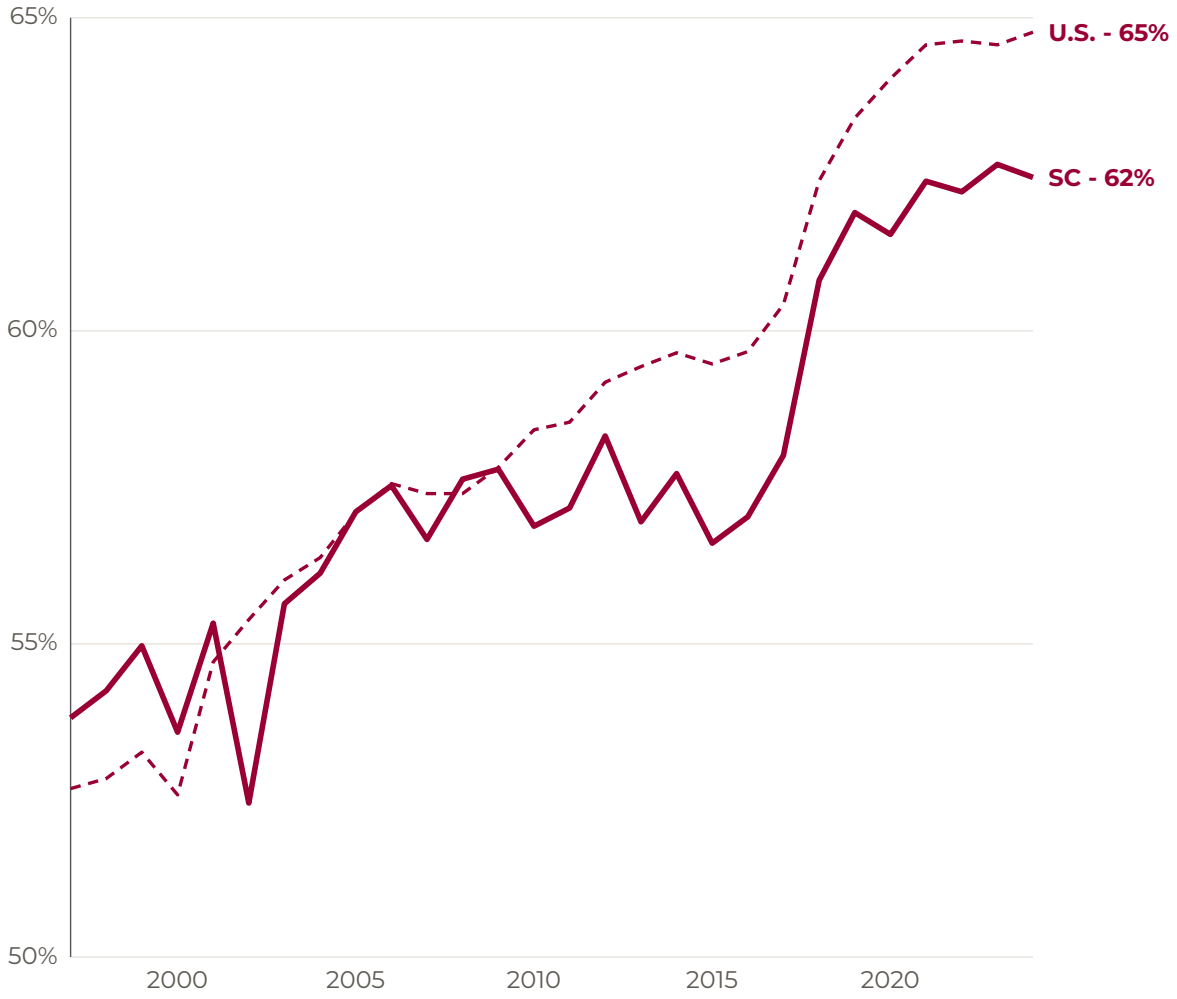
U.S. **41%** · **35th** of 50 · +18.2 pp since 2015

12.6

Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025

U.S. **12.3** · **26th** of 51 · +1.7 since 2015

Figure 38 Six-Year Bachelor's Graduation Rate



Four-year institutions; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

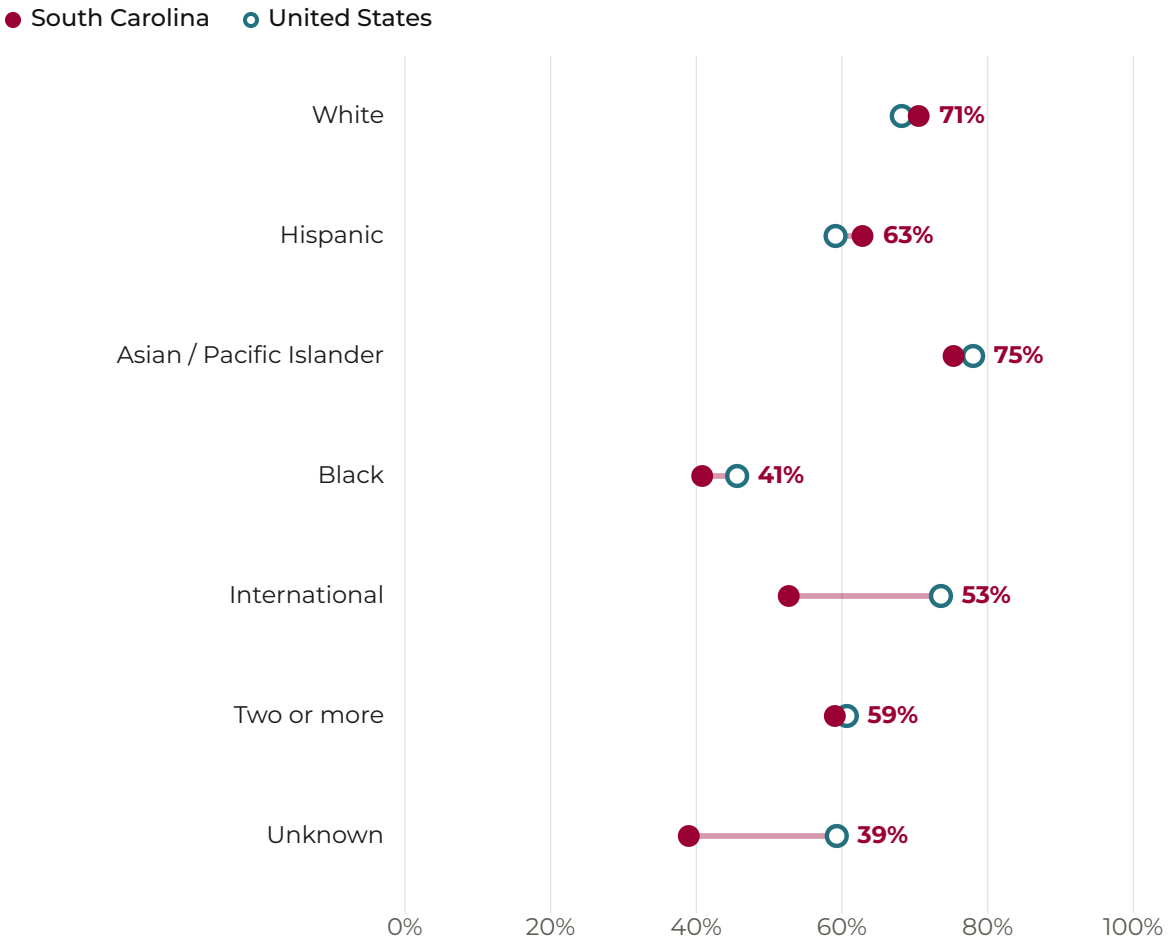
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The line follows the share of first-time, full-time bachelor's-degree students at South Carolina's four-year institutions who graduated from the institution where they started within six years (150% of normal time). Each year is the cohort that entered six years earlier. The state is solid and the United States dashed.

THE NUMBERS

- **Six-year graduation rate**: 62% in 2024 (U.S. 65%), down 0.2 points from 63% in 2023, and up 5.8 points since 2015 (57%).
- **Public 4-year institutions**: 67% in 2024, up 0.1 points from 67% in 2023, and up 5.2 points since 2015 (61%).
- **Private nonprofit institutions**: 51% in 2024, down 1.0 point from 52% in 2023, and up 4.4 points since 2015 (47%).
- **For-profit institutions**: 21% in 2024, up 21.1 points from 0.0% in 2023, and down 22.2 points since 2015 (43%).
- **Two-year institutions, completion within 150% of normal time**: 34% in 2024 (U.S. 41%), up 2.5 points from 32% in 2023, and up 18.2 points since 2015 (16%).

Figure 39 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Race and Ethnicity?



Six-year rate, 2024; groups with 100+ students. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Each row is the six-year bachelor's graduation rate for one racial or ethnic group of students at South Carolina's four-year institutions (filled dot), against the national rate for the same group (open dot). Groups with fewer than 100 students in the cohort are left out.

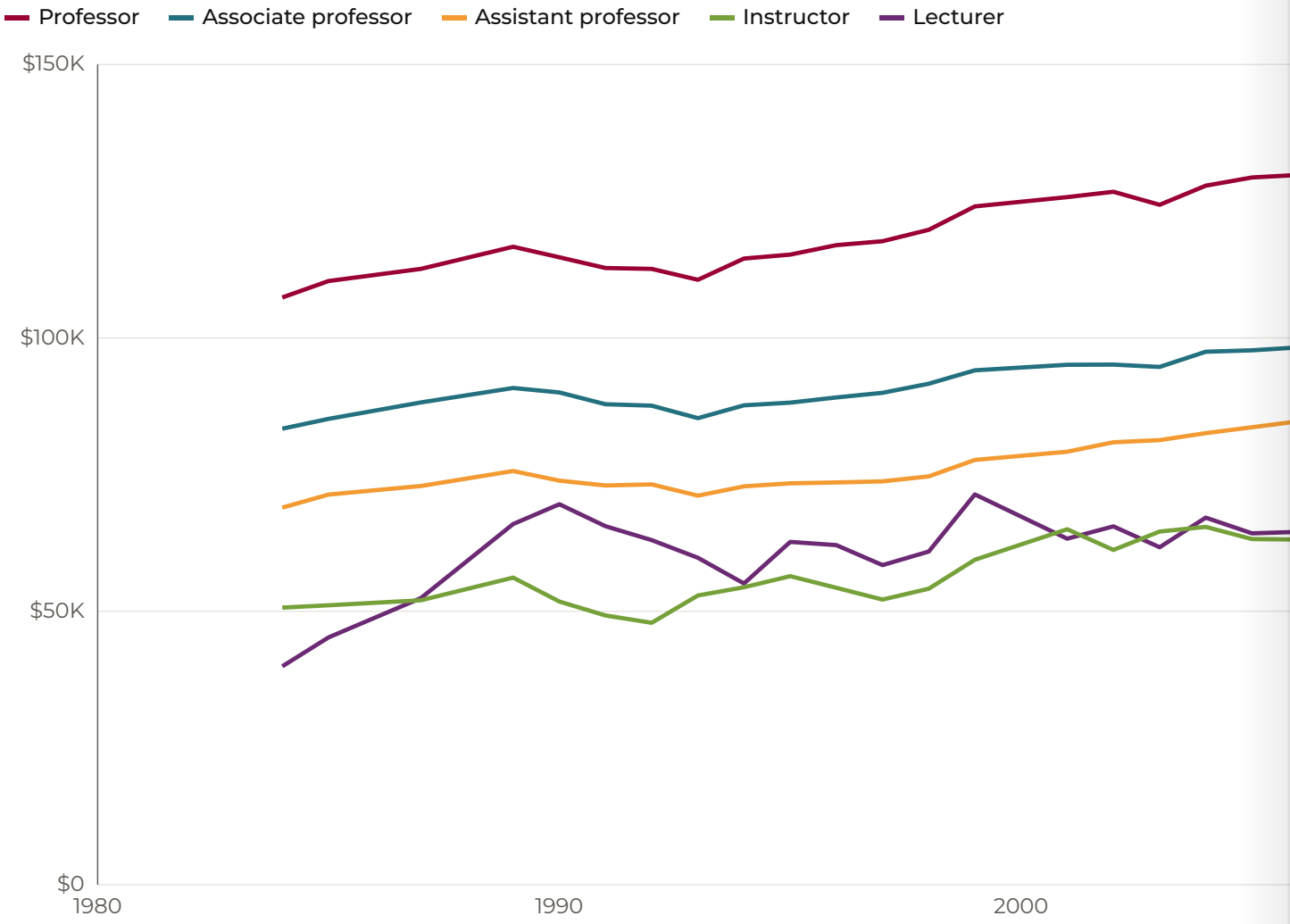
THE NUMBERS

- **White**: 71% in 2024 (U.S. 68%).
- **Hispanic**: 63% in 2024 (U.S. 59%).
- **Asian / Pacific Islander**: 75% in 2024 (U.S. 78%).
- **Black**: 41% in 2024 (U.S. 46%).
- **International**: 53% in 2024 (U.S. 74%).
- **Two or more**: 59% in 2024 (U.S. 61%).
- **Unknown**: 39% in 2024 (U.S. 59%).

SECTION 15

Faculty

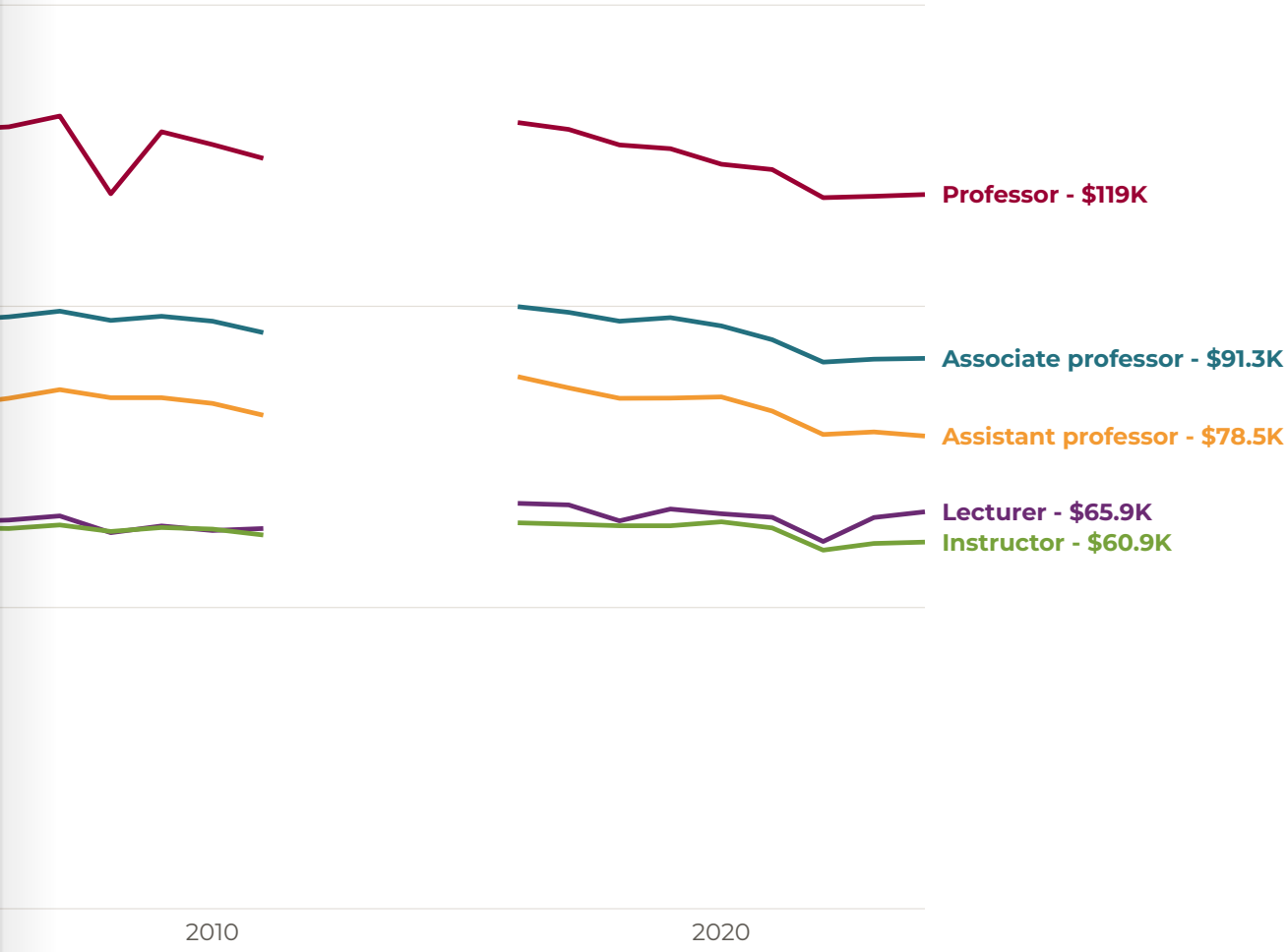
Figure 40 What Do South Carolina's Faculty Earn, by Rank?



Average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts, by academic rank, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data fro

Full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts at South Carolina's institutions earned an average of $83.9K in 2024 (2024 dollars), 21% below the U.S. ($106K); the state ranks 40th of 51. By rank (2024): professors $119K, associate professors $91.3K, assistant professors $78.5K, instructors $60.9K, lecturers $65.9K.

South Carolina's institutions had 10.3K full-time instructional staff in 2024, up 9% since 2015. Average salary across all ranks is down 8% since 2016.



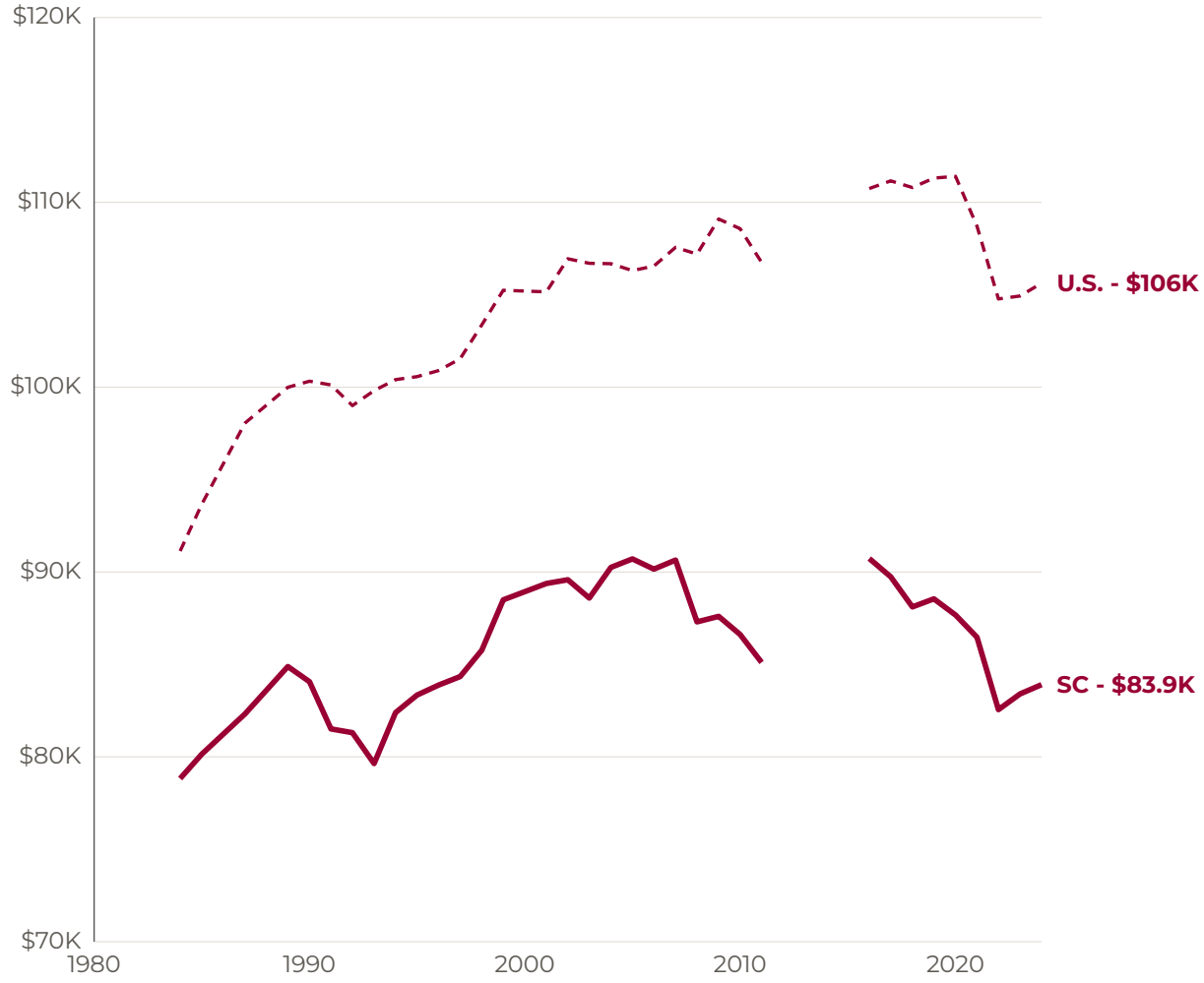
m NCES, IPEDS Human Resources.

$83.9K

Average faculty salary, 2024

U.S. **$106K** · **40th** of 51 · −7.5% since 2016

Figure 41 Average Faculty Salary



Full-time instructional faculty, 9/10-month, 2024 dollars. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

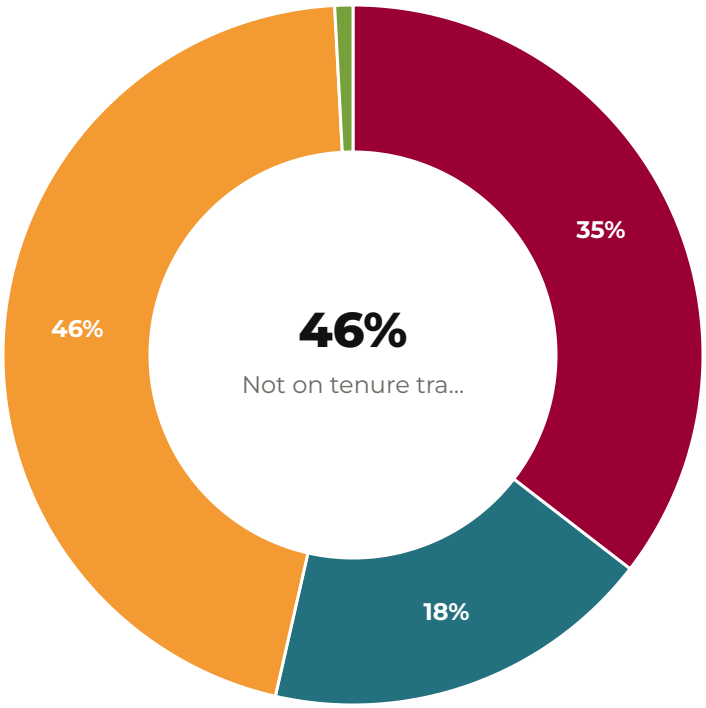
ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The line follows the average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9- or 10-month contracts at South Carolina's degree-granting institutions, all ranks combined, in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). The state is solid and the United States dashed.

THE NUMBERS

- **Average salary**: $83.9K in 2024 (U.S. $106K), up 0.6% from $83.4K in 2023, and down 7.5% since 2016 ($90.7K).
- **State rank on average salary**: $83.9K in 2024 (U.S. $106K; 40th of 51 states), up 0.6% from $83.4K in 2023, and down 7.5% since 2016 ($90.7K).
- **Full-time instructional staff**: 10.3K in 2024, up 1.6% from 10.1K in 2023, and up 8.6% since 2015 (9.46K).
- **Professors, average salary**: $119K in 2024, up 0.2% from $118K in 2023, and down 9.2% since 2016 ($131K).
- **Associate professors, average salary**: $91.3K in 2024, up 0.1% from $91.2K in 2023, and down 8.6% since 2016 ($99.9K).
- **Assistant professors, average salary**: $78.5K in 2024, down 0.9% from $79.1K in 2023, and down 11% since 2016 ($88.3K).

Figure 42 Tenure Status



	Share
Tenured	35%
On tenure track	18%
Not on tenure track	46%
No faculty status	0.8%

Full-time instructional staff, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

The ring divides South Carolina's full-time instructional staff in 2024 by tenure status: tenured, on the tenure track, not on the tenure track (for example, lecturers on fixed-term contracts), and staff at institutions with no tenure system.

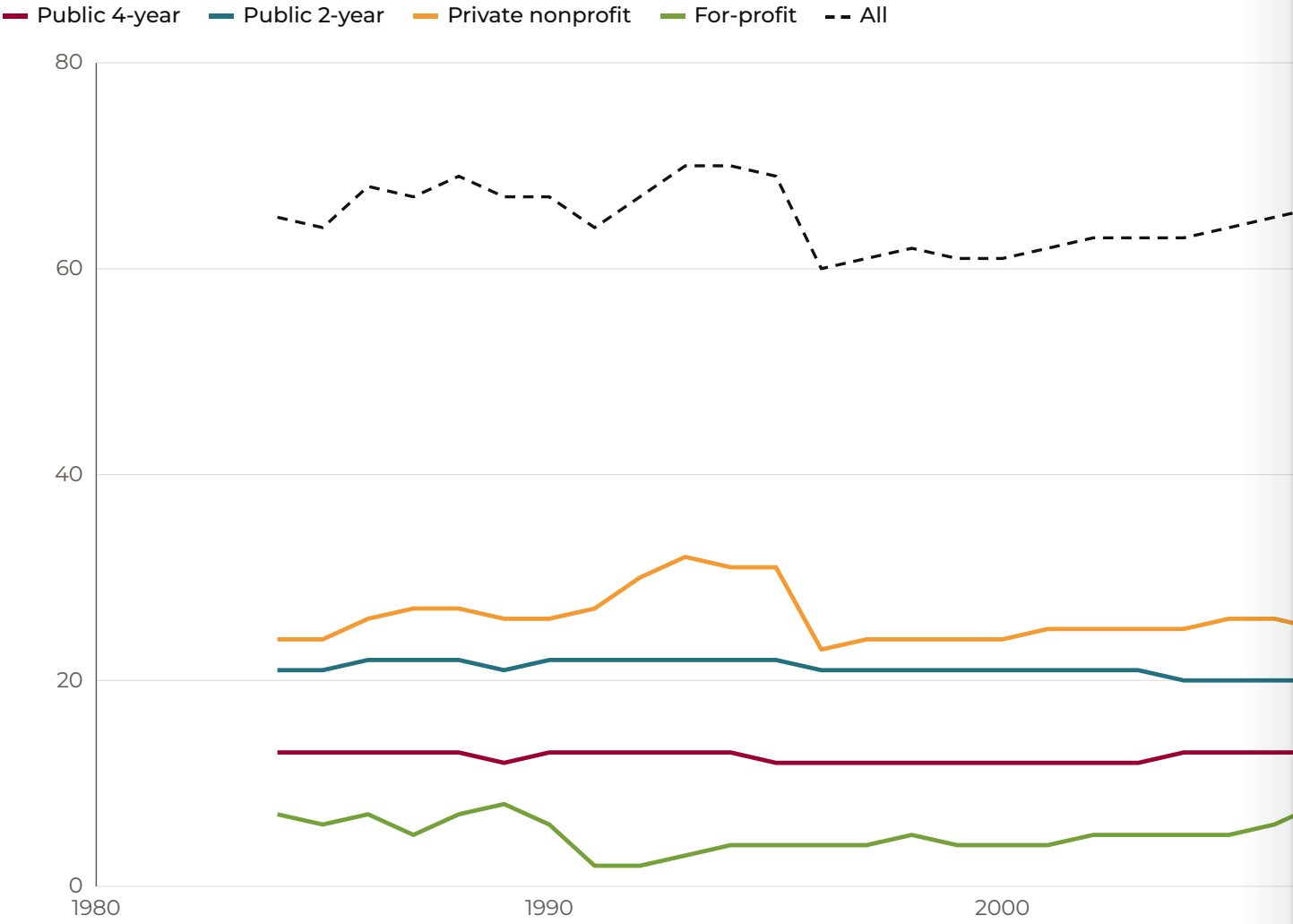
THE NUMBERS

- **Tenured, share of full-time instructional staff**: 35% in 2024, down 0.4 points from 36% in 2023, and unchanged since 2015 (35%).
- **On tenure track, share of full-time instructional staff**: 18% in 2024, unchanged from 18% in 2023, and up 0.1 points since 2015 (18%).
- **Not on tenure track, share of full-time instructional staff**: 46% in 2024, up 0.1 points from 45% in 2023, and up 0.1 points since 2015 (45%).
- **No faculty status, share of full-time instructional staff**: 0.8% in 2024, up 0.3 points from 0.5% in 2023, and down 0.2 points since 2015 (1.1%).

SECTION 16

Institutions

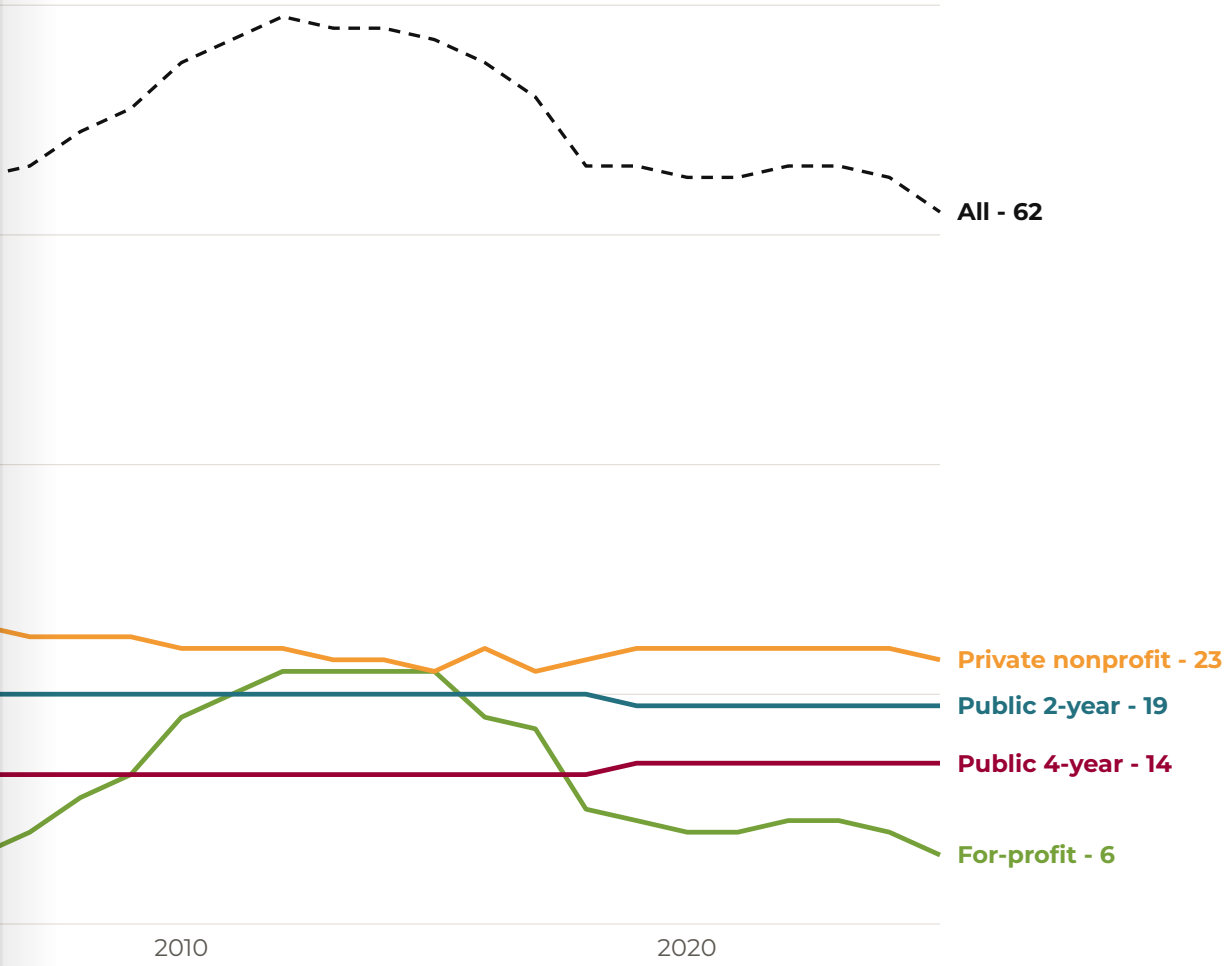
Figure 43 How Many Institutions Does South Carolina Have?



Degree-granting institutions by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

South Carolina has 62 degree-granting institutions: 14 public 4-year, 19 public 2-year, 23 private nonprofit, 6 for-profit (2025).

The number of institutions is down 19% since 2015. 84% of students attend public institutions and 1.2% attend for-profit ones.



84%

Students at public institutions, 2024

U.S. **73%** · **19th** of 51 · +2.5 pp since 2015

1.2%

Students at for-profit institutions, 2024

U.S. **5.5%** · **30th** of 51 · −3.8 pp since 2015

21%

Students fully online, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **37th** of 51 · +11.9 pp since 2015

Table 6 Which Institutions Train the Most International STEM Graduates?

Institution	Intl STEM master's	Int. share	Intl STEM doctorates	Int. share
Clemson University Clemson · Public 4-year	**368**	47%	77	41%
University of South Carolina-Columbia Columbia · Public 4-year	**66**	35%	51	49%
Anderson University Anderson · Private nonprofit	**18**	100%	–	–
Claflin University Orangeburg · Private nonprofit	**5**	45%	–	–
Charleston Southern University Charleston · Private nonprofit	**2**	33%	–	–
College of Charleston Charleston · Public 4-year	**1**	2.3%	–	–
Coastal Carolina University Conway · Public 4-year	**1**	5.9%	–	–
Medical University of South Carolina Charleston · Public 4-year	**1**	2.4%	–	–%

Degrees awarded in 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

Institutions in South Carolina ranked by the STEM master's and research doctorates they awarded to international students in 2025. The share columns give international students' share of each institution's STEM degrees at that level.

THE NUMBERS

- **Largest**: Clemson University (368 international STEM master's, 77 doctorates); University of South Carolina-Columbia (66 international STEM master's, 51 doctorates); Anderson University (18 international STEM master's, – doctorates).
- **International STEM master's degrees, all institutions**: 462 in 2025 (U.S. 117K; 35th of 51 states), down 1.3% from 468 in 2024, and up 53% since 2015 (302).
- **International share of STEM research doctorates**: 41% in 2025 (U.S. 43%; 27th of 51 states), down 2.7 points from 43% in 2024, and down 6.3 points since 2015 (47%).

Table 7 What Are South Carolina's Largest Institutions?

Institution	Enrollment	Int. share, grad	STEM bachelor's	Six-year grad rate	Admit rate
University of South Carolina-Columbia	**38.5K**	14%	1.61K	79%	60%
Clemson University	**29.1K**	26%	2.2K	87%	38%
Trident Technical College	**13.6K**	–	–	–	–
Greenville Technical College	**12K**	–	28	–	–
College of Charleston	**11.9K**	4.1%	466	66%	60%
Coastal Carolina University	**11.3K**	4.7%	314	48%	75%
Midlands Technical College	**9.23K**	–	–	–	–
Horry-Georgetown Technical College	**7.92K**	–	–	–	–
Spartanburg Community College	**6.65K**	–	–	–	–
Tri-County Technical College	**5.89K**	–	–	–	–
Piedmont Technical College	**5.14K**	–	–	–	–
University of South Carolina-Upstate	**4.92K**	5.1%	201	43%	67%
Winthrop University	**4.89K**	1.6%	116	57%	79%
York Technical College	**4.77K**	–	–	–	–
Anderson University	**4.71K**	–	119	66%	55%

Fall 2024 enrollment; degrees 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

ABOUT THIS FIGURE

South Carolina's largest degree-granting institutions by fall 2024 headcount enrollment, with the international share of graduate students, STEM bachelor's degrees awarded in 2025, the six-year graduation rate and the admission rate (a dash where the institution admits all applicants or does not report one).

THE NUMBERS

- **Largest**: University of South Carolina-Columbia (38.5K students); Clemson University (29.1K students); Trident Technical College (13.6K students).
- **Degree-granting institutions**: 62.
- **Share of students at public institutions**: 84% in 2024 (U.S. 73%; 19th of 51 states), up 0.7 points from 83% in 2023, and up 2.5 points since 2015 (81%).
- **Share at for-profit institutions**: 1.2% in 2024 (U.S. 5.5%; 30th of 51 states), down 0.9 points from 2.1% in 2023, and down 3.8 points since 2015 (5.0%).

NOTES

About These Data

International students

U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, as IPEDS defines them. IPEDS does not record country of citizenship. Permanent residents count with U.S. citizens.

STEM

CIP families 03, 04, 11, 14, 15, 26, 27 and 40. Doctorates are research and scholarship doctorates; professional doctorates appear only in the degree-count figure. Degrees are first majors only.

Universe

Degree-granting institutions located in the state; Title IV participants from 1996. Geography is the institution's location, not the student's home. Enrollment is fall headcount.

Migration

First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by home state, reported in even years before 2001 and every year since; odd years with incomplete reporting are omitted. Net migration is students arriving from other states minus residents leaving, per 100 resident first-time students.

Money

All dollar values are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. Appropriations and revenue are per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions.

Race and ethnicity

IPEDS did not collect race and ethnicity in every year before 2010, and categories changed in 2008–2010; “Two or more” exists only from then.

Countries of citizenship

From DHS SEVIS by the Numbers: active F-1 and M-1 student records in the month named, at every level from primary school to doctorate, by the state of the school. IPEDS records only whether a student is a U.S. nonresident, not where they come from. SEVIS counts are monthly snapshots and are not directly comparable with IPEDS fall enrollment or degree counts.

Peers

Comparison states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

Source

National Center for Education Statistics, Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS): Institutional Characteristics, Fall Enrollment, Completions, Graduation Rates, Finance, Human Resources and Admissions components, 1980–2025, harmonized into a state panel. Department of Homeland Security, SEVIS by the Numbers data mapping tool, 2014–2026. Generated November 2026.

This page intentionally left blank.

South Carolina – By the Numbers

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION							
Grade 8 mathematics, average score	276	**268**[2024]	−7.8 ▼	272	−9.0 ▼	#39	[5]
Grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient	26%	**24%**[2024]	−2.0 pp ▼	27%	−5.3 pp ▼	#35	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics, average score	237	**238**[2024]	+0.6 ▲	237	−2.5 ▼	#26	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics: at or above Proficient	36%	**40%**[2024]	+3.9 pp ▲	39%	0.0 pp	#23	[5]
Grade 8 reading, average score	260	**254**[2024]	−6.6 ▼	257	−7.3 ▼	#40	[5]
Grade 8 reading: at or above Proficient	28%	**26%**[2024]	−1.9 pp ▼	29%	−4.0 pp ▼	#36	[5]
Grade 4 reading, average score	218	**215**[2024]	−3.1 ▼	214	−7.1 ▼	#24	[5]
Grade 8 science, average score, 2009 framework	–	**151**[2015]	–	153	–	#31	[5]
Current spending per public-school pupil	$12.9K	**$14.3K**[2021]	+11% ▲	$16.8K	+12% ▲	#33	[3]
Public high school 4-year graduation rate, ACGR	80%	**84%**[2022]	+4.0 pp ▲	87%	+4.0 pp ▲	#33	[3]
Public high school graduates	43.6K	**52.1K**[2024]	+19% ▲	3.49M	+8.8% ▲	#23	[3]
Average public-school teacher salary	$63.4K	**$58.6K**[2022]	−7.6% ▼	$72.9K	−3.0% ▼	#44	[3]
Pupils per teacher, public schools	15.2	**14.1**[2022]	−1.1 ▼	15.4	−0.6 ▼	#27	[3]
Public elementary and secondary enrollment	764K	**797K**[2024]	+4.4% ▲	49.4M	−2.1% ▼	#23	[3]
Public-school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	56%	**70%**[2023]	+14.1 pp ▲	53%	+1.5 pp ▲	#4	[3]
English learners as a share of public-school students	5.7%	**5.8%**[2022]	+0.1 pp ▲	11%	+1.0 pp ▲	#34	[3]
Charter-school share of public-school enrollment	3.6%	**6.3%**[2023]	+2.7 pp ▲	7.6%	+2.2 pp ▲	#25	[3]
High schools offering calculus	67%[2016]	**56%**[2024]	−11.6 pp ▼	51%	−5.8 pp ▼	#19	[14]
High schools offering physics	72%[2016]	**61%**[2024]	−11.2 pp ▼	64%	−2.4 pp ▼	#30	[14]
High schools offering chemistry	89%[2016]	**93%**[2024]	+3.6 pp ▲	81%	+0.7 pp ▲	#9	[14]
High schools offering Algebra II	94%[2016]	**95%**[2024]	+1.2 pp ▲	87%	+1.3 pp ▲	#8	[14]
High schools offering computer science	84%[2021]	**79%**[2024]	−5.4 pp ▼	55%	+2.0 pp ▲	#8	[14]
High schools offering any AP course	74%[2016]	**63%**[2024]	−11.2 pp ▼	56%	0.0 pp	#23	[14]
High schools offering AP computer science	23%[2021]	**25%**[2024]	+1.6 pp ▲	25%	+2.6 pp ▲	#22	[14]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION (CONTINUED)							
High schools offering dual enrollment	83%[2016]	**85%[2024]**	+2.4 pp ▲	71%	+11.1 pp ▲	#10	[14]
AP course enrollments per 100 high-school students	12.9[2016]	**10.9[2024]**	−2.0 ▼	18.4	+1.0 ▲	#44	[14]
Calculus enrollments per 100 high-school students	3.1[2016]	**1.7[2024]**	−1.4 ▼	3.3	−1.0 ▼	#41	[14]
Physics enrollments per 100 high-school students	4.2[2016]	**3.2[2024]**	−1.0 ▼	9.4	−0.4 ▼	#44	[14]
SAT or ACT takers per 100 high-school students	26.9[2016]	**14.2[2024]**	−12.7 ▼	18.1	−2.5 ▼	#40	[14]
Students in gifted and talented programs per 100 students	15.6[2016]	**14.5[2024]**	−1.0 ▼	7.0	+0.4 ▲	#3	[14]
ENROLLMENT AND INSTITUTIONS							
Pell Grant share of undergraduates	42%	**36%[2025]**	−6.5 pp ▼	36%	−0.8 pp ▼	#19	[15]
Fall enrollment	250K	**256K[2024]**	+2.4% ▲	19.7M	−1.7% ▼	#26	[4]
Share of enrollment at public institutions	81%	**84%[2024]**	+2.5 pp ▲	73%	0.0 pp	#19	[4]
Share of enrollment at for-profit institutions	5.0%	**1.2%[2024]**	−3.8 pp ▼	5.5%	−1.2 pp ▼	#30	[4]
Share of students enrolled part-time	31%	**32%[2024]**	+0.9 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#41	[4]
Share of students who are graduate students	10%	**12%[2024]**	+1.7 pp ▲	17%	+2.0 pp ▲	#44	[4]
Share of students enrolled exclusively online	9.0%	**21%[2024]**	+11.9 pp ▲	27%	+12.1 pp ▲	#37	[4]
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY							
Research doctorates awarded	586	**580[2025]**	−1.0% ▼	59K	+7.3% ▲	#27	[7]
Science & engineering research doctorates, excluding health	432	**370[2025]**	−14% ▼	44.4K	+14% ▲	#29	[7]
Share of U.S. research doctorates	1.1%	**1.0%[2025]**	−0.1 pp ▼	100%	0.0 pp	#27	[7]
Engineering research doctorates	144	**113[2025]**	−22% ▼	10.9K	+9.9% ▲	#26	[7]
Mathematics & computer science research doctorates	44	**53[2025]**	+20% ▲	5.07K	+33% ▲	#24	[7]
STEM master's degrees per research doctorate	2.5	**3.8[2025]**	+1.3 ▲	6.4	+2.1 ▲	#39	[4]
STEM share of bachelor's	20%	**23%[2025]**	+2.9 pp ▲	24%	+5.3 pp ▲	#26	[4]
Share of bachelor's in computer & information sciences	2.4%	**4.2%[2025]**	+1.7 pp ▲	6.9%	+3.7 pp ▲	#36	[4]
Share of bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	5.3%	**6.2%[2025]**	+0.9 pp ▲	6.8%	+0.7 pp ▲	#28	[4]
Share of bachelor's in mathematics & statistics	1.0%	**0.7%[2025]**	−0.3 pp ▼	1.2%	0.0 pp	#33	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY (CONTINUED)							
Share of bachelor's in biological & biomedical sciences	9.2%	**9.3%**[2025]	+0.1 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#1	[4]
Share of bachelor's in physical sciences	1.6%	**1.2%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	1.3%	−0.3 pp ▼	#36	[4]
Share of bachelor's in health professions	8.5%	**10%**[2025]	+1.9 pp ▲	12%	+1.1 pp ▲	#34	[4]
Share of bachelor's in business	22%	**24%**[2025]	+1.9 pp ▲	19%	−0.1 pp ▼	#5	[4]
STEM share of master's	15%	**16%**[2025]	+0.8 pp ▲	23%	+6.7 pp ▲	#40	[4]
Share of master's in computer & information sciences	1.3%	**2.6%**[2025]	+1.3 pp ▲	10%	+6.3 pp ▲	#46	[4]
Share of master's in engineering & eng. technology	7.2%	**6.7%**[2025]	−0.6 pp ▼	6.7%	−0.2 pp ▼	#20	[4]
Share of master's in mathematics & statistics	1.0%	**0.4%**[2025]	−0.6 pp ▼	1.3%	+0.3 pp ▲	#44	[4]
Share of master's in biological & biomedical sciences	3.0%	**3.5%**[2025]	+0.5 pp ▲	2.5%	+0.6 pp ▲	#10	[4]
Share of master's in physical sciences	0.7%	**0.5%**[2025]	−0.3 pp ▼	0.8%	−0.1 pp ▼	#40	[4]
Share of master's in health professions	12%	**15%**[2025]	+2.2 pp ▲	15%	+1.7 pp ▲	#27	[4]
Share of master's in business	24%	**27%**[2025]	+2.7 pp ▲	21%	−3.2 pp ▼	#4	[4]
STEM share of research doctorates	41%	**25%**[2025]	−16.5 pp ▼	39%	−2.2 pp ▼	#46	[4]
Share of research doctorates in computer & information sciences	1.6%	**2.4%**[2025]	+0.8 pp ▲	4.2%	+1.4 pp ▲	#34	[4]
Share of research doctorates in engineering & eng. technology	18%	**9.9%**[2025]	−7.9 pp ▼	14%	−1.0 pp ▼	#36	[4]
Share of research doctorates in mathematics & statistics	2.3%	**2.2%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	2.4%	−0.2 pp ▼	#27	[4]
Share of research doctorates in biological & biomedical sciences	12%	**5.9%**[2025]	−6.5 pp ▼	10%	−1.1 pp ▼	#45	[4]
Share of research doctorates in physical sciences	6.0%	**3.9%**[2025]	−2.1 pp ▼	7.1%	−1.1 pp ▼	#46	[4]
Share of research doctorates in health professions	23%	**29%**[2025]	+6.1 pp ▲	12%	+3.5 pp ▲	#3	[4]
Share of research doctorates in business	1.7%	**8.9%**[2025]	+7.2 pp ▲	5.6%	+1.3 pp ▲	#10	[4]
Bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates	10.9	**12.6**[2025]	+1.7 ▲	12.3	+1.4 ▲	#26	[4]
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS							
First-time students from outside the U.S.	1.1%[2016]	**1.3%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	3.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#43	[4]
STEM master's degrees earned by international students	302	**462**[2025]	+53% ▲	117K	2.18× ▲	#35	[4]
Share of all U.S. international STEM master's degrees	0.6%	**0.4%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	100%	0.0 pp	#35	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
International share of undergraduate enrollment	1.1%	**1.2%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	3.0%	−0.3 pp ▼	#47	[4]
International share of graduate enrollment	10%	**10%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	17%	+2.8 pp ▲	#35	[4]
International share of all bachelor's	1.7%	**1.9%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	4.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#45	[4]
International share of STEM bachelor's	2.0%	**1.9%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#49	[4]
International share of all master's	9.1%	**12%**[2025]	+2.6 pp ▲	22%	+6.2 pp ▲	#34	[4]
International share of STEM master's	34%	**39%**[2025]	+4.9 pp ▲	52%	+9.1 pp ▲	#32	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences master's	51%	**66%**[2025]	+15.5 pp ▲	65%	+10.1 pp ▲	#21	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology master's	45%	**52%**[2025]	+7.0 pp ▲	50%	+0.9 pp ▲	#11	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics master's	44%	**23%**[2023]	−21.3 pp ▼	54%	+5.9 pp ▲	#34	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences master's	5.6%	**13%**[2025]	+7.6 pp ▲	23%	+6.2 pp ▲	#35	[4]
International share of physical sciences master's	20%	**25%**[2025]	+4.5 pp ▲	33%	+3.6 pp ▲	#30	[4]
International share of all research doctorates	25%	**17%**[2025]	−8.5 pp ▼	25%	−1.0 pp ▼	#41	[4]
International share of STEM research doctorates	47%	**41%**[2025]	−6.3 pp ▼	43%	−0.5 pp ▼	#27	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences research doctorates	–	**50%**[2025]	–	56%	–	#20	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology research doctorates	68%	**52%**[2025]	−16.2 pp ▼	55%	−1.0 pp ▼	#28	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics research doctorates	61%[2019]	**43%**[2024]	−18.0 pp ▼	52%	+0.8 pp ▲	#18	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences research doctorates	24%	**16%**[2025]	−8.1 pp ▼	23%	−4.3 pp ▼	#37	[4]
International share of physical sciences research doctorates	46%	**48%**[2025]	+1.8 pp ▲	38%	−1.1 pp ▼	#3	[4]
Active F-1/M-1 students, all levels	6.28K	**7.28K**[2026]	+16% ▲	1.19M	−0.1% ▼	#34	[20]
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.5%	**0.6%**[2026]	+0.1 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#34	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from India	14%	**29%**[2026]	+14.8 pp ▲	27%	+11.4 pp ▲	#15	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from China	28%	**10%**[2026]	−17.9 pp ▼	18%	−11.7 pp ▼	#29	[20]
Share from the two largest countries of origin	42%	**39%**[2026]	−3.0 pp ▼	45%	−0.3 pp ▼	#26	[20]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
Countries of citizenship represented	151	**158**[2026]	+4.6% ▲	219	−2.7% ▼	#33	[20]
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students	2.73K	**3.85K**[2026]	+41% ▲	749K	+61% ▲	#32	[20]
Active STEM master's students	943	**1.51K**[2026]	+60% ▲	393K	+90% ▲	#33	[20]
Active STEM doctoral students	1.18K	**1.55K**[2026]	+32% ▲	158K	+61% ▲	#28	[20]
Share of STEM master's students from India	61%	**65%**[2026]	+4.2 pp ▲	58%	−1.8 pp ▼	#16	[20]
U.S. students studying abroad for credit, from the state's institutions	6.31K[2017]	**6.47K**[2024]	+2.7% ▲	–	–	#17	[1]
Economic contribution of international students	$206M[2018]	**$207M**[2024]	+0.6% ▲	$42.9B	+4.6% ▲	#34	[2]
Jobs supported by international students' spending	2.07K[2018]	**1.49K**[2024]	−28% ▼	356K	−22% ▼	#32	[2]
Share of U.S. student and exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.5%	**0.5%**[2024]	0.0 pp	100%	0.0 pp	#29	[16]
Share of U.S. F-1 student admissions, by destination	0.3%	**0.4%**[2024]	0.0 pp	100%	0.0 pp	#35	[16]
Share of U.S. J-1 exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	1.0%	**1.0%**[2024]	0.0 pp	100%	0.0 pp	#24	[16]
J-1 exchange visitors starting a program in the state	5.68K	**4.75K**[2025]	−16% ▼	275K	−14% ▼	#20	[18]
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH							
Graduate students in science & engineering	4.88K	**4.69K**[2016]	−3.9% ▼	620K	+0.4% ▲	#32	[9]
S&E graduate students on temporary visas	1.88K	**1.79K**[2016]	−4.5% ▼	241K	+2.3% ▲	#31	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students	39%	**38%**[2016]	−0.3 pp ▼	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#18	[9]
Temporary-visa share of engineering graduate students	60%	**60%**[2016]	+0.5 pp ▲	57%	0.0 pp	#11	[9]
S&E postdoctoral appointees	284	**287**[2016]	+1.1% ▲	45.7K	+1.0% ▲	#30	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs	49%	**44%**[2016]	−4.7 pp ▼	56%	−0.9 pp ▼	#41	[9]
University R&D spending	$665M	**$990M**[2024]	+49% ▲	$118B	+71% ▲	#31	[6]
Share of U.S. university R&D	1.0%	**0.8%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	100%	0.0 pp	#31	[6]
Federally funded share of university R&D	43%	**52%**[2024]	+9.4 pp ▲	55%	−0.2 pp ▼	#29	[6]
Business-funded share of university R&D	6.5%	**6.5%**[2024]	0.0 pp	5.4%	−0.4 pp ▼	#7	[6]
State- and locally funded share of university R&D	5.1%	**5.9%**[2024]	+0.9 pp ▲	5.2%	−0.4 pp ▼	#23	[6]
University R&D in mathematics and computer science	$12.9M	**$28.2M**[2024]	2.19× ▲	$5.12B	+97% ▲	#32	[6]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH (CONTINUED)							
University R&D in engineering	$94.8M	**$182M**[2024]	+92% ▲	$19.3B	+74% ▲	#25	[6]
University R&D personnel, headcount	6.45K	**11K**[2024]	+70% ▲	1.09M	+20% ▲	#29	[6]
Federal R&D obligations to the state	$447M	**$2.56B**[2024]	5.73× ▲	$193B	+53% ▲	#21	[8]
Federal R&D obligations to universities in the state	$213M	**$378M**[2024]	+78% ▲	$44.4B	+64% ▲	#28	[8]
Defense R&D obligations to the state	$142M	**$1.43B**[2024]	10.13× ▲	$97.2B	+60% ▲	#15	[8]
Health (HHS/NIH) R&D obligations to the state	$159M	**$867M**[2024]	5.45× ▲	$48.5B	+62% ▲	#14	[8]
NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science grants performed in the state	$207M	**$318M**[2025]	+54% ▲	$45B	+47% ▲	#29	[19]
Federal R&D contracts performed in the state	$47.2M	**$827M**[2026]	17.51× ▲	$59.3B	+59% ▲	#16	[19]
COLLEGE COSTS AND OUTCOMES							
Median earnings 10 years after entering college	$43K[2020]	**$44K**[2022]	+2.4% ▲	$47.5K	+11% ▲	#38	[15]
Median earnings 1 year after completing	–	**$45.2K**[2025]	–	$47.5K	–	#41	[15]
Median debt of completers	$21.5K	**$20.5K**[2024]	−4.7% ▼	$17.6K	−4.6% ▼	#10	[15]
STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$62.5K**[2025]	–	$68.2K	–	#41	[15]
Non-STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$48.1K**[2025]	–	$51.9K	–	#35	[15]
Bachelor's graduates: median earnings 5 years out	–	**$65.7K**[2025]	–	$68.1K	–	#30	[15]
STEM master's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$86.6K**[2025]	–	$91.6K	–	#25	[15]
Six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions	57%	**62%**[2024]	+5.8 pp ▲	65%	+5.3 pp ▲	#24	[4]
Completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions	16%	**34%**[2024]	+18.2 pp ▲	41%	+12.1 pp ▲	#35	[4]
In-state tuition & fees, public 4-year	$15.7K	**$12.8K**[2023]	−18% ▼	$9.71K	−14% ▼	#12	[4]
State & local appropriations per FTE, public institutions	$5.33K	**$9.11K**[2024]	+71% ▲	$11.4K	+22% ▲	#38	[4]
Tuition share of core revenue, public institutions	70%	**57%**[2024]	−12.9 pp ▼	43%	−5.9 pp ▼	#11	[4]
Average full-time faculty salary (9/10-month)	$90.7K[2016]	**$83.9K**[2024]	−7.5% ▼	$106K	−4.6% ▼	#40	[4]
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO							
International graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied	28%	**32%**[2016]	+4.4 pp ▲	44%	−1.8 pp ▼	#31	[21]
OPT retention, bachelor's graduates	33%	**43%**[2016]	+9.3 pp ▲	58%	+0.3 pp ▲	#28	[21]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
OPT retention, master's graduates	26%	**26%**[2016]	+0.5 pp ▲	39%	−2.5 pp ▼	#33	[21]
OPT retention, STEM graduates	23%	**31%**[2016]	+7.7 pp ▲	37%	−1.9 pp ▼	#24	[21]
OPT workers employed in the state per OPT graduate of its schools	0.63	**0.66**[2016]	0.0	1.00	0.0	#35	[21]
STEM OPT extensions approved, by state of the school	234	**218**[2016]	−6.8% ▼	41.2K	+51% ▲	#32	[21]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating (PSEO)	57%[2016]	**56%**[2019]	−1.2 pp ▼	72%	−0.1 pp ▼	#26	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 5 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**49%**[2016]	–	65%	–	#29	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 10 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**50%**[2010]	–	64%	–	#29	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	53%[2016]	**54%**[2019]	+1.1 pp ▲	67%	+1.5 pp ▲	#24	[11]
Master's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**61%**[2016]	–	66%	–	#21	[11]
Doctoral graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**49%**[2016]	–	49%	–	#17	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$42.3K[2016]	**$44K**[2019]	+4.0% ▲	$48.1K	+2.3% ▲	#27	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 5 years out (PSEO)	–	**$61.7K**[2016]	–	$67.3K	–	#28	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$51.9K[2016]	**$53.1K**[2019]	+2.2% ▲	$59.3K	+0.1% ▲	#28	[11]
Net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents	+13.3	**+17.4**[2025]	+4.1 ▲	–	–	#1	[12]
Net domestic migration of graduate-degree holders	+5.55K	**+9.73K**[2025]	+75% ▲	–	–	#2	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved in from another state	4.7%	**4.4%**[2025]	−0.3 pp ▼	–	–	#4	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved out to another state	3.3%	**2.7%**[2025]	−0.7 pp ▼	–	–	#27	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who arrived from abroad in the past year	6K	**7.71K**[2025]	+28% ▲	–	–	#20	[12]
First-time students who are in-state residents	76%[2016]	**72%**[2024]	−4.1 pp ▼	–	–	#27	[4]
Net student migration (per 100 resident first-time students)	+13[2016]	**+14**[2024]	+0.8 ▲	–	–	#19	[4]
Recent high school graduates who go to college out of state	11%[2016]	**15%**[2022]	+3.8 pp ▲	22%	+2.5 pp ▲	#38	[3]
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS							
Certified H-1B positions, by worksite	5.3K	**3.41K**[2025]	−36% ▼	914K	−24% ▼	#28	[17]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Share of U.S. certified H-1B positions	0.4%	**0.4%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	100%	0.0 pp	#28	[17]
STEM share of certified H-1B positions	86%	**67%**[2025]	−19.5 pp ▼	76%	−7.8 pp ▼	#26	[17]
Median offered H-1B wage, nominal dollars	$63K	**$95K**[2025]	+51% ▲	$119K	+66% ▲	#34	[17]
H-1B positions at H-1B-dependent employers	62%	**25%**[2025]	−36.7 pp ▼	22%	−25.7 pp ▼	#14	[17]
Green-card labor certifications	714	**909**[2025]	+27% ▲	138K	+75% ▲	#26	[17]
Share of PERM certifications for citizens of India	9.7%	**18%**[2024]	+7.9 pp ▲	47%	−10.6 pp ▼	#42	[17]
PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas	8.5%	**20%**[2024]	+11.2 pp ▲	8.7%	+4.9 pp ▲	#5	[17]
PERM workers with a master's or doctorate	15%	**22%**[2024]	+7.7 pp ▲	47%	−4.9 pp ▼	#38	[17]
STEM share of PERM certifications	9.0%	**25%**[2025]	+15.8 pp ▲	49%	−25.8 pp ▼	#36	[17]
Median offered PERM wage, nominal dollars	$16.8K	**$42.5K**[2025]	2.52× ▲	$100K	+9.9% ▲	#41	[17]
New lawful permanent residents (green cards), by state of residence	4.42K	**7.95K**[2024]	+80% ▲	1.36M	+30% ▲	#27	[16]
Share of U.S. new green-card holders	0.4%	**0.6%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#27	[16]
People naturalized as U.S. citizens, by state of residence	4.61K	**7.87K**[2024]	+71% ▲	819K	+12% ▲	#21	[16]
Share of U.S. naturalizations	0.6%	**1.0%**[2024]	+0.3 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#21	[16]
Share of U.S. temporary-worker admissions, by destination	0.5%	**0.6%**[2024]	0.0 pp	100%	0.0 pp	#21	[16]
Share of U.S. H-1B worker admissions, by destination	0.3%	**0.4%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#27	[16]
Share of U.S. L-1 intracompany-transferee admissions, by destination	0.7%	**0.9%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#19	[16]
Share of U.S. O-1 extraordinary-ability worker admissions, by destination	0.1%	**0.2%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#32	[16]
New H-1B approvals (initial), by employer state	282	**648**[2026]	2.30× ▲	127K	+14% ▲	#25	[13]
Continuing H-1B approvals, by employer state	386	**1.02K**[2026]	2.64× ▲	268K	+52% ▲	#27	[13]
Share of U.S. new H-1B approvals	0.3%	**0.5%**[2026]	+0.3 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#25	[13]
Denial rate, new H-1B petitions	3.4%	**4.4%**[2026]	+1.0 pp ▲	3.4%	−3.0 pp ▼	#12	[13]
New H-1B approvals at colleges and schools (NAICS 61)	41%	**27%**[2026]	−14.6 pp ▼	8.6%	−1.7 pp ▼	#17	[13]
New H-1B approvals in professional, scientific & technical services	11%	**22%**[2026]	+11.6 pp ▲	44%	−12.5 pp ▼	#35	[13]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH CAROLINA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Five largest employers' share of new H-1B approvals	35%	**19%**[2026]	−15.5 pp ▼	9.1%	−6.7 pp ▼	#44	[13]
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION							
Workers in STEM occupations	98.6K	**176K**[2024]	+79% ▲	13.7M	+51% ▲	#24	[12]
STEM workers as a share of all workers	4.5%	**6.7%**[2024]	+2.2 pp ▲	8.1%	+2.1 pp ▲	#32	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers	12%	**12%**[2024]	+0.9 pp ▲	24%	+1.6 pp ▲	#29	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a graduate degree	22%	**25%**[2024]	+3.6 pp ▲	41%	+2.2 pp ▲	#28	[12]
Noncitizen share of STEM workers	6.8%	**6.0%**[2024]	−0.8 pp ▼	11%	+0.7 pp ▲	#33	[12]
STEM workers born abroad who arrived in the last 10 years	4.6%	**4.8%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	7.5%	+0.3 pp ▲	#24	[12]
Share of foreign-born STEM workers born in India	23%[2018]	**29%**[2024]	+6.4 pp ▲	28%	−0.5 pp ▼	#16	[12]
Foreign-born share of residents	4.8%	**6.6%**[2025]	+1.9 pp ▲	15%	+1.3 pp ▲	#33	[12]
Foreign-born share of graduate-degree holders, 25+	7.4%	**9.7%**[2025]	+2.4 pp ▲	21%	+2.8 pp ▲	#37	[12]
STEM jobs, employer survey	87.2K	**129K**[2025]	+48% ▲	10.4M	+26% ▲	#26	[10]
STEM jobs concentration vs the U.S., location quotient	0.76	**0.84**[2025]	+0.1 ▲	1.00	0.0	#33	[10]
Mean annual STEM wage, nominal	$73.9K	**$103K**[2025]	+40% ▲	$120K	+38% ▲	#30	[10]
Median software developer wage, nominal	$86K[2019]	**$129K**[2025]	+51% ▲	$136K	+26% ▲	#23	[10]
Software developer jobs	5.6K	**13.2K**[2025]	2.36× ▲	1.69M	+48% ▲	#28	[10]
Mean annual wage, all occupations, nominal	$40.6K	**$59.3K**[2025]	+46% ▲	$69.8K	+44% ▲	#43	[10]
Patents granted to assignees in the state	445	**669**[2025]	+51% ▲	135K	−0.6% ▼	#30	[22]
Share of U.S.-assignee patents	0.3%	**0.5%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	100%	0.0 pp	#30	[22]
Share of the state's patents in digital technologies	19%	**9.0%**[2025]	−10.4 pp ▼	43%	+1.6 pp ▲	#45	[22]
Share of the state's patents in life sciences	13%	**10%**[2025]	−2.4 pp ▼	17%	+0.4 pp ▲	#41	[22]
Share of the state's patents in semiconductors	5.1%	**0.3%**[2025]	−4.8 pp ▼	2.9%	−1.7 pp ▼	#38	[22]
Women's share of inventors on the state's patents	7.3%	**12%**[2025]	+4.4 pp ▲	14%	+3.4 pp ▲	#24	[22]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

Sources

[1] Institute of International Education. *Open Doors Report on International Educational Exchange: State Fact Sheets*. Editions 2020–2026. New York: Institute of International Education. https://opendoorsdata.org/. Accessed November 2026.

[2] NAFSA: Association of International Educators. *NAFSA International Student Economic Value Tool*. Academic years 2018–19 to 2024–25. Washington, DC: NAFSA. https://www.nafsa.org/isev. Accessed November 2026.

[3] National Center for Education Statistics. *Digest of Education Statistics*. Editions 1995–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/. Accessed November 2026.

[4] National Center for Education Statistics. *Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS)*. Survey files, 1980–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/ipeds/. Accessed November 2026.

[5] National Center for Education Statistics. *National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP)*. NAEP Data Service, 1990–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://www.nationsreportcard.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[6] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Higher Education Research and Development Survey*. Data tables, FY2003–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/higher-education-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[7] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Earned Doctorates*. Data tables, 1994–2025. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/earned-doctorates. Accessed November 2026.

[8] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Federal Funds for Research and Development*. Data tables, FY1985–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/federal-funds-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[9] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates in Science and Engineering*. Data tables, 1994–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/graduate-students-postdoctorates-s-e. Accessed November 2026.

[10] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. *Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics*. State estimates, 1999–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.bls.gov/oes/. Accessed November 2026.

[11] U.S. Census Bureau, Center for Economic Studies. *Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes (PSEO)*. Release R2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://lehd.ces.census.gov/data/pseo_experimental.html. Accessed November 2026.

[12] U.S. Census Bureau. *American Community Survey*. 1-year estimates and Public Use Microdata Sample, 2010–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://data.census.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[13] U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services. *H-1B Employer Data Hub*. Fiscal years 2009–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.uscis.gov/tools/reports-and-studies/h-1b-employer-data-hub. Accessed November 2026.

[14] U.S. Department of Education, Office for Civil Rights. *Civil Rights Data Collection*. School years 1980–81 to 2023–24. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://civilrightsdata.ed.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[15] U.S. Department of Education. *College Scorecard*. Institution and field-of-study data, 1996–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://collegescorecard.ed.gov/data/. Accessed November 2026.

[16] U.S. Department of Homeland Security, Office of Homeland Security Statistics. *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics*. Fiscal years 1996–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://ohss.dhs.gov/topics/immigration/yearbook. Accessed November 2026.

[17] U.S. Department of Labor, Employment and Training Administration, Office of Foreign Labor Certification. *LCA and PERM Disclosure Data*. Fiscal years 2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.dol.gov/agencies/eta/foreign-labor/performance. Accessed November 2026.

[18] U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs. *BridgeUSA: Exchange Visitor Program Participants by State*. 2015–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of State. https://j1visa.state.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[19] U.S. Department of the Treasury, Bureau of the Fiscal Service. *USAspending.gov*. Award data, FY2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of the Treasury. https://www.usaspending.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[20] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, Student and Exchange Visitor Program. *SEVIS by the Numbers: Data Mapping Tool*. Monthly data, 2014–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/sevis-data-mapping-tool. Accessed November 2026.

[21] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement. *Student and Exchange Visitor Information System (SEVIS) Data*. Freedom of Information Act releases, 2008–2016. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.ice.gov/foia/library. Accessed November 2026.

[22] U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. *PatentsView*. Annualized patent data, grant years 1976–2025. Alexandria, VA: U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. https://patentsview.org/. Accessed November 2026.